



RUTHLESS
ARRANGEMENTS

Forbidden
VOW

A FORBIDDEN MAFIA ROMANCE

LILITH VINCENT

FORBIDDEN VOW

A FORBIDDEN MAFIA ROMANCE

RUTHLESS ARRANGEMENTS BOOK 2

LILITH VINCENT

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FORBIDDEN VOW (A FORBIDDEN MAFIA ROMANCE)

Lilith Vincent

Lucy is the only woman I love. The only heart I cherish. But she can never be mine.

Life is danger, and life is pain. I learned that lesson at twelve years of age when my father and sister perished in flames. Lucy and I were the only survivors, she an abandoned little girl with pain in her eyes, tears on her cheeks, and steel in her heart.

I couldn't lose her, so I lied about who we were, without knowing the terrible price we'd pay. Lucy and I became Barones, children of one of the wealthiest and most sinister families in Malus. I love Lucy more than anyone in the world, but I led her unwittingly into danger.

Our new family treads a dark and violent path, strewn with bullets and blood. Our true identity is a deadly secret. To protect my beautiful Lucy, I must walk the same path as our parents. To save her from a violent fate, I must arrange her marriage to someone else.

But seeing Lucy with another man's ring on her finger unlocks feral instincts inside me. My desire for her is going to tear our lives apart,

because I'm about to do something dangerous, reckless, and utterly forbidden.

I'm going to make Lucy mine.

Author's Note: Forbidden Vow is a forbidden MF romance with dark themes, a jealous, overprotective, obsessed hero, and a sweet, clever virgin heroine. This is the second book in the Ruthless Arrangements series of arranged marriage mafia romances and can be read as a standalone. The story is dirty and delicious, so please read at your discretion.

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WELCOME TO MALUS

The city of Malus.

Proud and deadly mafia families locked in a struggle for power.

Protect your heart.

Love is ruthless.



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AUTHOR'S NOTE

I've wanted to write a sibling-adjacent story for years. I've dabbled in a few ideas, writing scenes and sketching plots, but I couldn't decide on the brother and sister story that I wanted to write first. Then François Arnaud's sexy, sweet, horny, and badass portrayal of sister-obsessed Cesare Borgia in *The Borgias* altered my brain chemistry. Violent *and* sweet? Devoted *and* murderous? Delicious. I fell hard. (And have you seen him as Scott in *Heated Rivalry*? This man knows how to *yearn*.)

This story is The One. Damiano Barone is everything I crave in an overly protective, dangerous, and gorgeous big brother. He's the epitome of *only soft for her*, and Lucy is his weakness, his strength, and his obsession. The rags-to-riches plotline and the wealthy but cold adoptive parents are inspired by all the V.C. Andrews novels I inhaled as a teenager.

There's no shared blood between Damiano and Lucy, but they grew up together from the ages of ten and twelve, and they are posing as full blood siblings for reasons that you're about to find out.

Pronunciation note: Damiano Barone is *da-mi-AH-no bah-RO-nay*.

Content note: this book contains violence and attempted rape of the heroine by a side character.

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Lucy

Ten years ago

The rumble of a car engine and tires crunching over gravel pierce the heavy silence. I sit up quickly and peer over the hood of a dented brown Chrysler. A truck is coming up the weed-lined driveway toward me with a man at the wheel. This is the third vehicle today to approach the run-down weatherboard house with its yard full of overgrown grass, rusting farm equipment, and old tires. Each time I hear the throb of an engine, the knots in my growling, empty stomach tighten, and hope flares in my heart.

I don't recognize the vehicle.

My heart sinks, and I sit back down in the dirt.

I once saw a skinny white dog at a gas station, trembling in the parking lot with her tail tucked between her legs. When a car approached, she would lift her head eagerly, and her tail would start to wag, but when she saw who got out of the vehicles, the light would go out of her eyes, and she would sink back into her terrified crouch. When Mom came back from paying for the gas, I asked her why the dog kept doing that. She stared at the pitiful animal for a moment, then started the car and drove away. I kept pestering

Mom to answer, and she finally snapped, "Because no one wants her. The owners threw that dog out of their car, and the dog is too stupid to know that they're never coming back." My heart broke for the animal, who was confused and frightened and all alone in the world. I begged Mom to go back so we could rescue the abandoned dog and make it feel loved again, but she told me to shut up and kept driving, and I cried all the way home.

Right now, I don't feel like Lucy Cinders, ten years old, pretty good playing the flute and multiplying fractions, but too small to be good at sports or shoving people back on the playground when they shove me first. I am that skinny white dog, waiting for someone who's never coming back.

I listen to the car coming to a halt behind the three beaters that are parked beside the house. When I peer around the wheels, I see a tall, lanky man getting out of the driver's seat.

"You two stay in the car. I'll be right back," the man mutters. He has dull skin and shadows beneath his hollow eyes. It's the same look Mom gets before she disappears for days.

The man goes inside the house, the screen door slamming behind him. The truck door opens, and a girl about my age, ten or so, clambers out, her lower lip jutting.

A moment later, another passenger gets out. It's a boy who looks a few years older than the girl and must be her brother. He's tall and nice-looking, with dark eyes and curly hair, wearing faded jeans and a dark T-shirt. He moves around the truck and takes his sister's hand with a protectiveness that makes my chest ache.

The girl moves toward the house, but the boy tightens his grip and stands firm.

"I want Dad," she complains.

"You can't go in there, Lil." The boy sounds angry, but not with his sister. His thumb rubs her hand comfortingly, and I feel a sharp stab of envy.

"Let's go for a walk," he mutters, and turns toward where I'm hiding.

I duck back out of sight, making myself as small as possible with my arms wrapped around my knees. As the boy and girl pass by, he sees me out of the corner of his eye. He stops in his tracks and stares.

When I meet his brown eyes, his surprise shifts into understanding. He knows exactly what it means to be crouched in the dirt beside a drug house. He glances toward the house, and then back at me.

“Are you waiting for your mom or dad?”

He thinks Mom’s inside with the other grown-ups who are taking drugs. I’m too ashamed to tell him that she got what she needed in that house a long time ago.

Then she drove off and left me here.

When I don’t answer, he says, “You shouldn’t wait there. Come with us into the backyard.”

My arms tighten around my knees. This place is terrifying, and the terror only grows worse if I’m not right here, waiting for Mom. She will come back. She *has* to. Though with every cold, lonely hour that passes, that seems less and less likely.

“I want Dad,” the girl whines.

The boy’s grip on his sister’s hand is so tight that his knuckles are white, and his dark eyes are hard and angry. He takes a small, calming breath before he says with forced cheerfulness to his sister, “Do you remember the creek down past those trees? Let’s go look for fish.”

The distraction works. His sister’s face brightens.

The boy turns and offers me the same smile, but I can tell he doesn’t mean it. Whatever’s eating at him—whatever he’s hiding from his sister—is crushing him. He hates being here as much as I do.

“Come with us. You’ll like the creek.”

“I’m staying here,” I tell them.

“Why?” the girl asks in a snotty tone, impatient to get to the creek now that her brother has tempted her with it.

“None of your business.” I look away and hug my knees tighter.

“Whatever.” The girl pulls out of her brother’s grip and races across the backyard.

“Don’t go in the water,” he shouts after her.

We hear her fading voice call back to us, “I won’t.”

The boy comes toward me and hunkers down on his heels. I automatically flinch backward.

“I’m Damiano. What’s your name?”

Close up, the boy is even more good-looking than at first glance. He has thick lashes and beautiful dark brows. His jaw is defined and will become even more so as he grows. His voice is already deeper than the boys my age. But it’s his eyes that entrance me. They’re bleak, and too wise for his age.

I look at him warily, and then finally answer, “Lucy.”

“You know what this place is, don’t you? That’s why you’re so scared.”

I nod.

He glances toward the creek where his sister is. “My sister doesn’t know. I lied to her. She thinks Dad is in there helping people. But I, um...” He swallows, and for a moment, his kind expression cracks. He looks desperately unhappy, like he’s carrying a weight too heavy for someone so young. “I don’t know how much longer I’m going to be able to keep the lie going.”

Despite my own misery, something in my chest twists for him. We’re both alone, just in different ways.

“Come down to the stream with me and Lily. We’ll see if we can catch a fish.” He uses the same forced cheery tone that worked on his sister, but it doesn’t work on me.

Damiano drops the smile. “Listen. I’ll tell you the truth. You can’t sit here. It’s not safe. You smell that?”

A chemical scent hangs in the air. I’ve noticed it getting stronger throughout the day, seeping into my clothes and hair.

“They’re not just selling here. They’re cooking.”

“Does that mean making drugs?” I ask.

“Yes, and the ingredients are horrible chemicals that will make you sick.” Damiano stands up and holds out his hand to me. The defiant expression in his eyes tells me he’s not going anywhere until I agree to go with him.

I stare at his outstretched hand. Two days I’ve been alone. Two days of stealing stale bread and lukewarm water from the kitchen when the scary people weren’t looking. Two days of making myself invisible. And now this boy—this stranger—is offering his hand to me like I matter.

I put my hand in his, and he helps me to my feet. I expect him to drop my hand as we cross the grass toward the creek, but he holds it firmly. After being cold, alone, and scared for so long, the warmth of his fingers feels like he’s scooped me up in a hug. The frightening house melts away. Everything melts away. I’m only aware of the tall boy walking beside me, keeping me grounded.

Keeping me safe.

We reach the creek and our shoes touch stones that have been smoothed by the water. I want to go on holding Damiano’s hand. Actually, what I

really want is to bury my face in the front of his T-shirt and sob while he holds me, but weakness makes people irritated with you, or it makes them want to hurt you.

I drop Damiano's hand and pretend to be interested in the water. Lily has picked up a stick to poke some water weeds.

"Lucy is going to help us fish," Damiano tells her.

Lily looks me over with a critical scowl. "Your hair is curly, like mine and my brother's, but yours is blonde."

I don't know what to say to that.

"Our dad is a paramedic," she boasts. "He comes here to help people, and we have to wait."

Damiano shoves his hands in his pockets, his jaw tight. The lie is costing him something.

"What are you doing here?" Lily asks me.

"I'm waiting for my mom."

My answer seems to bore her, and the girl wanders along the creek away from us.

Damiano steps closer to me. "How long has your mom been inside?"

He told me the truth about why I can't sit by the house. I should tell him the truth too. "She's not inside."

He frowns at me, not understanding.

"A fish, a fish!" Lily screams, beating the surface of the water with her stick and no doubt scaring away any fish that might have been there.

Damiano calls out to her, "That's close enough, Lily. The water is deep there." When he's satisfied she's stepped back, he turns back to me. "If she's not inside, where is your mom?"

I open my mouth, but no words come out. I've been asking myself that question for two days.

"I'm bored. I want Dad." Lily drops her stick and dashes across the grass toward the house.

"Lily, don't." Damiano reaches for her, but it's too late, and she slips away from him. As she flees, he shouts after her, "Don't go in that house."

Lily was about to reach for the handle on the back door, but she changes her mind and starts knocking instead.

He sighs and turns back to me. "Sorry. Where's your mom?"

"I don't know. She was in the house, and I was out here. I heard the car start, but when I ran over to it, she turned onto the street and drove away." I

can still see it—the red taillights disappearing around the corner while I screamed for her. I ran until my lungs burned and my legs gave out, and then I sat in the middle of the empty road and cried until I couldn't cry anymore.

“You mean she drove off and left you here?” Damiano’s expression is full of disbelief. “I’m so sorry, Lucy. Do you know her phone number? When Dad comes out, I’ll borrow his phone, and we can call her.”

I shake my head. I don’t know her number. She changed it recently and I haven’t got the new one memorized.

“Then I guess we’ll have to call the police,” he says, with the grimace of someone who has learned to dislike cops. I wonder if seeing a police car makes his dad’s hands clench on the steering wheel like it does my mom. Maybe like Mom, Damiano’s father fearfully twitches aside the curtains to see who’s knocking on the front door.

“If Dad lets me,” he mutters, kicking a rock. “I’ll have to call where he can’t hear me.”

“I don’t want you to get into trouble because of me.”

He looks at me from beneath his lashes and smiles—a little cocky, a little sweet. It’s the first real smile I’ve seen from him, and it makes warmth bloom in my chest. “Don’t worry about me. I’ll be fine.”

I find myself smiling back at him. For the first time in two days, I don’t feel quite so alone.

He smiles wider, and then laughs, turning toward the house. “Come on, let’s go and get Lily before she—”

But Damiano’s words die in his throat. Lily is disappearing inside the house, the door closing behind her.

Damiano’s face drains of color. He takes one lurching step forward, then another. “Lily, come back out here.”

The world explodes.

A deafening roar tears the air apart. The house erupts in a ball of fire and light so bright it’s like the sun has crashed to earth. The force of the blast hits me like a physical thing, knocking the air from my lungs.

Damiano breaks into a run, his legs pumping as he races toward the house. “Lily!” he screams. “LILY!”

Damiano’s scream cuts off. I can hear more screaming from inside the house.

Heat washes over me in waves. Glass and metal rain down around us, glinting in the firelight. Something hot slices the right side of my head, a burning agony that makes white spots dance across my vision. Wet warmth streams down my neck and into my collar.

My knees buckle.

The world tilts sideways and goes dark.



SOUND RETURNS FIRST, a high-pitched ringing that drowns out everything else. Then someone calling my name, over and over, desperate and broken.

“Lucy. Lucy. *Lucy.*”

Hands on me, gentle but shaking. Something soft being wound around my head—fabric, I think, but my thoughts are sluggish and confused.

“You’re okay, you’re okay, Lucy.”

I force my eyes open. My vision is blurry. Above me, Damiano’s face swims into focus.

He’s covered in soot and ash. His eyes are too wide, too bright. His hands shake as he wraps torn fabric around my head.

“You’re okay,” he keeps saying, but his voice cracks. “You’re okay.”

He gathers me up in his arms. He smells like singed fabric, smoke, and chemicals. His heart is racing so hard I can feel it against my cheek.

No one’s screaming anymore.

No one’s coming out of that burning house.

I can feel his head turning, searching. For help, maybe. For his sister, though we both know she’s gone. Everyone in that house is dead. His dad. His sister. All those scary people with strange eyes.

If it wasn’t for Damiano, I’d be dead too. I was sitting right next to those cars, and now they’re burning.

There are neighbors’ houses dotted around this place at a distance. No one comes to help us, but someone must have heard the explosion or seen the smoke, because eventually we hear sirens approaching.

Damiano picks me up in his arms and carries me out to the road. I wipe my eyes, look around, and see that the whole house is ablaze.

The firemen run past with hoses and other equipment, stopping long enough to ask us how many people are inside. Damiano pleads for them to

help me, but the firemen don't do much for us except wrap us in shiny metallic blankets and sit us on the curb to wait for the ambulance.

I hear the words *meth lab explosion* from the firemen in tones of disgust. There are a few glances in our direction that are pitying, but most are unfriendly. They hate meth labs, and we were playing in the backyard, so we must be bad kids.

The ambulance arrives, and I'm put onto a stretcher and loaded inside. As the ambulance sets off, I'm suddenly sick with fear that I'm all alone with strangers who are poking and prodding me, and I cry out, "Damiano?"

There's a reassuring squeeze of my shoulder. "I'm here."

His voice is rough, scraped raw. But he's here. He didn't leave me.

At the hospital, I know Damiano is nearby, because I hear him defiantly say, "I'm staying with her," several times, and asking different people if I'm going to be all right.

They stick a needle in my hand. The pain in my head fades, and I think I must fall asleep.

I wake up sometime later, blinking slowly and able to see again. My face feels clean. There's a curtain around my hospital bed. Next to me in an uncomfortable-looking chair with his head pillowed on his arm is Damiano.

He must hear me moving because his eyelashes flutter, and he sits up. There are bandages on his hands and forearms, and ash streaked through his dark curls.

"Damiano, what happened to you?"

He glances at the bandages as if he'd forgotten they're there. "It's just some burns. Don't worry about me. How are you feeling?" He scoots closer to the bed and reaches for my hand.

My head is fuzzy and my mouth is dry. I put my other hand up to touch something stiff in my curls. It feels like gauze. "What happened to me?"

"Burning metal from the explosion. It cut your head, and they stitched you up. You're dehydrated so they put you on a drip."

"Why doesn't my head hurt? I feel strange."

"They gave you something to stop the pain."

I glance around, looking for a clock. "What time is it?"

"About nine in the morning."

"The morning! Where did you sleep?"

Damiano looks exhausted, his face gray beneath the soot, but he smiles. "Right here. You were never alone."

My head falls back on the pillow, and tears swim in my eyes. Never alone. Two of the sweetest words I've ever heard. It means so much to me that he never left my side.

"Your sister..." I whisper. "I'm so sorry."

He puts his head down on the bed. His hands clench on the blanket so hard his knuckles turn white. When he speaks, his voice is barely a whisper. "I tried to go into the house and save her, but the fire was too hot. I shouldn't have let her leave the creek."

"It's all my fault," I tell him, my voice cracking. I distracted him from looking after her by being too grateful for his attention. Too needy for his kindness. The grief in his eyes is unbearable, and I put it there.

Damiano sits up fast, swipes tears from his cheeks, and says fiercely, "It's Dad's fault for bringing us there. Did you see the place where you were sitting after the explosion? The car was on fire. You would have died as well, which is your mom's fault for leaving you there. You and my sister could both be dead. The only good thing that's happened is that I saved you, and I don't ever want to hear you say that any of this is your fault."

Anger blazes in Damiano's eyes. He's seeing that burning house all over again. Reliving those terrifying moments. His breath is coming faster and faster.

I reach out and touch his cheek, stroking my fingers over his jaw. He covers my hand with his and leans gratefully into my touch. His breathing slows. His eyes close.

"You were bleeding so much," he whispers. "I was so scared for you. I couldn't save Lily, but I'm so grateful you're alive."

There's the sound of brisk footsteps approaching my bed, and a woman dressed in street clothes peers around the curtain. She introduces herself as Ms. Mills from Child Protective Services. Her blouse has a loud floral print, and she wears a navy skirt. She smiles at us, but her smile looks pinned on.

"You two are from the explosion yesterday? We're going to do some paperwork, and then I'll take you to a residential facility for children. Just for a little while. It's a very nice place."

Her expression flickers as she says *very nice place*. She's lying.

"This will be while we locate some family for you both, and they'll come and collect you." She's about to take a seat on the other side of my bed when her phone rings, and she checks the screen. "I'll be back in one moment."

We watch her step outside the curtain and take her call.

“What’s going to happen to us?” I ask Damiano. My heart is starting to race, panic rising in my throat.

Damiano reaches for my hand again and strokes my knuckles with his thumb. “Your mom will come and get you.”

Maybe it’s the drugs, or maybe it’s Damiano holding my hand and being so kind to me, but I no longer have the strength to swallow down the words that are begging to be screamed out loud.

“Mom’s not coming for me,” I say brokenly, tears filling my eyes. “Even if she does, she’ll just leave me behind again. This isn’t the first time she’s driven off and left me.”

Damiano’s hand clenches on mine, and his mouth drops open in outrage. “She leaves you behind on purpose?”

Shame floods me from head to toe. Other parents are frantic when they lose sight of their children for even a second. There must be something horribly wrong with me because Mom enjoys leaving me behind.

“She does it to punish me when I’m too clingy, and she’s threatened a couple of times that one day she’ll never come back.”

Damiano’s eyes search mine. His thumb strokes the back of my hand so hard it almost hurts. “Lucy. How long were you alone at that house?”

I don’t want to admit it, but Damiano’s looking at me so intently with those beautiful brown eyes that I know I can’t lie to him. “Two days. I crept into the house and stole some stale bread from the kitchen when I got hungry, and to use the bathroom. The people were so scary, and their eyes were weird, but nobody really noticed me.”

For a moment, Damiano just stares at me. Then his face twists with an emotion I can’t name, somewhere between rage and pain.

“Do you have any other family? Aunts, uncles, grandparents, godparents?”

I shake my head. “If I had family, I think Mom would have left me with them long ago. I don’t have anyone.”

He’s silent for a long time, staring at my hand in his. When he speaks, his voice is barely audible. “I don’t have any family either.”

So we’re both completely alone.

Heavy silence fills the curtained space. Outside, machines beep. People talk in low voices. The world keeps moving, but inside this little bubble, time has come to a miserable stop.

The child protection worker's voice floats into the room. "So one of them over at Egret and the other at Milbray? If that's all that's available, then it will have to do. I'll take the boy to Egret now, and the girl over to Milbray when she's discharged. Okay. Yes, I'll be back in the office soon. Save me some of that birthday cake." She ends the phone call with a cheery laugh and tells her coworker goodbye.

I meet Damiano's stare.

Different facilities.

We'll never see each other again.

My heart pounds so hard I can hear it in my ears. After everything that's happened in the last few days, it's this that threatens to shatter me completely. I'm going to be alone again. This boy who held my hand and saved my life and sat by my hospital bed all night is going to disappear like everyone else.

Damiano's face has gone very still. Very pale. His eyes are fixed on the curtain where Ms. Mills disappeared.

Ms. Mills replaces her smile with a sympathetic expression as she comes back to my bedside and takes some papers out of her bag. She addresses Damiano. "All right, let's get started on this paperwork. What's your name and date of birth?"

I listen as he replies. His name is Damiano Julian Lamberti. His birthday is July 12, and his birth year makes him two years older than me.

"Only twelve and already quite the young man," Ms. Mills says in an overfriendly kind of way.

Damiano glares stonily back at her.

Her smile fades as she turns to me. "What's your name, honey?"

From the other side of the bed, Damiano looks at me. Really looks at me, and his eyes are desperate. This is the last time we're going to see each other. As soon as that form is filled out, she'll take Damiano away. I'll be all alone again, just like that dog at the gas station, waiting and waiting for someone who's never coming back.

I swallow down my tears, but I have to swallow so hard that my throat aches. "Lucy Cinders," I start to say, but Damiano's voice cuts across mine.

"Lucy Lamberti."

His voice is louder and faster than mine, drowning me out. Ms. Mills's pen stops moving. She looks up at him, confused.

"Her real name is Liliana, but she goes by Lucy. She's my sister."

Ms. Mills nods slowly and notes that down. She doesn't question it. Why would she? We have the same curly hair and dark eyes. We were at the same place. We're clearly traumatized children who need help, not questions.

I stare at Damiano in shock. My mouth opens but no sound comes out.

He catches my eyes briefly and widens his, urging me silently to play along. He's made a choice, and he's asking me to trust him.

Has he gone crazy? Why is he pretending I'm his dead sister?

"Dad took us to that house and left us outside while he went in to take drugs," Damiano explains to Ms. Mills. His voice is steady now, confident. He's committed to this lie. "We were down by the creek when the whole place exploded. Dad was inside. Lucy's date of birth is August 4. She's ten. Born two years after me."

My birthday is May 23. Damiano must be telling Ms. Mills his sister's birthday. He speaks in a determined rush, staring hard at the CPS worker as she scribbles down his sister's information on my form. He flicks glances at me, silently begging me not to contradict him.

I'm too shocked to speak. My heart is racing. What is he doing?

"It's very sad what happened to your father," the CPS worker remarks blandly as she checks over her paperwork, marking the page here and there. She looks up at him with a brisk smile. "All right, Damiano. There isn't enough room for you both to go to the same facility, and Lucy needs to stay in the hospital for a while longer. I'm going to take you to—"

Damiano's hand tightens on mine until it almost hurts. He interrupts her, his brown eyes flashing with defiance. "No."

Ms. Mills blinks. "I'm sorry?"

"I'm not going anywhere without Lucy." His voice rings with absolute certainty.

Ms. Mills opens her mouth, probably to explain how the system works, how he doesn't have a choice. But Damiano is fierce and protective and utterly unmovable.

"She's my sister," he says. "We stay together."

I stare at this twelve-year-old boy who just lost everything, who's covered in bandages and ash, and who's claiming a stranger as family to keep her from being alone. He's saving me. Just like he saved me from the explosion.

I squeeze his hand as hard as I can.

“He’s right,” I whisper, finding my voice. “We stay together.”

Ms. Mills looks between us, her professional mask slipping slightly. Maybe she sees something in our desperate faces. Maybe she just doesn’t want to fight two traumatized children.

“I’ll...see what I can do,” she says finally.

Damiano doesn’t relax his grip on my hand. Not even a little. And neither do I.

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Lucy

Present day

The Corinthian Hotel ballroom glitters with crystal chandeliers and the muted wealth of Malus's most powerful families, political and criminal, all mingling together. I stand at the edge of the crowd, champagne flute untouched in my hand, watching Damiano work the room.

He's twenty-two now and devastatingly handsome in his black tuxedo. Dark curls, perfectly styled, frame his sharp jaw, and those warm brown eyes see everything. He moves through the crowd with the easy confidence of a prince who knows he'll one day be king. Men defer to him. Women gravitate toward him. He clasps hands, claps shoulders, laughs at jokes. Playing the part of Don Carlucci Barone's heir perfectly.

My chest aches as I watch him. Ten years we've lived under the same roof, pretending we're brother and sister. Ten years of dying inside every time he dates someone else, touches someone else, smiles at someone else the way I wish he'd smile at me.

"Beautiful, isn't she?"

I turn in surprise. A blond man in his mid-twenties has materialized at my elbow. He's tall, good-looking in a carefully groomed way that speaks of money and insecurity in equal measure. His smile is pleasant but doesn't reach his eyes.

"Excuse me?"

He gestures with his whiskey glass toward a stunning brunette laughing at something Damiano just said. "Jessica Calabrese. Your brother has excellent taste."

The champagne turns sour in my mouth. I know who Jessica is. A senator's daughter, impeccably connected, and exactly the kind of woman Mom would approve of.

"He does," I say, taking a sip to hide my envy.

The blond man extends his hand. "Andreas Montoni. I don't believe we've been introduced, though I know who you are, of course. Lucy Barone. The jewel of the family."

I feel a flicker of annoyance at the empty flattery and shake his hand briefly. His palm is slightly damp. "Mr. Montoni."

I know the Montonis well. I went to school with his cousin, Adora Montoni, daughter of the late Agnello Montoni, and sister to the cold and slightly sinister Cristiano. He's the new Montoni don, the head of the crime family and one of the most powerful men in the city. I hope Cristiano turns out to be less bloodthirsty than his dead father.

"Please, call me Andreas. We're practically friends already, aren't we? Your father and my cousin do so much business together." He moves closer, invading my space. Close enough that I can smell his cologne, which is expensive and applied too liberally. "In fact, I've been hoping to get to know you better. Your father speaks very highly of your expertise with gemstones."

"Does he?" This surprises me. Dad barely acknowledges my existence at home.

"He says you have an exceptional eye. I've been thinking of making an investment in jewelry myself. Perhaps you could advise me?" His gaze drops to my neckline, lingering on the pendant nestled between my breasts. "I'd be grateful for your...expertise."

His oily tone makes my skin crawl. I'm about to excuse myself when I feel a familiar presence behind me. A subtle shift in air pressure that means safety and home, and everything I want and can't have.

“Andreas.” Damiano’s voice is cordial but with a sharpened edge. His hand settles on my lower back, possessive and protective. “I see you’ve met my sister.”

“Indeed. We were just discussing business opportunities.” Andreas’s smile doesn’t waver, but his eyes flick between Damiano’s face and where his hand rests on my back. Behind his pleasant expression, his eyes are calculating. “Lucy was telling me about her gemology work.”

“I wasn’t telling him anything, actually,” I correct, shifting closer to Damiano despite myself.

Damiano’s hand tenses fractionally on my back. “Lucy’s expertise is too valuable to discuss at a social function.” The warning is subtle but unmistakable. I’m not for the Montonis to covet.

Andreas raises his hands in mock surrender. “Of course. I meant no offense. Though I hope we’ll have the chance to speak again someday, Lucy.”

He melts back into the crowd, but not before shooting me one last appraising look that makes me feel like merchandise being evaluated.

“Creep,” I mutter once he’s out of earshot.

Damiano’s thumb traces a circle on my lower back, sending electricity up my spine. “Is it wrong I want to break his fingers for looking at you that way?”

My heart beats faster. I turn to face him, and we’re suddenly very close. Close enough that I can see the flecks of gold in his brown eyes. If I rose on my toes just slightly, our lips would meet.

“Damiano—” I start, not even sure what I’m about to say.

“There you are!” Jessica Calabrese appears, looping her arm through Damiano’s and pulling him away from me. Her smile is bright and possessive. “You promised me a dance, remember?”

Damiano’s hand drops from my back, and I feel the loss like a physical ache.

“Of course.” He glances back at me, something complicated and painful in his eyes. “Lucy, will you be all right?”

I want to say no and ask him not to leave me.

I force a smile. “I’m fine. Go dance.”

I watch them glide onto the floor, his hand on her waist instead of on mine, her head tilted up toward him adoringly. Around me, the gala continues, a glittering display of power and wealth.

Andreas Montoni is watching me from across the room, that calculating smile still in place.

Mom is holding court near the bar, regal and cold, probably already plotting which suitable man she can marry me off to.

This is what our lie has bought us. I set down my champagne flute and walk out of the ballroom before anyone can see the tears threatening to spill from my eyes.

I don't know how much longer I can pretend my heart isn't breaking every single day.

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Damiano

Ten years earlier

“**L**ucy, don't go in there. Lucy, please. I'm begging you.”
I'm standing on the edge of the creek watching Lucy smile and wave at me in slow motion before walking into the old weatherboard house that's standing once more, whole and unburned. There should be plenty of time to run and save Lucy, but my feet are rooted to the spot.

I scream her name until I'm hoarse. “*Lucy.*”

The house explodes in flames, glass and metal flying out in every direction. A small figure stumbles from the house, her whole body on fire. She crumples to the ground and doesn't move as flames engulf her body.

“*Lucy,*” I sob, and I know it's all my fault, because for some reason that I don't understand, I'm the one who brought her back here.

A cool hand touches my forehead. A sweet voice calls my name. “*Damiano.*”

My eyes snap open. Lucy is hovering over me in the dark, stroking my sweaty brow. Her blonde curls are wild around her head, unsinged. Whole.

Alive.

"It's not real. You're having a nightmare," she whispers.

I groan, seizing her and pulling her down against my chest. She's okay. She's okay. With my heart thundering in my ears, I watch as Lucy lifts the blankets and crawls into the narrow bed with me.

"You'll get into trouble," I remind her. The Milbray group foster home is very strict about girls staying in the girls' dorm at night and boys staying in the boys' dorm, but my arms are already wrapping around her, needing the comfort of knowing she's safe and in one piece.

"I don't care." Lucy scowls in defiance and pulls the blankets over both of us.

"I care," I insist, but I still hold her tight against me, feeling her heartbeat against my ribs. Proof that she's alive, and I didn't fail her like Lily.

Getting into trouble at Milbray isn't like school where all you get is a telling-off or lines to write. We've only been here a short time since Lucy was discharged from the hospital, but I've already discovered that the people who work here are mean. When they look at you, they see every misbehaving, troubled kid who's been through this horrible place. I guess some of the kids swore at them, or punched them, or threw things at them, and now the workers don't like any of us.

Lucy and I have been following instructions as best we can, but that doesn't stop the workers from shouting at me to shut up and sit down when I try to explain that Lucy's afraid of loud noises since the explosion, and she's scared because kids are banging on the tables. I can't stop them from grabbing Lucy's arm and wrenching her back into her seat when she tries to run and hide, and that's even worse. It makes my blood boil seeing people hurt Lucy.

I hate them all. I hate this place so much. Most of all, I hate what it's doing to Lucy. She's even skinnier than when we arrived two weeks ago, and there are dark shadows beneath her eyes. I know she only heard me crying out because she was lying awake, unable to sleep.

I bury my face in her hair and breathe in deeply. She smells like the cheap soap they give us here, but she's still Lucy. Letting out the breath in my lungs in a deep, slow rush, I feel my heart rate slow and some of the terror ease.

Lucy is the only good thing I have. I can't stand to see her suffering in this place.

"Tell me something about you," she whispers, stroking my hair.

I lift my head and check the beds around me. The other six boys in this room are all fast asleep. I relax back down and rub my cheek against hers. "I like you here with me."

I don't know why, but holding Lucy feels so different to when I used to hold Lily. When Lucy's in my arms, I never want to let her go.

"Give me a real answer. I need to know all about you if you're supposed to be my brother."

"That was a real answer." I think for a moment, trying to remember important things I should tell her that my sister would know. "Things have been hard since Mom died. Cancer. It was horrible seeing her like that. She didn't look like Mom anymore. Dad lost the plot afterward. He stole drugs from his ambulance job and got fired, but he still needed drugs, so that's why we were always at that horrible house." The words taste bitter in my mouth. I've never said any of this out loud before. "Lily was in denial about everything, so there was just me watching them both thinking, this is a nightmare, I'm the only one who knows it, and I don't know how to fix it."

Lucy's fingers trail through my curls, gentle and soothing. "Now tell me something that makes you happy."

Her touch makes it easier to breathe. Easier to think about something other than flames and screaming. My eyes drift closed. "The hope that things can get better. What about you?"

Her fingers thread through my curls in a steady rhythm. "Quiet gardens," she says softly. "Bees humming over flowers. Warm sunshine and cold soda. An afternoon so peaceful and lovely that the whole world and all its problems fall away."

I open my eyes and look at her. In the darkness, I can just make out her face. "I want all that for you. I'm going to make it happen."

Her beautiful brown eyes, that have seen too much at her young age, grow troubled. "Damiano. I'm afraid people are going to figure out you're not really my brother, and when they do, they'll send one of us away, and we'll never see each other again."

The fear in her voice makes my chest tighten. "They won't," I say urgently. "Remember what I told you? If someone tries to separate us, you

tell them..." I prompt her, waiting for her to recite the instructions I gave her.

"I say, *I'm not going anywhere without my brother Damiano. I want my brother Damiano.* I scream it if I have to, so you'll hear me and come running."

"And I will run to you as fast as I can." I press a kiss to her forehead and squeeze her in a hug. She yelps in pain, and my head lifts off the pillow. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing," she says quickly. Too quickly. She's covering her ribs with her hand, trying to curl away from me.

I reach for the hem of her T-shirt, and she clutches my fingers with panic in her eyes.

"Damiano, don't. It's nothing."

She doesn't want me to see, because then I might get angry and get into trouble. But I need to know.

"It's not nothing. Let me see." I lift her T-shirt and search her stomach in the dark. There's a bruise on her left ribs, a nasty shade of purple and blue. It looks like someone elbowed her or even kicked her while she was on the ground.

Fury and regret churn through me. I gently touch the spot, and Lucy flinches. "Lucy, who did this?"

"It doesn't matter. I just wish I was bigger than them. Then they wouldn't dare," she whispers fiercely.

Lucy is small for her age, she doesn't trust or like anyone but me, and she wears her dislike on her face. Some people take that as an invitation to hurt her. I can guess who it was—that sandy-haired boy of eleven or so who's been hanging around her with a nasty look on his face. His name is Mason, or Mark, or something like that. I've seen how he watches her. How he smirks when she flinches at loud noises.

I kiss the bruised spot gently and pull her T-shirt down. My jaw clenches so hard my teeth ache. "I'm bigger than them. Next time, tell me, and I'll sort them out. Promise?"

"Promise."

Her eyes close, and she slowly drifts into sleep. I watch her pretty face for as long as I can because it keeps the dancing flames away.

I couldn't save Lily.

I couldn't save Dad, even though he didn't deserve saving.

But I can save Lucy. I will save Lucy.
My eyelids grow heavier and heavier until I succumb to slumber.



WE'RE WOKEN by a boy shouting at the top of his lungs, "There's a girl in the boys' dorm. There's a girl in the boys' dorm!"

Lucy sits up with a gasp, pulling herself out of my embrace. The room is bright with morning light. The boy in the bed across from me is pointing at Lucy like she's a wild animal who has crept inside.

She scrambles out of my bed and hurries toward the door, but not before I see the fear on her face that they might separate us because of this.

"Shut your mouth, or I'll shut it for you," I snap at the boy.

The boy quiets his shouting, but he says in a bossy voice, "You can't sleep in the same bed as your sister."

Like there's anything wrong with sharing a bed with your sister when neither of us can sleep. After what we've been through, we need each other. "You mind your damn business."

"Pervert," he flings at me. "Weirdo."

I head for the bathroom, muttering, "You've never had a sister before, and it shows."

But his words stick in my mind as I wash up and get dressed. Pervert. Weirdo. Is there something wrong with how much I need Lucy and how much I think about her?

No. It's not like that. She's my sister, and I'm just protecting her.

I head for breakfast. The institutional off-white paint on the walls has yellowed with age, the color making me feel sick. None of the children here are happy, and unhappy kids are noisy, disobedient, violent kids. Every mealtime is grating, but breakfast this morning is particularly chaotic. Forty kids squabbling over packets of cornflakes and cartons of milk, hitting each other, shouting, and crying. There's no sign of anyone who works here.

Lucy is sitting in a corner pressed into her chair, too scared to go up and get herself something to eat. My chest tightens seeing her like that, small and afraid and hungry.

I fetch us some cereal and even manage to grab a small bowl of cut fruit.

I place the food in front of Lucy, and I sit down to eat my breakfast. But Lucy doesn't touch her spoon. She's staring at the commotion around us with big, scared eyes, her breathing too fast.

I can't stand it. I scoop her out of her chair and settle her into my lap, turning her away from the other kids and shielding her with my body. At least here, she doesn't have to see them. She doesn't have to be afraid.

"Look at you," I scold her gently, finger combing the tangles from her hair. "You're like a woolly sheep. Mary's little lamb."

She smiles just a little and puts her arms around my neck.

"I know you like strawberries." I pick one up and hold it to her lips.

She takes a small bite and chews it, and I smile at her. "Good?"

Lucy nods.

It takes me nearly half an hour of coaxing her and talking to her about different things, but she finally eats a small breakfast. All the while, I'm thinking about that bruise on her ribs. About Mason or Mark or whatever his name is, and how much I want to make him pay for hurting her.

"After we finish eating, should we go outside for a little while? Or maybe you can read to me like you did yesterday."

Lucy swallows her mouthful and stares silently at me. There's something in her eyes. A question she's afraid to ask.

The smile fades from my lips. "What's wrong?"

"Are you only being nice to me because you miss your sister?"

The question hits me like a punch. I look around, afraid someone might have overheard her. I take hold of her hands, and whisper urgently, "No. God no, Lucy. Please don't think that. I'm looking out for you because I want to. I don't want you to be alone." I stare at our joined hands, and then confess, "I don't want to be alone either."

When I look at Lucy, I don't see Lily. They're nothing alike. Lily was innocent, naïve, trusting. Lucy has already learned that the world is cruel. She's guarded and wary and so strong. I need that strength. I need her.

"I'm sorry about Lily," she whispers.

I nod, swallowing down the knot of grief in my throat. It's always there, sitting heavily inside me. "Me too. I miss her, but that's not why I'm doing this. You and me, we have to look out for each other, okay? No one's going to look out for us, so we have to be careful. No talking about not being a real brother and sister where anyone might hear us. In fact, we shouldn't

talk about it at all. If anyone finds out, you'll be taken away from me. I don't ever want that to happen."

We won't have any independence for years and years, which means we have to be smart. The only power we have in this situation is if we make everyone believe we're a brother and sister who refuse to be separated.

"You're so nice to me. I don't understand why you're so nice to me." Her lower lip trembles and tears fill her eyes.

Lucy looks so afraid that I wonder if she's still seeing the taillights of her mom's car disappearing as she's left behind. Anger burns hot in my chest—not at Lucy, never at Lucy, but at her mother. At my father. At every adult who should have protected us and didn't.

"How could I not be? You're the only person who understands what being us feels like." I lean my forehead against hers, and whisper, "I need you as much as you need me. When I saw you sitting between those cars all by yourself, I thought, there's a girl who needs a big brother. I was right, wasn't I?"

Lucy was too proud at first to tell me that she'd been abandoned, and she doesn't want to admit, even now, how desperately afraid she was. She tries to hold the truth in, but she can't. The tears fall down her cheeks, and she sobs, "Yes, I need you."

I wrap her in my arms, rock her back and forth while she cries, and press kisses to the top of her head. Being able to comfort Lucy soothes some of the pain in my heart. Some of the guilt over Lily. I couldn't save my sister, but I can save Lucy. I can give her the protection and love she deserves.

I take her face in my hands and stare into her tear-filled eyes. She shouldn't be so desolate at just ten years old. I want to put some light back into her heart.

"I can't be Lily's brother anymore, but I can be yours. I'm not going to let anything happen to you, Lucy. We're going to stay together, and things are going to get better for us. I swear it."



"IF SHE DOESN'T LEARN to smile, no one's ever going to want her. So skinny she's all bones, and that miserable face? Ugh, I can't stand to look at her."

Two of the facility workers are discussing Lucy, who's sitting at a table drawing with pencils, thankfully too far away to hear what's being said about her.

White-hot rage floods through me. I want to shout at the women for talking about Lucy like that. I want to hurt them. But I can't, because we need to get out of Milbray, and if they start thinking I'm trouble, that will be bad news for me and Lucy.

That's what I've heard them say to prospective adoptive and foster parents about some of these kids. *Don't take him. That kid's trouble.* And those kids are stuck here. Some of them have been here for months. The worst ones, like the boy who hurt Lucy, have been here for years. Locked up and forgotten like animals at the pound.

Lucy's been abandoned too many times, and it's killing her to be in here, reminding her every day that she's not wanted.

As I pass the women, I smile at them and cheerfully wish them a good day, being my most charming self. I've been told I have a lovely smile. In the last six months, the number of grown women who have told me what a *handsome little man* I am and touched my curls has gone up exponentially. I detest it. I loathe strangers touching me, but if my looks and my smile help me and Lucy get out of here, then I'll use them as much as I have to.

They smile fondly at me. "And you, Damiano."

My smile drops as soon as I'm out of their sight. I hate them. Hate them. *Hate them.* The rage simmers under my skin. Sometimes I imagine what I'd do if I didn't have to smile and be good. Sometimes I imagine making them hurt the way they've hurt Lucy, but I push those thoughts down, because I can't afford to be that person until Lucy is safe.

All Lucy and I need is a couple who are not on drugs, not neglectful, not cruel, who want to foster or adopt a brother and sister who love each other very much. I swear under my breath to any deity who might be listening that I'll work so hard for my new family. I'll obey them and respect them, as long as they respect and love Lucy. She needs love so goddamn much.

I don't have to wait long. A week later, opportunity knocks.

I'm called into Mr. Lane's office, Milbray's director, and the other kids stare at me because everyone knows what that means. Prospective parents. Some kids look envious, others bitter, but most pretend they don't care.

Excitement flutters in my stomach as I hurry down the corridor. I expect to see Lucy already in the room, but there's no sight of her as I approach.

Mr. Lane's voice reaches my ears, and I linger in the doorway to listen.

"...a well-mannered, respectful, and clever boy, not been here for very long, and keen to be adopted by a kind and loving couple such as yourself." Mr. Lane catches sight of me and waves me in. "Ah! And here he is. Come in and sit down, Damiano. Meet Mr. and Mrs. Barone."

There's a couple sitting in chairs in front of his desk, and they both look around and smile at me. The man looks like he's in his early fifties, and the woman is a little younger, in her forties. Both of them have dark hair and dark eyes, though Mr. Barone is going gray at the temples. I don't know much about clothes and jewelry, but these two have the whiff of wealth about them. Mr. Barone's suit fits him like a glove, and there's a heavy gold watch on his wrist and a gold ring on his pinkie finger. Mrs. Barone is immaculate in a blouse and long skirt made in a lustrous fabric that rustles softly as she moves. Her nails are wine red and manicured into points. She wears gold jewelry, and a lot of it. Rings sparkle on her fingers. The handbag she holds in her lap has a gold logo that I've seen on billboards, clutched by supermodels.

Mr. and Mrs. Barone will be able to give Lucy everything she's dreamed of and more. A bed with one of those canopies that princesses have. A pony. A bookshelf full of new books to read. Persian kittens. Pretty dresses.

Quiet gardens. Warm sunshine. Peace.

I didn't think to hope for a family who is kind *and* wealthy to adopt us, but it seems the universe sent us one anyway.

I sense something else about them that makes the nape of my neck prickle and my heart beat faster.

Power.

And power means better security for Lucy.

I smile and shake the couple's hands, introduce myself, and sit in the empty seat next to them. My palms feel sweaty, but I make myself stay calm, for Lucy's sake.

"Mr. and Mrs. Barone are keen to get to know you, Damiano. Would you mind if they asked you some questions?" Mr. Lane asks.

"I don't mind at all."

The Barones are polite and friendly, and they ask me so many questions about myself that they give me the impression they're looking for a boy with a particular temperament, the right look, the right qualities. They seem

keen to assure themselves that I will grow up to be a tall, strong young man. They discuss my olive skin and brown eyes, so similar to their own. They seem happy when I tell them that my father was tall like Mr. Barone. They point out to each other that my curly hair is very like Mrs. Barone's.

It's strange, but maybe this is a normal part of the adoption process. I wouldn't know. I've never done this before.

"Are you a brave young man, Damiano?" Mr. Barone asks me.

Mr. Lane interjects, "Damiano lost both his parents, one of them violently, and he's been as steady as a rock. Adversity only makes Damiano stronger."

Steady as a rock? I have nightmares every single night. I wake up screaming Lucy's name, convinced she's burning, but if Mr. Lane wants to lie for me, I'll let him.

"That's wonderful to hear," Mr. Barone says with a decisive nod. "None of this crying and feeling sorry for yourself for men like us, right, Damiano?"

"Right," I say uncertainly. Men like us? What does that mean?

Mr. Barone's eyes are sharp and assessing. He's wondering if I'm strong enough for...something.

"I think we'll take a beautiful family portrait together," Mrs. Barone tells me with a smile.

I start to feel like a racehorse up for sale, but I push that thought away and focus on what matters. "You should meet my sister, Lucy. I'll go and get her."

Before I can get out of my seat, Mr. Lane holds out his hand to stop me. "Mr. and Mrs. Barone are only interested in adopting a boy. They already have a daughter."

I look from one adult to the other, an ominous buzzing starting up in my ears. "But Lucy is my sister."

Mr. Lane fixes a placating smile on his face. "Damiano, this might be difficult to hear, but brothers and sisters are often adopted separately, and it's the best thing that can happen to them. Lucy is such a sweet, pretty girl, and a family who desperately wants a girl is going to be along very soon to choose her."

I stopped listening at *adopted separately*.

I leap to my feet, the chair shooting out behind me and crashing into the wall. "No one's taking Lucy away from me."

Mrs. Barone's eyes widen at my outburst, and then they narrow. I can see her reconsidering. I'm going to ruin everything if I don't calm down. No one wants to adopt an angry boy who loses his temper all the time.

I sit back down and force myself to take a breath. I need to be smart about this.

"I'm sorry about that," I say, trying to keep my voice level. "I just love my sister so much. Can I ask your daughter's name?"

Mrs. Barone looks at Mr. Barone, who gives a slight nod. She turns back to me. "It's Ariana. She's eleven."

"I can't wait to meet Ariana. I love being a big brother." I smile warmly at Mrs. Barone, and I see her start to relax.

"You do?" Mrs. Barone asks.

"I've had a lot of practice. Since our mom died...well, Dad didn't cope very well. Drugs," I explain.

Mr. Barone gives me a sympathetic nod, though I notice his sympathy doesn't quite reach his eyes.

"Since then, I've been looking out for Lucy. She's ten, and she's told me so many times how she longs for a sister to play with. Lucy's so sweet. And smart. She's doing better than me in school. Sometimes she even helps me with my homework." I laugh, and Mrs. Barone laughs with me.

Am I selling this? I think desperately about what else I can say to convince them to adopt both of us. How many wealthy couples come in here? Almost none. I can't let this opportunity slip away, but one thing's for certain.

I'm not leaving without Lucy.

"Did I mention how pretty Lucy is? If you just meet her, I know you're going to love her."

I can see Mrs. Barone wavering. Mr. Barone is harder to read.

"Well..." Mr. Barone says, and that's all the permission I need.

I leap from my seat and rush out the door.

I run down the corridor, shouting Lucy's name. "Lucy! Where are you?"

I find her in her dorm room, sitting on her bunk bed. She looks up in surprise from her book. "What's wrong?"

"I think we're getting adopted," I say, slightly out of breath but smiling at her. My heart is racing. This is it. This is our chance. "Come and meet them. Wait. Let me just..." I gently pull the band from her hair so that her curls tumble around her face, and then I finger comb them into place.

“What’s going on? Adopted by who?”

I put my hands on her shoulders and gaze deep into her eyes. “Do you trust me?”

She nods without hesitation, and warmth expands in my chest.

“Good. There’s no time to explain. You don’t have to say much, but smile and be polite, okay?”

“To who? Why us?”

“Why not us?” I examine what she’s wearing. The jeans are fine, but her shirt is old and stained. I reach into her drawer for a clean pink baby doll T-shirt. “Quickly. Put this on.”

I help her out of the stained T-shirt and into the clean pink one. Her hair crackles with static as I pull it over her head and smooth it down. Going down on one knee, I examine Lucy’s face. She’s pale and too thin, with shadows under her eyes, but she’s still the prettiest girl I’ve ever seen. She just doesn’t have much chance to show it right now while the world is being so cruel to her.

I rub my thumbs across the apples of her cheeks to put some color in them. “Bite your lips,” I tell her.

She does, and they redden a little.

“Perfect.” I stand up and hold out my hand to her. “Let’s go, and don’t forget to smile.”

Lucy puts her hand into mine, and I take her down the corridor, hoping I’m leading her toward a better life. No, I *know* I’m leading her toward a better life. Rich people can give Lucy everything she deserves.

They have to take us both. They have to.

The Barones are waiting for us to return. Mrs. Barone looks uncertain, but Mr. Barone smiles at Lucy as we enter. “You are pretty, aren’t you? Just like your brother said.”

I gently squeeze Lucy’s hand, and she remembers to smile back, but I can feel her trembling slightly. She’s scared.

“And you’re determined not to be separated?” Mrs. Barone asks me, a crinkle of worry between her brows.

A jolt of anger shoots through me that she’s asking me that again, and in front of Lucy. I thought I made that clear. “It’s my duty as a big brother to look after my sister, no matter what. I wouldn’t be a very good big brother if I walked away from her or let her be taken from me.”

Mr. Barone nods approvingly. “The boy has a strong sense of family duty. I like it. That’s what I’m looking for.” He steps toward me and clasps his hands behind his back, and I sense that this is it. The moment that will determine our future. “You’ll be an obedient son and look out for this family?”

I straighten up and look him in the eye. I know the answer is yes. I’ll do whatever it takes. “I will, sir.”

“You’ll love and protect both your sisters? Not just Lucy?”

“Of course.”

“You’ll take after me, your new father, and join the family trade?” His eyes bore into mine. “What I’m building, I want to leave to my son. My wife is regretfully not able to have any more children, and we decided that we want a boy who can start learning what it means to be a Barone right away. You’ll be the eldest, and the head of this family one day.”

Head of the family. The weight of that settles on my shoulders, and it feels like purpose.

“What’s the family trade?” While they were asking so many questions about me, I forgot to ask anything about them.

The corners of his lips turn up slightly. “I own a lot of property. I’m a businessman. Negotiations. Alliances. Deals.”

There’s something he’s not saying, but right now, I don’t care. “So I’ll have to be a persuasive talker to follow in your footsteps?” I risk a roguish smile, guessing that he’ll like that.

Mr. Barone laughs and wags a finger at me. “That you will. I can tell you’re already well on your way in that department, young man.”

“Such a charming boy,” Mrs. Barone tells me with a fond smile.

Lucy and I are asked to wait outside the office, and I pace up and down, wondering if I made the right impression on them. Lucy stands back against the wall, watching me with worried eyes.

“I don’t think they want me, Damiano,” she says quietly. “I think they only want you.”

I stop pacing and crouch down in front of her, taking her hands in mine. “They want you,” I say fiercely. “Don’t you dare believe otherwise, even for a second. I won’t let them take me without you. I promise.”

A few minutes later—minutes that feel like hours—Mr. and Mrs. Barone emerge from the office, and they’re smiling.

“Welcome to the family,” Mr. Barone tells us.

“Both of us?” Lucy blurts out, hope and disbelief warring on her face.

“Both of you. Your brother was very persuasive,” he adds with a chuckle. “Mr. Lane tells us that there’s some paperwork that needs to be completed, but we can bring you home tomorrow morning. There will be a car waiting for you at nine o’clock.”

My heart does a victory lap around my chest. I did it. I actually did it.

As soon as we’re alone, I pick Lucy up and swing her around in my arms, laughing in joy and relief. “Tomorrow, Lucy. We’re getting out of here tomorrow. In less than sixteen hours, we’ll leave this place forever.”

Lucy doesn’t say anything as I set her back on her feet. She looks dazed, like she can’t quite believe it’s real.

“Are you pleased? Are you happy?” I ask, needing to see her smile.

She thinks carefully for a moment and then looks up at me. “You’re happy, so I’m happy.”

It’s not the wholehearted excitement that I was hoping for, but it’s enough for now. It’s understandable that she’s hesitant after all the disappointment she’s suffered. As I smooth her curls back, she smiles at me a little.

“Things are going to be much better for us from now on,” I promise her. “You’ll see.”

I take Lucy back to her room, press a kiss to her hair, and go for a walk around the facility. The two women workers call my name in greeting, but I walk past without a word or a smile.

Heavy chains have fallen from my shoulders. I’ve loathed feeling shackled into good behavior by this place, but I no longer have to pretend that I don’t hate every single person here but Lucy.

It only takes me a moment to find the boy I’m looking for, the sandy-haired piece of shit who’s been leaving bruises on Lucy’s body. I follow him into the boys’ bathroom, my footsteps quiet on the tile floor.

He doesn’t notice me until I’m right behind him.

I approach him slowly, letting cold fury fill my expression. “Good news, Mark. I’m getting out of here.”

“Mason,” he corrects me automatically, but his eyes flicker with fear as he realizes we’re alone.

“Good news for me. Not good news for you.”

Mason tries to get away from me, but I reach out and block his escape with my arm. I’m taller than him. Stronger. And I’ve been waiting for this

moment for two weeks.

“Did you think I don’t know you hurt her? Did you believe I didn’t care?”

“Who are you, um, talking about?” His voice cracks.

As I drink in his fearful expression, a powerful new sensation expands inside me, from the top of my head right down to my toes. It feels like black flames flickering in bright daylight, casting shadows instead of light.

It feels good.

I have to be strong to protect Lucy, now and always, and that means being willing to do dark things.

“Do you know the only thing I like about this hateful fucking place?” I ask, stepping closer. “There are no locks on the dorm doors. I’m not leaving until tomorrow morning, so I have all night to get to you while you sleep.”

I’ve fantasized long and hard about my revenge as I’ve laid awake at night, and I know exactly how I’d do it. Leaning close to his ear, I whisper, “Strangling isn’t noisy. No one will hear you choking for breath. It hurts, though, and it takes a long, long time to die. Your dorm mates will find your cold body hanging from the top bunk when they wake in the morning. Your face and lips blue. Your tongue sticking out. *He did it to himself*, they’ll tell each other. *So sad.*”

“Please,” the boy begs, his voice breaking. “It wasn’t me. I didn’t mean it.”

Bullies will say anything to wriggle out of the consequences of their actions. It’s pathetic. “I saw the bruises on Lucy’s body. Unless you want to feel me wrapping a sheet around your scrawny neck in the dead of night, you’ll find Lucy and apologize to her.”

Mason nods frantically and tries to get away, but I seize his arm and offer one last piece of advice. My fingers dig in hard enough to bruise.

“If you breathe one word of this to anyone, remember that you’re locked in here with me, and I will use every minute of every hour to make you regret your pathetic existence.”

I watch him run away, stumbling in haste to escape. Satisfaction washes over me, dark and intoxicating.

I can protect Lucy. No one will dare hurt her ever again.

And if they do? I’ll make them wish they’d never been born.

Lucy

Two years later

“**L**ucy, posture.” I straighten my spine at the dinner table, my fork hovering over the chicken I can barely taste. Even though I’ve been living in this house for two years, dinner is a formal affair, and it makes me nervous. I’ve never felt at ease in this majestic house of stern gray stone, with columns and tall, gleaming windows. It’s nestled in a neighborhood of large, expensive houses just like it, set back from the streets behind wrought iron fences and landscaped gardens. This is a far cry from the Malus I was born into, which was a world of peeling wallpaper and roaches, where the apartment reeked of cigarettes and desperation, and dinner was whatever Mom remembered to buy before she disappeared again.

Across from me, Ariana sits with her napkin folded just so in her lap, dressed perfectly with her hair smooth and shining. She catches my eye and smirks.

Mom dabs at her lips with her napkin. “We’re attending a charity gala next week. Ariana will be coming with us. Lucy, you’ll stay home with Mrs.

Monti.”

“What about Damiano?” I ask.

“Damiano will be attending with us, of course. He needs to be seen.”

Needs to be seen. Like he’s a show dog being paraded around. But at least he gets to go. I have to stay home with the housekeeper.

“Lucy should come too,” Damiano says, and I flash him a grateful smile.

Dad doesn’t even look up from his plate. “Lucy isn’t ready for that kind of event.”

“When will I be ready?” The words slip out before I can stop them. The silence that follows is deafening.

Mom’s lips thin. “When you learn not to speak out of turn.”

Damiano reaches under the table and finds my hand, giving it a quick squeeze. It’s the only comfort I get.

Later, when everyone else is asleep, I hear my door creak open. Damiano slips inside, closing it quietly behind him.

“You okay?” he whispers.

I nod, but we both know it’s a lie.

He climbs into bed with me like we’ve been doing since the group home, wrapping his arms around me. “They’ll warm up to you. Give it time.”

“It’s been two years, Damiano. They haven’t warmed up to me. They don’t want me here. They tolerate me because you wouldn’t come without me.”

Damiano doesn’t argue because we both know it’s true. If only I knew how to make myself so useful to them that they can’t imagine life without me.

I’m sitting in the library one afternoon, reading a book about gemstones, when I hear voices from Dad’s study down the hall.

“...doesn’t fit in. If Damiano wasn’t so attached to her, I’d send her to boarding school in Europe and be done with it.” Dad sounds impatient, and I picture him pacing up and down.

Tears prickle in my eyes as I realize he must be talking about me. I’ve been trying so hard. I’ve learned to sit quietly at dinner. I laugh at Dad’s jokes even when I don’t understand them, and dress in the way Mom wants me to dress. I try to be friendly with Ariana, though she still looks at me like I’m something she scraped off her shoe.

Yet it's not enough. Mom still corrects my posture, my diction, the way I hold my fork. Dad barely acknowledges I exist unless I do something wrong.

And Damiano is slipping away from me.

Not intentionally. I know he doesn't mean it, but he's being prepared for something. I can see it in the way Dad pulls him aside for father-son talks that I'm never included in. Damiano comes back from these talks looking older, more serious, and more distant.

"She's just shy. She'll grow out of it," Mom replies, but she doesn't sound like she believes her own words.

"She's trouble, and she distracts Damiano. She'll never be anything but a burden to this family."

I don't hear Mrs. Barone's response because blood is rushing in my ears.

Burden. Trouble.

I look down at the book in my hands. *The Gemologist's Handbook*. I've been reading it because Mom loves jewelry, and I thought maybe if I learned about it, I could find something to talk to her about. Some way to connect with her so she would smile at me.

But a new thought occurs to me. This family is obsessed with money and power. I hear Dad talking on the phone about deals and profits, and Mom discusses her friends and acquaintances in terms of how expensive their clothes are and how much money their husbands make. Jewelry is important in their world. I have no idea what I want from my future, but this could be it. If I become an expert and make myself invaluable to Mom and Dad, if I can impress them, then I'm not just Damiano's unwanted sister anymore.

I'll be an asset. And assets don't get discarded.

That night, I don't wait for the middle of the night to go to Damiano. I need him as soon as dinner is over. He's not in his room, and so I wait. My fingers trail over his desk. His school backpack. I grow impatient, wondering where he is, and idly open a desk drawer.

What I see makes me freeze. A gun, gray metal, cold and deadly, nestled among pencils and erasers like it belongs there. I reach out with trembling fingers and touch it. The metal is cool, and it's heavier than I expected when I pick it up.

Why does Damiano have a gun?

“Lucy, do you want to—”

I spin around. Damiano is standing in the doorway, his mouth parted in surprise at what I’m holding. We stare at each other.

“It’s not loaded,” he says quickly, closing the door behind him. “The bullets are separate. I would never be so careless.”

“Why do you have a gun?”

He pushes a hand through his curls, looking older than his fourteen years. He won’t meet my eyes. “Dad gave it to me. For protection.”

“Protection from what?”

Damiano doesn’t answer. He takes the gun from my shaking hands and puts it back in the drawer, closing it firmly.

“Damiano, what’s going on? What is Dad involved in?”

“Nothing you need to worry about.”

“Don’t do that. Don’t treat me like I’m stupid.” My voice rises in pitch, along with my anxiety.

His jaw clenches. “I’m not. I’m protecting you.”

I don’t need protection. I need the truth, but he won’t give it to me. “Do you think I’m a burden?”

His face transforms with concern. He comes forward and pulls me into his arms. “What? No. Never. Where is this coming from?”

I want to tell him what I heard, but if I do, he’ll confront Dad, and that will make everything worse.

“It’s a feeling I get from our parents. Just the way they look at me sometimes.”

“They don’t understand you yet. But they will. I promise.”

I wish I could believe Damiano. I let him hold me anyway because this is the only place I feel safe.

That night, I lie awake thinking about the gun. About the expensive cars that come and go at odd hours. About the men in suits who defer to Dad with a particular kind of fear-tinged respect.

I’m not stupid. I’m beginning to suspect what this family is. I just didn’t want to admit it.

Meanwhile, Damiano’s nightmares are getting worse. He wakes up screaming at least twice a week now, and I always run in to comfort him. I slip into his bed and hold him while he shakes, while he gasps about fire and burning.

“Lucy, no. Lucy, please. Don’t go in there.”

Tonight is particularly bad. He's thrashing so violently, I'm afraid he'll hurt himself.

"Damiano, wake up. I'm here. I'm safe."

His eyes fly open, wild and unfocused. Then they land on me, and he makes a sound like a wounded animal, pulling me against his chest so hard I can barely breathe.

"You're okay. You're okay." He's saying it like a mantra, his hands running over my hair, my back, my arms, as if checking that I'm real and whole.

"I'm okay," I promise. "I'm right here."

He buries his face in my hair, and I feel wetness on my neck. Tears.

"I can't lose you, Lucy. I can't. You're all I have."

"You won't lose me. Never."

We stay like that for a long time, wrapped around each other in the darkness. Within his embrace, something shifts inside me. It's the way I fit against him. The way his heart beats against my cheek. The way his fingers tangle in my hair like he's trying to memorize the feel of it. Is this how a brother holds a sister?

My own heart is racing, and warmth pools in my stomach. I never want to leave his arms. It doesn't feel like how a sister loves a brother.

Am I falling in love with Damiano?

Confusion crashes over me like ice water. I'm twelve years old, and I have tender feelings for the boy who calls himself my brother. The boy who saved my life, who's the only person in the world who truly loves me.

I open my mouth to ask him if he feels the same about me, but what if he's so horrified that he pulls away? What if he never comes to my bed again or lets me come to his?

What would Mom and Dad do to me if they found out? What would they do to *him*?

I picture their cold eyes at the dinner table. The way they assess everything and everyone. They took us in, but we're not really theirs. Not their blood. If they discovered the truth, that we lied about being siblings, they'd throw me out. Or worse.

And if they knew I had *these* feelings for Damiano? My stomach twists, and I close my mouth.

Damiano only sees me as the sister he wants to protect. I can never, ever tell him.

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Lucy

Four years later

“Well, well, the prodigal son drags himself out of bed at last.”
I look over the top of my book at a shirtless Damiano as he emerges onto the sunny terrace. His dark curls are messy from sleep, and it strikes me—not for the first time—that my eighteen-year-old brother looks more like a man every day. Tall and muscular, with a tan burnishing his skin, and dark stubble on his jaw.

My stomach does that stupid flip it’s been doing for the past six years whenever I look at him. I hate it. I love it. I can’t help it.

Striding toward me with a smile on his lips, Damiano tosses aside my book, puts an arm under my knees and another around my back, and scoops me out of the chair and into his arms.

“Hey, I was reading,” I chide him, wrapping my arms around his neck. His skin is warm beneath my fingers, and I have to resist the urge to trace the defined muscles of his shoulders.

“You can read later. I need you.” Damiano sits down with me in his lap, settling my thighs across his and wrapping his strong arms around me. He

presses a kiss to my temple and takes a deep, relaxing breath, and I feel some of the tension leave his body as mine melts into his.

This is dangerous. Being this close to him. Breathing in his scent. Feeling the steady thump of his heart against my side. This is the highlight of my day.

I nestle into his warmth, trying to enjoy the moment despite the hot lump of worry that's been sitting in my chest all day. "Where were you last night?"

"Nowhere in particular," he deflects with a charming smile.

My eyes narrow. Damiano was somewhere else, and so was the gun he keeps in his bedroom drawer. It wasn't there when I checked his room.

Over the past few years, Damiano has received special treatment from Mom, but especially from Dad. Not only is he praised for his cleverness and good looks, but he's told things. Secrets. Carefully guarded family knowledge. I've lingered outside doors and listened furtively to conversations. I know what kind of family we really are, yet no one's admitted it out loud to me.

The frightening part is watching Damiano being pulled deeper into Dad's world while I can only watch from the sidelines.

Damiano idly plays with one of my curls as he gazes around the expansive garden. The flowers are in full bloom. The hedges are manicured into razor-sharp lines. The white gravel paths are raked into pristine uniformity. A fuzzy bee tumbles past on its way to another flower.

He smiles, enjoying the perfect weather. "Do you remember what you told me would make you happy while we were living at Milbray? A garden full of bees and flowers. Sunshine and soda. A sunny and peaceful afternoon."

He gazes with satisfaction at the fragrant and colorful patio, my sweating glass of cold lemonade, and the paperback book I was reading.

"You remember that?" I ask, warmth spreading through my chest.

He turns to me with a small frown, and our faces are very close together. Close enough that I can see every single one of his velvety lashes. "Of course I do. I remember everything that's important to you."

A hot spark races through my body, and I fall deeper into his brown eyes. My lips part involuntarily, and the craving that accompanies Damiano's touches and loving words becomes an ache.

I'm not allowed to admire my brother's handsome face. It's dangerous for me to want him to be my first kiss. My first everything.

If Mom and Dad find out I'm not really Damiano's sister, they'd throw me out of this house without a second thought. Despite what my brother insists, they don't love me. They never have. Only Damiano loves me, and if anyone finds out we're not blood related, I'll never see him again.

My beautiful, rich, ruthless parents will see to that.

"You're so good to me," I whisper, and put my head down on his chest. As I stroke the warm skin there, he makes a contented noise that does things to my insides. I smooth my hand up his chest and squeeze his shoulders, which feel like ropes of steel beneath my fingers.

He's so tense. More than usual.

"Do you remember the day we arrived in this house?" I ask, trying to ground myself in memory rather than the dangerous present.

He tilts his head so his chest is resting against my brow. "Like it was yesterday. We'd never seen a house as grand as this one. Your hand was trembling in mine as we crossed the threshold."

I felt as though we were walking into the lion's den. And maybe we were. "Frank picked us up from the group home, not Mom and Dad." Frank is Dad's driver, though we both know he's so much more than that. "It made me feel like we were parcels to be delivered, not people."

Damiano's arms tighten around me slightly. He doesn't like being reminded of how we were treated that day.

I trace one of the prominent veins on his forearm. "Frank had a gun holstered under his arm. I saw it when he reached for our bags."

Damiano hesitates. "Did he? I didn't notice."

My brother doesn't lie to me. He just gets evasive. Maybe he didn't notice the gun that day because he was focused on me, making sure I was okay. But he's noticed it since. He knows what Frank really is.

Drivers don't carry weapons.

Bodyguards do.

Enforcers do.

I let my fingers trail down his forearm, feeling the strength there. "You and Dad didn't come home until after three in the morning last night. What kind of father-son stuff happens at three in the morning?"

Damiano doesn't answer. When I raise my head to look at him, he rests his fist against his temple and smiles at me. "You look beautiful today."

The single hot spark racing through my body explodes into dozens more. Heat floods my cheeks, and I have to look away before he sees too much in my eyes.

“Your famous charm doesn’t work on me,” I lie.

He reaches for my lemonade and swallows a mouthful. I watch his throat working, mesmerized despite myself. “What charm? I’m telling the truth.”

“Damiano.”

He quirks a brow as he takes another sip. “Yes, sis?”

The word “sis” grates on me more every day. I’m not his sister. We both know it, but we have to keep pretending.

I take a breath and ask the question I’ve been building up to for weeks. “Are we in the mafia?”

He chokes a little on the lemonade and puts the glass down. His expression shifts from surprise, to calculation, and then careful neutrality. “What makes you ask that?”

There he goes, evading me again.

“Your expression. Your secrets. The gun in your drawer that sometimes isn’t there. Frank and the other men who come to the house at odd hours. The way people look at Dad, and at you, with fearful respect.” I lower my voice, even though we’re alone. “Do you really think you can keep things from me? You and I were adopted because Dad wants a son to pass the family business on to, but it’s not a normal family business, is it?”

Damiano’s jaw tightens. For a moment, I think he might actually tell me the truth. Then his expression softens and becomes almost pleading. “I don’t want you to spend your time worrying about why we were adopted. What we have now is so much better than what might have been. If we’d been separated at the hospital, or if we were adopted by different families...”

In his eyes, I see an echo of the terrifying nightmares that still wake him up almost nightly. The ones where he screams my name because I’m dying in the fire instead of Lily.

I wrap his hand in both of mine and squeeze it. “I’m so grateful for what you did for us. Don’t ever think I’m not.”

Damiano takes a deep breath and lets it out slowly. His expression is pained and haunted. “I don’t know what I’d do without you. If anything happened to you...”

“Nothing’s going to happen to me.”

“You don’t know that. This world—” He cuts himself off, his jaw clenching.

This world. The world he’s being pulled into that I’m not allowed to be part of.

“There you go again. Why must you two always be so dramatic?”

The prissy voice shatters the peaceful afternoon. A slender, dark-haired girl strolls across the patio carrying several shopping bags emblazoned with designer names. The fruits of our sister’s morning shopping spree.

Ariana is dressed like a New York socialite in a tiny slip dress, heels, and a short bouclé jacket with large gold buttons. Her makeup is perfect, and her hair is glossy and smooth. She looks like she stepped out of a magazine.

Ever since the day we arrived in this house, Ariana has resented our presence. Me because she mistakenly feared I’d take her place as Daddy’s little princess. Damiano because he’s a constant reminder that she’s not enough for Mom and Dad—because they wanted a son.

She looks with distaste at me sitting in Damiano’s lap. His hand is draped over my thigh while he plays with my hair. My hand is resting on his bare chest, fingers splayed over his heart.

We must look like lovers, not siblings.

She shakes her head in disgust. “You two...”

“Us two what?” Damiano asks, a hard edge to his voice. His hand on my thigh tightens possessively.

She smiles mockingly at him. “Such a *normal* brother and sister. So *normal* how you’re always plastered half naked against each other. Freud would have a field day with you two.”

I glower at Ariana. She can stick her needles into me whenever she likes, but not in front of Damiano. He feels the weight of responsibility for me on his shoulders, and it devastates him when someone hurts me.

“Jealous we don’t love you half as much as we love each other?” he asks, his fingers caressing my thigh in slow circles that make my breath catch.

It takes all my self-control not to part my lips and take a ragged breath or shift in his lap and press closer.

“Not in a million years,” she says with a laugh, and walks toward the house. “Freaks.”

Apprehension snakes through my belly as I watch her go. If Ariana has noticed that Damiano and I don't act like a normal brother and sister, what if Mom and Dad notice too? They'll excuse any mistakes that Damiano makes, but never mine.

"I hope she's not going to tell Mom and Dad what she just saw," I murmur.

Damiano glares after her. "Dad is tired of her whining about us. She can blow it out her ass." He turns to me with a smile, his mood shifting as it always does when it's just the two of us. "What are you doing tonight?"

I almost tell him the truth, that I'm doing nothing. Then I remember that he wouldn't be honest with me about what he and Dad were doing last night.

Two can play at that game.

I shrug nonchalantly. "Oh, this and that."

His eyes narrow slightly. "That's vague. I thought we could stay in and watch a movie."

"Sorry. Maybe another time."

His expression shifts, something dark flickering across his face. "You're busy on a Saturday night?"

"Is that a problem?" I smile like I'm thinking about the most handsome boy I know. Like I'm not already plastered against said boy's chest.

Damiano's expression grows stormy. His fingers dig into my waist. "You have a date? With who? You're sixteen. I forbid it."

A thrill runs through me at his possessiveness. I shouldn't enjoy it this much, but I do.

"Oh, you *forbid* it?" I ask archly. "What gives you that power?"

"Because I've heard every disgusting thing the boys of St. Peter's say about the girls from St. Agatha's, and I don't trust any of them anywhere near you." His voice is low and dangerous.

My smile remains mysterious. "Who says he's from St. Peter's? I know lots of boys."

It's a complete lie. I don't know any boys. I don't want to know any boys. There's only one person I want, and I can't have him.

"You *will* tell me who he is," he insists, and his hands slowly tighten on my waist.

"Maybe I will, maybe I won't," I counter playfully, enjoying pushing his buttons more than I should.

He laughs without humor and shakes his head. "Oh, Lucy. You think I'll be merciful with you just because you're my sister?"

But I'm not your sister!

I can't say that, so instead I say, "I'll never beg for mercy. A Barone doesn't spill her secrets."

Damiano gives me a hard, steely look that makes my pulse race. "You have three seconds to tell me. Three. Two. One. Right. You asked for this."

He attacks me with all ten of his fingers, tickling me mercilessly. I shriek with laughter and try to get off his lap, but he wraps a strong arm around my waist to hold me in place and redoubles his efforts.

I thrash from side to side, trying to free myself or make him stop. "Damiano! Damiano, please."

"Pleading won't help. I demand the truth." He keeps tickling me until there are tears streaming from my eyes, and I can't breathe I'm laughing so hard.

"All right, all right, *all right!*" I scream.

He pauses, but his fingers remain poised to resume torturing me. "You'll tell me who you have a date with?"

Panting, I sit up and push my curls out of my face. "I don't have a date. I was teasing you."

He captures my jaw with his thumb and forefinger and makes me look at him. His expression is fierce and possessive in a way that makes heat pool low in my belly. "I'll know if you sneak out. You had better not be lying to me. Remember what Dad has always taught us? Barones are not liars."

Guilt twists in my stomach. We're the biggest liars of all.

"I swear, I don't have a date. No one has ever asked me on a date," I say ruefully.

It's true, and I don't know if that's because of my intimidating family or because no one at St. Peter's likes me enough to ask.

He relaxes a little, but his eyes are still narrowed, searching my face. "And what do you say if some meat-headed, horny idiot asks you on a date?"

"I say, my big brother will kill you."

"You're damn right he will." He strokes my hair back from my face and studies me with an intensity that makes me feel naked. "If you want to go out tonight, I'll take you out. I just have to do some things first."

My heart leaps. A night out with Damiano, just the two of us. It's pathetic how much I want this.

I shrug, not wanting to show Damiano that a night with him all to myself is my idea of heaven. "Sure, if you're so desperate, I suppose I'll have to keep you company."

Damiano smiles like he can see right through me. He probably can. We've never been good at hiding things from each other.

"I'll pick you up at eight. Be ready when I get home?"

"I will."

He kisses my cheek, so close to the corner of my mouth that I feel it like a brand, and he gets to his feet with me still in his arms. For a moment, we're pressed together, chest to chest, his face inches from mine.

Then he settles me back into the chair like I weigh nothing.

"See you then, sis."

I watch his broad, muscular back as he heads into the house, my heart pounding in anticipation. Going out with Damiano on a Saturday night, and he's promised to pick me up.

It almost feels like a date.

Damiano

The capo is on his knees and sobbing his heart out, a pathetic display for a Barone man. My father sits behind his desk, fingers steepled, the gold viper signet ring glinting on his little finger. His face is impassive, but there's a slight curl to his lip as he gazes at the man.

He speaks to me, standing on his right-hand side. "What's my number one rule, Damiano?"

"Live with honor, Don Carlucci," I reply.

"And what do I hate more than anything in the world?"

The answer is readily on my tongue. It's been driven into me almost since the day Lucy and I arrived at the Barone mansion. "Lies, Don Carlucci."

The man on his knees sobs even harder. The dozen capos at his back are as still and impassive as stone. Everyone in this room knows the don's ironclad rules by heart, and they would sooner slash their own throats than act with dishonor. No one has an ounce of pity for the traitor.

Carlucci Barone makes his expectations crystal clear. The day we become made men, we swear an oath of loyalty to him, and we must live it, breathe it, and honor it until the day we die.

Even before I became a made man, I learned to fear displeasing Dad. I lost count of the number of times he beat me between the ages of twelve and fifteen. If I was late, if he thought I was lazy, if I questioned him or

didn't follow his instructions to the letter, he would take off his belt and lay into me viciously. Every inch of my back, my ass, my thighs would be on fire. Physical punishment is his favorite form of discipline.

It never happened at home, only in this office adjoining the Barone warehouses, so Lucy never knew.

I think she might have screamed the house down if she did.

When I turned fifteen, I learned the truth about our family, and I never dared to break one of Dad's rules again. I stood on the spot where Emilio is presently kneeling, the capos at my back, while Dad told me the reason why I'd been adopted. Not to be his son, or rather, not only to be his son. My father is not a businessman. Mr. Barone is just his public persona. He is Don Carlucci, head of the Barone crime family, and I had been plucked out of that squalid, hateful group foster home to become a mafia prince. Not a lot of what he was saying was a surprise to me as he'd given me a gun the year before, but this was the point of no return.

Dad was asking me to join him. I would be a soldier, the lowest ranked one at first, but I could work my way up, and if I worked hard enough and gave my whole life to the family, one day I would take his place and be as powerful as he is.

One day, I'd be Don Damiano.

Power clings to my father, giving him an aura that very few people possess. I sensed it that day he came to Milbray to handpick me as his son. Power means safety. Power means being able to protect the ones you love.

But power can be a double-edged sword. Power attracts danger.

That day when I was fifteen and Dad asked me to become a soldier, I hesitated before I gave my reply. "Will I get hurt?" I asked him.

I heard scoffing noises behind me. Dad's men thought I was a coward, but I didn't care. I wanted the truth.

Dad looked displeased. "My son, I brought you here to speak to you in front of my men because I thought you were brave."

"I'm asking for Lucy's sake. It would upset her if I got hurt, and she's shed too many tears already. I don't want to be the reason she cries."

"Who's Lucy?" one of the capos asked.

"My sister."

The man waved a dismissive hand. "Eh, I wouldn't worry so much about your sister."

“I *will* worry about my sister, sir,” I said tightly, my fists clenching at my sides.

I met Dad’s gaze and held it. I’d do what Dad asks of me. I’d break the law. I’d hurt people if that’s what he wants. But loving Lucy any less than with my whole heart?

Unthinkable.

I didn’t think he’d be offended by me loving Lucy more than him, Mom, and Ariana, and I was right. Love was not the reason he adopted me.

“I can’t see the future,” Dad told me. “Malus is a complicated and dangerous city, and it needs strong leaders. The best thing you can do to protect Lucy, to protect this family, is join me.”

I could see the sense in that. I’m a Barone, and that comes with respect as well as danger. Better that I face that danger head-on to shelter Lucy from it.

“Then I accept.”

Dad smiled, and his capos welcomed me.

When I turned eighteen three months ago, I became a made man, and I swore the *omertà*. The oath of honor. If I break that oath, I’ll be punished.

A Barone man keeps his mouth shut.

He does not tell his wife his secrets.

He does not tell his sister his secrets.

We keep our women out of our business for their own protection.

Loyalty to the family above all else.

Honor above life itself.

I swore that oath knowing that I was already breaking it. I was living a lie, concealing from my father that my sister and I did not share any blood. The lie has become part of me, knitting itself into my soul. It can never be undone because that lie is the only thing keeping Lucy safe.

I may not love Carlucci Barone, and he may not love me, but he respects me, and I respect him.

He has no such respect for my sister, and neither does the woman we call Mom. It pains me that they look upon Lucy with disdain. She’s the daughter they never wanted and never valued. I hoped that over the years they would learn to love her quick wits, her determination, or at least her beauty. They find her wits irritating because she talks back. They loathe her determination and call it stubbornness. They prefer Ariana’s polished looks to Lucy’s natural loveliness.

I can't change how they feel about her, but they will afford her protection as long as they think of her as a Barone. The sister of their prized son.

The lie I'm carrying is a deadly one. I fear what they'll do to Lucy if they ever find out the truth.

Lately, I'm the one putting her in danger because something has changed between Lucy and me. I tell myself I didn't notice when it happened. That there wasn't a specific moment. But that's a lie.

It was three months ago. Lucy came downstairs for dinner wearing a dress Mom had bought her for a family event. Just a simple black dress that made her eyes look as bewitching as jewels.

She smiled at me, the same smile she's given me a thousand times. She was still the same Lucy who holds my hand during thunderstorms and steals food off my plate, but I couldn't breathe.

I stared at her, frozen, while universes exploded into existence inside me. She wasn't my little Lucy anymore. She's never been just my little Lucy.

I left the room before anyone saw my face and the way I was looking at my stunning, sixteen-year-old sister.

I've been trying to kill these feelings. I date other girls, though never seriously, and never anyone who matters. Lucy thinks I'm pulling away and being evasive because I don't care anymore, but that's not true. Every time she touches me, every time she looks at me with those trusting eyes, my thoughts go to dark, heated places. I want things that are dangerous.

I want to make her mine. And that makes me a monster, because as far as Mom and Dad and everyone in Malus knows, she's my blood.

Emilio, the man on his knees before Don Carlucci, has broken his oath. Last night he got drunk and ranted about the Sokolis, a newer, rival crime family in Malus, boasting for everyone in the bar to hear that Don Carlucci was going to crush them. It was a stupid, nonsense rant, but it will bring Sokolis to our doorstep. They will hear about the drunken threats. Probably they already have.

There's a fireplace in Dad's office, and a fire crackles menacingly in the grate despite the warm day. A fire iron is buried in the hot coals, its tip glowing red.

Dad pronounces Emilio's sentence. "For your broken oath, you will be banished from Malus for the rest of your life. You are no longer part of this

family.” He nods to two of his men, who rip the shirt from Emilio’s back.

“But I have nothing without you, Don Carlucci,” Emilio begs. “My family has nothing without you.”

The pleas fall on deaf ears. Dad turns to me. “Will you do the honors, Damiano?”

I look at him in surprise. Me? He’s never asked me to dispense justice before, but I know better than to argue with the don. I make my way over to the fireplace and pull out the iron. The end has been flattened into a square, and it glows red-hot.

My face betrays nothing, but my heart races and stomach churns as I look at the glowing tip. This is a sign that Dad is putting more trust in me. Giving me more responsibility. I have no choice but to show him that I’m worthy of his trust.

I walk around behind Emilio and contemplate his bare back. His Barone viper tattoo is coiled across his shoulder, and it’s over a foot long. He’ll be wishing he chose something more discreet in a moment. My own viper tattoo is curled around my forearm. I got it the day after I swore the *omertà*.

“Hold his arms.” At my command, two capos seize Emilio by the shoulders and wrists on each side.

I press the red-hot iron into Emilio’s flesh. He screams and tries to thrash from side to side, but the capos have a tight hold of him. His flesh sizzles and smokes. The acrid scent fills my nostrils.

I keep my face impassive as I work my way from the tail of the snake right up to its flickering tongue until the tattoo is completely obliterated.

When I’m finished, I toss the fire iron back into the grate and turn.

Bile burns the back of my throat, but I swallow it down. I don’t feel sorry for Emilio. I’m disgusted. He’s a fool for running his mouth. You couldn’t drag my secret out of me under the cruelest torture.

Emilio is shuddering and gasping, but his tears have turned to fury. He slowly lifts his head and glares at my father. This idiot still hasn’t learned his lesson.

“Fuck you, Don Carlucci. I hope you burn in—”

He doesn’t have the chance to finish the sentence. Francesco Conti, one of Dad’s capos, draws his gun and shoots Emilio in the back of the head. He slumps forward and lies motionless as blood pools across the floor.

Emilio’s stupidity is a bitter taste in my mouth. His wife and his children are now unprotected because of his actions. He’s a pathetic excuse

for a man.

With a nod from Dad, a couple of soldiers come forward and drag the body from the room.

Francesco notices me staring at the bloodstained wooden floor and claps me on the back. “Are you going to lose your guts, boy?”

I heard a whole house full of meth addicts screaming in pain as they burned alive, along with my sister Liliana. I hear their screams in my nightmares every night. I held a bleeding Lucy in my arms, terrified she was going to be taken from me as well.

A short, sharp death like Emilio’s isn’t going to rattle me.

I examine my bare forearms for red spatter. “Is there blood on me? I have a date now.”

Behind his desk, Dad smiles and lights a cigar. As smoke wreaths his head, he says proudly, “That’s my boy.”



TWENTY MINUTES LATER, I meet Lucy in the entrance hall of the Barone mansion, and I pull her into my arms. I bury my face in her sweet-smelling hair and groan in relief. I’ve needed her ever since I pressed the red-hot iron into Emilio’s flesh. To reassure myself that she’s safe. Alive. Still mine.

The scent of burning flesh still clings to my nostrils, but Lucy’s perfume, floral and sweet, starts to wash it away.

As I pull back, I notice what she’s wearing for our night out. Jeans, and the tiniest handkerchief top I ever saw tied around her breasts. It exposes her midriff as well as some cleavage.

My eyes travel down her body slowly, drinking in every curve. She’s all grown up. When did that happen? When did Lucy become so...

I swallow hard.

Sexy.

I raise an eyebrow, trying to keep my voice light. “Looking to cause a riot tonight, sis?”

She puts her hand on her hip and pops it out, and the movement makes my mouth go dry. “Are you going to tell me to change?”

Telling her she can’t go out looking drop-dead gorgeous is like admitting I can’t protect her from other men, and it’s also admitting I can’t

handle seeing her like this.

I can handle it. I can.

I step closer and tuck her hair behind her ear, my fingers lingering on the soft skin of her neck. “I can fight. Wear what you want.”

A pretty blush spreads over her cheeks as she smiles up at me, and a warm sensation expands in my chest.

I reach for her hand and hold it tight. “Ready?”

“Ready.”

I drive us to the coast with one hand on the wheel and the other resting on her thigh. It’s a warm night, so we roll the windows down, and her curls dance in the breeze. She tells me about school and her friends, and funny stories that make me laugh and forget about all the bloodshed today. The way Emilio screamed, and the smell of burning flesh.

Lucy makes all of it fade away.

We end up at Giorgio’s Diner, a vibrant, old-fashioned place with red booths and a jukebox. All the kids from St. Peter’s and St. Agatha’s hang out here. As we enter, I take a quick look around.

Antonio and Giovanni catch my eye, friends I went to school with whose fathers are Dad’s capos. Antonio’s father was the one who shot Emilio in the head. Their knowing expressions tell me that they heard what went down tonight. I’ll catch up with them later to discuss it when Lucy’s safely tucked up in bed.

My eyes keep moving. Ariana is in a booth, giggling with her friends over milkshakes. Rafael Lucania is in another booth with some friends, wearing a tight white T-shirt that shows off the ink covering his arms and throat, and his blond hair is shaved at the sides. He’s a son of the Lucania don, who is currently serving a life sentence. Their family is shattered, and their fortunes are low, but most damning of all, at least as far as Mom is concerned, is that the Lucanias are from the wrong side of the tracks.

Rafael raises his chin to me in greeting, and I nod back. I don’t know what a Lucania is doing on Barone turf, but I don’t dislike the Lucanias, and he’s not unwelcome—if he behaves himself.

Lucy waves to a clutch of her friends across the room and slides into an empty booth. I slide in beside her, not in front of her, needing to be close. The smell of burning flesh is still lingering in my nostrils, and I’m not ready to be more than a foot away from her.

We order burgers and fries. Lucy gets ketchup on her finger and tries to put it on my nose. We tussle for a moment, and then she dabs it on her own nose. I lick it off, making her giggle.

My heart feels lighter than it has all day.

“What the fuck, Damiano?”

A shrill female voice cuts through our moment. I turn and see that there’s a young woman in a tight dress standing at the end of our booth.

“We had plans, and you stood me up to go out with someone else?”

Oh, right. I did make plans to go out tonight, but it was nearly a week ago, and I forgot. Between Emilio’s execution and thinking about Lucy, I have no room in my head for whatever her name is.

“Jessica, this is my sister, Lucy. Lucy, this is—”

The woman looks angrier than ever. “Who’s Jessica? I’m *Faith*.”

“Sorry. Lucy, this is Faith.”

“Hey, Faith.” Lucy’s fighting a smile, which annoys Faith even more.

“Don’t think I’m falling for that *this is my sister* crap.”

I level a dark gaze at her, and I see her flinch slightly. “Are you calling me a liar?”

Faith looks put out, and mutters, “Well, you two don’t look very brother-sisterly.”

Through a twist of fate, Lucy and I share similar facial features. The same brown eyes, defined cheekbones, tilted-up noses, and Cupid’s-bow lips. Our hair is curly, though mine is rich brown, and Lucy’s is golden. The starkest difference between us is that I am tall and muscular while Lucy is small and slender, though people put that difference down to our genders.

But Faith isn’t talking about our looks. She’s annoyed that my arm is around Lucy’s bare waist. We look like brother and sister, but we’re not acting like she thinks a brother and sister should act.

My hand tightens on Lucy’s waist possessively. The other rests on the table, and Lucy covers it with her own. I turn my hand over so she can stroke my palm, and she meshes her fingers through mine.

The gesture is intimate and tender, and I don’t pull away.

“I’m busy, Jessica. I’ll call you later.”

“Don’t bother.” She strides off, calling over her shoulder, “You’re an asshole, Damiano Barone.”

“You called her Jessica again,” Lucy points out, amused.

“Oh, well.” I hold a fry to Lucy’s lips, and she bites into it. As she chews, I put the other half in my mouth.

“Did you call her the wrong name on purpose, or are you dating so many women that you can’t keep track?”

“Maybe. Maybe not.” I give her a sly smile. Is that a spark of irritation in Lucy’s eyes? Is my sister being as possessive over me as I am over her? She’s never been jealous before.

I think I like it.

“You torture me until I can’t breathe because I might have a date tonight, while apparently you’re out here being a—”

I grasp her shoulders suddenly and push her back against the diner wallpaper. She’s pinned in by the booth, the table, and me. “A what?” I whisper, a smirk on my lips, which are very close to hers. “What am I, sis?”

We’re so close that our bodies are pressed together. I can feel the heat of her skin through the thin fabric of her top. Her eyes narrow in playful accusation. “A troublemaker.”

I glance at her mouth, and those soft, pink lips, and then back up at her eyes. “Who, me? I’m the glue holding this family together.”

“You didn’t answer my question,” she says, and I feel her breath on my mouth. “The one I asked back at the house. Are we in the mafia?”

Fear makes my heart rate spike. I don’t know what Dad would do to us if he finds out that Lucy is asking dangerous questions. If she’s asking me, she might start asking other people, and if it gets back to him that Lucy can’t keep her mouth shut, I don’t like to imagine what might happen.

“We are out for a nice dinner. We are a brother and sister who love each other very much. We look out for each other no matter what. That’s what we are. What I do, what Dad does, you don’t have to worry about.”

A frustrated line forms between her brows. “Either we’re both in the mafia, or neither of us are. I’m your sister.”

“You’re my adorable, fierce, beautiful little sister.” I rub the tip of my nose against hers, keeping my voice low. “Who doesn’t ask questions about the mafia. Malus is a dangerous city. Stay close to home, and don’t grow up too fast. I like knowing where you are all the time and that your life is school, your books, shopping, and your friends.”

Her eyes flash with annoyance. “I’m sixteen. Why must you treat me like I’m still a child?”

I take a deep breath and let it out slowly, my gaze running over her face. Because it's comforting for me. Because if she stays innocent, she's safe. Because I can't bear the thought of my world touching her.

"This is the life I wanted for you when Mom and Dad came for us," I remind her. "You have everything you want, and if there's something more you need, I'll get it for you. I just wish I'd realized back then..."

For a moment, the light in my heart dims.

Would I have agreed for us to be adopted by the Barones if I knew who our father really was?

No, I wouldn't have. I would never have brought Lucy into such a dangerous family willingly.

But it's too late now. I brought us into this world, so now it's my job to shield Lucy from it.

"You wish you'd realized what?" Lucy asks, but I barely hear her.

The diner door opens, and I glance over out of habit, checking on who's entering the room that contains the person I love most in the world.

Every muscle in my body tenses.

What the fuck do they think they're doing?

Three men in their early twenties have just entered the diner. Dangerous men with hard faces and violence glinting in their eyes. The spider tattoos on their hands and necks tell me all I need to know.

Sokolis.

Come to start shit here because Emilio couldn't keep his goddamn mouth shut. Invading the place where I've brought my sixteen-year-old, unarmed and vulnerable, sister.

Anger hotter than that poker fresh from the fire burns through me. How fucking dare they breathe the same air as her?

My arm tightens around Lucy. "I need to get you out of here."

"Who are they?"

"Sokoli drug dealers."

I have never seen them so deep in Barone territory, or so blatantly.

"Drugs?" Lucy whispers, her voice rising anxiously. Both of us get tense when drugs come up. It reminds us of where we came from.

"Antonio will take you home."

Antonio is already out of his seat and on his way to me, but before he can reach us, one of the Sokoli men comes over to my booth. As he does,

everyone in the restaurant falls silent. Both his hands are in the pockets of his black bomber jacket, and most likely he's holding a concealed gun.

The other two Sokoli men are standing by the front door, blocking the exit. The owner has come out from behind the counter, but he's frozen in place, uncertain what to do. He won't call the cops, but I know he's wishing there were more Barone men here than just me, Antonio, and Giovanni.

The Sokoli stops in front of us with a nasty smile on his face. "I've seen your picture. You're the don's son, pretty boy."

I can't say the same about him. He's got looks that would be improved by a beating.

I turn so Lucy is shielded by my body, but I can feel her peeping out behind me. "This is Barone territory. You're not welcome here."

He jerks his chin at Lucy. "Who's your pretty bitch, Barone?"

My eyes narrow, and an icy cold clarity settles over me. If bullets start flying, innocent people are going to get hurt, but I am going to make this man bleed.

When I don't say anything, he continues in a conversational tone. "Your man had a message for us, and so we have a message for your darling dad. We're going to eat the Barones alive, starting with his little whore daughters —"

Rage explodes inside me.

I slide out of the booth, seize his shoulders, and ram my knee into his nuts.

The man doubles over with a pained *oof*, and the gun falls out of his pocket. I kick it away. A silver fork is glinting on the table. I snatch it up and ram it into the Sokoli's mouth, stabbing him through the tongue.

He screams in the back of his throat and struggles, but I keep him bent double with a hand gripping the back of his neck.

"We haven't been properly introduced. I'm Damiano Barone, and you've scared my sister and called her a bitch and a whore, you piece of shit."

I take a quick glance around the restaurant. Lucy is still behind me in the booth, gazing in surprise at the fork I have rammed down the Sokoli's throat. Antonio and Giovanni have closed in on the Sokoli's two friends, keeping them away from me while I deal with their boss. Rafael Lucania has joined them, and he has one of the men shoved against the wall with a tattooed hand wrapped around his throat and a dangerous glint in his eye.

Unexpected help, but I'll take it.

"Apologize," I snarl to the man trying futilely to pull the fork from his mouth and get away from me. I twist the fork, making the Sokoli scream. "Say you're sorry to my sister, or I'll rip your tongue out."

"Mrrrm err-ry," is all the man manages to say. Blood is pouring from his lips and down his chin.

I twist the fork again. "You tell your boss that if he sends anyone else into Barone territory, we won't make you apologize. We'll kill you on sight. Now fuck off."

I yank the fork out of his mouth and shove him toward the exit.

Someone passes me a paper napkin, and I wipe the blood from my hand. The man staggers away, spattering wet, red drops on the black-and-white floor. Rafael, Antonio, and Giovanni push the three Sokolis out the front door.

I turn back to Lucy. My expression transforms from fury into concern as I cup her face. "Are you all right?"

My sister is glaring indignantly after the Sokoli. "How dare he come here. He was going to hurt us, wasn't he?"

"He was going to try."

"Then I'm glad you hurt him first."

I smile and caress her cheek with my thumb. That's my girl. Fierce and unafraid. "I'll be back in a moment, and then I'll take you home."

As I turn away from Lucy, I see her best friend, Adora Montoni, slip into the seat opposite and reach for her hand. Adora's father is Don Agnello, and the Montonis are a crime family the Barones are on good terms with. Unlike the Lucanias, Mom says the Montonis are "our" kind of people. Well dressed, wealthy, and with a veneer of respectability. Barones and Montonis pay the right people to stay on the right side of the law.

I tell Antonio and Giovanni to follow the Sokolis and make sure they leave our territory without causing any more trouble, and they head out.

Rafael is by the door, and I clasp his hand. "Thanks for the backup."

"Anytime. Nice work with the cutlery, Barone," he says with a smile.

"I forgot my knife. Had to improvise."

I approach the owner and apologize profusely for the disturbance. The man is in his fifties and has every right to tell me to get out, but because of my father, he's deferential, shaking my hand in a double clasp and even

trying to apologize to me. “Damiano Barone, you are welcome here any time.”

I take a wad of money out of my wallet and thrust it into the tip jar to make amends, nod to the waiters, and make my way back to Lucy.

She’s perched on her booth seat like a princess, back straight, eyes clear as she and Adora talk. I wouldn’t mind if she cried or trembled because of what just happened. I’d be more than happy to comfort her, but seeing her like this, so poised after coming face to face with danger...

The world fades away as I stare at her. Maybe she’s more grown up than I thought.

I study her profile, her soft lips and her bright eyes. Her beautiful, elegant throat. I crave to kiss her just below her jaw and feel her heart racing against my lips.

My sister is forbidden fruit, and I can’t want anything of the sort.

I lean down to give her a chaste kiss on the cheek. At the same time Lucy turns her head toward me to say something, and my lips crash into hers.

Time stops.

Her mouth is as sweet and soft as a daydream. Her lower lip is caught between mine, and I feel my eyelashes flutter. Every nerve ending in my body lights up like fireworks. I breathe in her exhale, and it feels like coming home.

My eyes start to close. I want to deepen the kiss. I want to slide my hand into her hair, pull her closer, and taste her properly.

A groan rises up my throat, hungry, desperate, and full of need that I’ve been suppressing for longer than I want to admit.

An alarm blares in the back of my mind. I’m kissing Lucy. *Fuck.*

I tear my lips from Lucy’s, and she gasps. I stare into her startled, beautiful face. Her mouth is very red and swollen from the brief contact. Her pupils have expanded, and a blush has spread over her cheeks. She’s breathing fast.

Twin lances of red-hot desire and panic shoot through me.

Nobody saw that, right?

I take a quick glance around, and my stomach drops.

Everyone has been staring at me since I rammed a fork down the Sokoli’s throat. They watched me defend my sister.

And they watched me kiss her.

It was a mistake. A *mistake*. I was aiming for her cheek. She turned her head at the wrong moment.

But from where everyone else is standing, it looks like I kissed my sister on the mouth on purpose, and I didn't pull away fast enough.

I can see shock and confusion in everyone's faces. The careful way that Antonio and Giovanni are averting their eyes from us, because they've probably suspected for a while that Lucy and I are closer than we should be.

Adora's eyes are wide, her hand frozen in midair as she was reaching for her milkshake.

"We need to go," I say roughly, reaching for Lucy's hand.

Lucy slides out of the booth, and I'm acutely aware of how everyone's eyes follow us as we move toward the door. I keep my body between her and the rest of the diner, shielding her from their stares.

Antonio catches my arm as we pass. "Damiano—"

"Not now," I say sharply.

We push through the door into the cool night air, and I don't stop walking until we're around the corner, away from the windows, away from prying eyes.

Lucy leans against the brick wall of the building, breathing hard. "Damiano, what just happened?"

"That was a mistake," I say, but the words feel rough in my throat. "I'm sorry."

"A mistake," she repeats flatly.

I run my hands through my hair, pacing. "I was aiming for your cheek. You turned your head. It was an accident."

"Was it?" she asks so fiercely that I stop pacing and look at her.

Her curls are wild around her face, and her lips are still red from my kiss. She looks beautiful, brave, and defiant.

"Lucy—"

"Because it didn't feel like an accident to me, Damiano." She takes a step toward me. "It felt like something we've both been wanting for a long time."

My heart is racing. "Don't."

"Don't what? Tell the truth?"

"We can't do this." I take her shoulders, and I'm gripping too hard. "You know why. If Mom and Dad discover that we've been lying to them all this time, they won't just throw you out, Lucy. They'll kill you."

I should be saying *I don't want you*. A lie to protect her life, if not her heart.

But that's too painful, and all I can manage is *we can't*.

"Do you understand?" I shake her slightly, desperate to make her see. "The lie protects you. As long as everyone believes you're my sister, you're safe. You're untouchable. But if that lie falls apart..."

"They'll kill me," she whispers.

"Yes." The word is bitter on my tongue. "You know Dad doesn't tolerate deception. And you'd be a liability. A loose end. Someone who knows too much and has no blood tie to keep her loyal."

Lucy's eyes are filling with tears, but she blinks them back fiercely. "So what are we supposed to do?"

"Nothing. That kiss was an accident. We laugh it off if anyone mentions it, and we never, ever do that again."

"Even though we both wanted it."

I breathe in sharply.

It's not a question. It's a statement of fact, and I can't deny it.

She looks down at her hands, and when she speaks, her voice is small. "I've loved you since I was twelve years old. Not as a brother. I need you to know that."

My heart thumps painfully.

Tell her you don't feel the same. Lie to her. Protect her.

But the words won't come.

I'm so tired of pretending. So tired of watching her smile at other people and knowing I can never have her. So tired of the jealousy, and of lying in bed at night, knowing she's just down the hall, but I'll never be able to touch her the way I want to.

"I know it's wrong," she continues. "I know we can't be together. But I needed to say it out loud at least once. I love you, Damiano. And that kiss wasn't an accident for me."

I'm gripping her shoulders so hard I'm probably leaving bruises, but I can't make myself let go. Every cell in my body is screaming at me to pull her close, to kiss her properly, to tell her that I love her too. That every girl I've dated has been a pale substitute for the one girl I can never have.

But if I do that, we're both dead.

"Lucy. I need you to understand something. The only reason you're alive right now is because everyone believes you're my sister. That lie is the

only thing keeping you safe from our father, from the Sokolis, from everyone in this world who would use you to hurt me.”

“I know.”

“And if I love you—” The words slip out before I can stop them. “If I love you the way I want to love you, we both die.”

Her eyes snap to mine, wide and shocked. “You love me?”

Fuck. Fuck, fuck, *fuck*.

But there’s no taking it back now.

“Of course I love you,” I say roughly. “You’re my Lucy. You’re the only person in this world who matters to me. I’ve loved you since you were ten years old and too scared to eat breakfast unless I was holding you. I’ve loved you through every nightmare, every tear, every smile. I love you so much it’s killing me.”

A tear spills down her cheek. “Then why—”

“Because loving you means protecting you. Even if that protection is *from* me. Especially if it’s from me.” I cup her face with shaking hands, wiping away the tear with my thumb. “I wouldn’t survive losing you. But I’d rather live without you than get you killed because I was too selfish to let you go.”

A sob rises in her throat. “That’s not fair.”

“Nothing about this is fair.” I press my forehead to hers, breathing her in one last time. “But this is how it has to be. For now. Until I’m strong enough, powerful enough to change the rules. Until I’m Don Damiano instead of just the don’s son.”

Her hands clutch my shirt. “How long will that take?”

I look at her hopelessly. “Who knows.”

“We could be waiting forever.”

I say in a broken whisper, “I know.”

We stand there in the darkness, holding each other, both of us memorizing this moment. Because this is as close as we can get. This is all we can have.

“We have to go back,” I finally say. “People will wonder where we are.”

“I can’t go back in there. Not after...” She gestures helplessly.

“I’ll text Antonio, tell him to spread the word that you were upset after the Sokoli confrontation, and I’m taking you home. It gives us an excuse to leave, and it explains why we looked shaken when we left.”

She nods, wiping her eyes.

As we walk to my car, I keep my arm around her shoulders in what could be seen as brotherly comfort. But my thumb traces circles on her skin, and she leans into me more than necessary.

I open the car door for her, and before she gets in, she looks up at me one more time.

“Damiano?”

“Yeah?”

“When you’re the don, will things be different?”

I think about my father. About the power he wields. About how he makes the rules, how he controls everything and everyone. When I’m the don, I’ll have that power.

“Yes,” I promise her. “When I’m the don, everything will be different.”

She searches my face for a long moment, then nods and gets into the car.

As I drive us home, neither of us speaks. But my hand finds hers in the darkness, and our fingers intertwine.

We can’t kiss. We can’t be together. We can’t act on what we feel.

But we can hold hands in the dark.

And we can wait.

However long it takes.

Lucy

Four years later

The revolver kicks in my hand as bullets explode from the barrel, one after the next. The figure in front of me is struck six times in the heart.

I pull off my ear protectors and admire my handiwork. The paper target's heart is peppered with holes. Near-perfect shots at fifty feet. I bet there are made men all over Malus who can't shoot as well as me.

I've been coming to this shooting range in secret since I was sixteen, when Sokoli drug dealers invaded our territory and Damiano confessed he loved me and promised that when he became don, we'll be partners. Real partners. In everything.

I'm twenty years old now, but he's still treating me like a child who needs protecting from the big, bad world. When we were adopted, it was Damiano and me against everyone else. Then Dad made him a part of the Barone family secrets that I'm excluded from just because I'm a woman.

I'm not afraid of danger. I can handle myself as well as any man. Better than most, if I had to guess. I just have to find a way to prove it.

I'm about to reload my gun and go again when I notice the time. It's creeping toward six in the evening, and I have to be perfectly turned out and sitting at the Barone family dinner table at seven, or else there'll be hell to pay from Mom. I pack up my gear and quickly head out to my car.

It's Saturday night, and that means semi-formal attire is required at dinner. I still think that's kind of ridiculous. When I was a child, I was lucky if Mom remembered that I needed to eat dinner, let alone changing for dinner. The first night in the Barone mansion, I sat at the dining table in jeans and a T-shirt while my new mom quietly and coldly informed me that in this house I am expected to dress for dinner, smart casual on weekdays and semi-formal on the weekends. At Christmas and New Year and on family members' birthdays, festive attire is required.

I must have looked so utterly stupid and confused, because across from me, Ariana laughed behind her hand, and I wished the ground would swallow me up. My new sister took great pleasure in spelling out the new rules for me as obnoxiously as possible. I'd seen the mountains of new clothes in my beautiful new bedroom, but I'd been too overwhelmed to touch any of them, let alone try them on. I wasn't convinced that they were meant for me. The moment I touched them, I was sure that the Barones would scold me for dirtying their beautiful things. I've never been able to shake the fear that I don't belong in this house.

Tonight, I put on a slinky black velvet dress and high heels, and I fasten my curly hair into a twist at the nape of my neck. I pull a few curls loose to frame my face, because I know Damiano thinks I look pretty that way. When I add some lipstick and a gold pendant and earring set Damiano gave me last Christmas, I look presentable.

Downstairs in the dining room, Damiano looks tense in his black suit and tie, but when he sees me, he smiles and comes forward to greet me.

"You look beautiful," he murmurs, clasping me briefly around my waist and kissing my cheek, as far from my lips as possible. He's practically kissing my ear. He's been doing this ever since he kissed me on the mouth in front of a diner full of people. Four years have passed, but I haven't forgotten one single detail of how it felt to have his lips on mine. For a delicious, heart-pounding moment, I thought he'd kissed me on purpose. That the blood and violence of the night had made him throw caution to the wind and claim what he craved.

Me.

But the second he pulled away, I saw the panic in his eyes.

He confessed he loved me that night. Promised me when he's done, we'd be together. Four years later, I'm still waiting.

Damiano's a lot more cautious with his affection these days, and it's slowly killing me. He still has nightmares and welcomes me into his bed with open arms while I soothe his terror. I kiss the sweat from his brow, and he holds me like he never wants to let go. His fingers tangle in my hair. His breath catches when I'm close.

But as soon as he's calmed down, he insists I go back to my own room. "If someone catches us," he always whispers, pain in his eyes. "If Mom or Dad finds you here..."

He loves me. I know he loves me. He told me four years ago.

But love without being together is torture.

As a family, we take our seats at the dinner table.

My gaze flickers over my brother, who is somber, distracted, and more handsome than ever. I swear he gets better-looking every time I see him. Cheekbones more defined. Dark eyes more dangerous and alluring. Body honed with muscle and his lower lip so full and soft. I've tried appreciating other men, but none of them compares to Damiano.

Mom makes polite conversation with each of us in turn, asking us about our days. Ariana is the only one who talks at any length as she discusses her upcoming riding competition. Since school, she's poured more time and energy into dressage, and apparently she's a very good rider. She's at the stables nearly every day.

Dad and Damiano give minimal answers, but Mom keeps smiling and doesn't take offense. She never pries into their work. Unlike me, she's not burning to know the details about what they get up to. I watch her as she delicately cuts a sliver of salmon and puts it in her mouth. For her, ignorance is bliss.

I grip my knife and fork. How can she live like this? Will I have to be like this one day, a perfect, idiotic, smiling mafia wife?

The only time Mom's serene expression falters is when Dad's phone rings. He apologizes to her, checks the screen, and then gets to his feet. "I have to take this."

There's a small frown between her brows as her eyes follow him out of the room, but she doesn't scold him. She puts her knife and fork down, and she won't resume eating until he returns.

If I had to be her for even one day, I think I'd go mad.

I grimace, because in a way, I am her every day. I'm also putting down my knife and fork to wait for Dad, because if I don't, Mom will scold me. This isn't my house, and so it's not my choice. When I'm married, will my husband expect me to behave the same way as Mom?

I flick a look at Damiano, which he doesn't notice because he's staring distractedly after Dad. There's an ache in my chest. I know what my ideal life would be, because Damiano promised it to me four years ago. Him as don. Me as his partner, not his secret. Discussing family business over dinner instead of being excluded. Children together. Freedom.

Sometimes I wonder if he regrets his confession, and if he wishes he could take it back.

Dad thrusts his head back into the dining room. "Damiano, I need you."

My brother gets to his feet and goes to Dad, closing the door behind him, sparing not even one glance at me.

There's a member of staff attending us, and Mom says, "Mrs. Monti, will you please tell the cook to hold the main course until my husband returns?"

"Yes, Mrs. Barone." Mrs. Monti nods and leaves the room.

Mom takes a placid sip of her wine. Ariana sits back and looks bored. I can hear Dad and Damiano talking not far away, but their voices are muffled.

I get up from my seat, earning a frown from Mom, and saunter toward the window as though I want to look out into the garden. Really, I'm straining to hear what's being said on the other side of the door.

The voices are a little clearer here. Dad and Damiano are speaking about the Norris Street warehouse. I didn't know we had a Norris Street warehouse. There was a break-in, or the alarm was tripped? I'm not sure, but the security system is down, and Dad doesn't like that. I step closer to the door, practically pressing my ear against it in my desperation to hear what's being said.

"Lucy, sit down," Mom says sharply.

I quickly swerve my attention to the window and twitch the curtain aside to gaze at the empty garden. "I'm just looking out the window."

What I want to say is, *Will you be quiet? I'm trying to eavesdrop.*

Dad and Damiano must have stepped away because they become even harder to hear. What Norris Street warehouse? What's stored there? Why is

it important?

Behind me radiates cold fury. I glance at Mom, and her eyes are narrowed. “Do you think your future husband will put up with back talk and disobedience from you? I’m trying to protect you from the consequences of your own actions.”

My stomach lurches. She’s been dropping that phrase more often lately, and it scares me. *Your future husband*. No man is taking me away from Damiano. “What consequences?”

Ariana gives me a pitying look. “Mom means that when you piss off your future husband as much as you piss us off, he won’t put up with it. He’ll beat you.”

“Language, darling,” Mom murmurs. “We’re at the dinner table.”

I grip the windowsill. “No one would dare lay a finger on me. Damiano would kill him.”

“Sure, you could cry to your brother,” Ariana says with a cruel smile. “But what good will it do? You’ll belong to your husband.”

My stomach clenches. Damiano won’t let that happen. He can’t.

But every year that passes, I’m more afraid that Dad will arrange my marriage before Damiano has the power to stop it.

“Damiano would never take any side but mine,” I say, but my voice wavers, because what if Ariana’s right? What if when it comes down to it, Damiano chooses the family over me? He says he loves me, but does he love me enough?

Ariana is enjoying herself now—and smiling from ear to ear. “Once you’re married, you won’t be Damiano’s problem anymore. He’s probably counting down the days.”

“You have no idea what you’re talking about,” I whisper, because my chest is suddenly too tight to draw breath. Maybe she’s right. Damiano barely looks at me anymore. I hate that Ariana’s cruel words are hitting their mark.

“I wonder who you’ll marry,” Ariana muses out loud. “Someone Dad chooses, of course. As a woman, getting married is the only useful thing you can do for this family.” Ariana’s smile turns bitter, and I realize that the truth is painful for her.

Mom looks meaningfully at my empty chair. “Know your place, Lucy.”

She didn’t refute anything Ariana said. She didn’t promise to come to my defense if my future husband beats me. She just sipped her wine and

gazed at me with resentful eyes. She's never loved me. The only person in the whole world who loves me is Damiano.

"I'm aware of my place in this house," I mutter, staying where I am.

"I said. Sit. *Down*."

I resume my seat, my eyes lowered so she can't see how hurt and angry I am. What Ariana described can't really be my future, can it? I don't want to get married and have some stranger pawing at my body and suffocating me with his kisses and demands.

"We are Barone women," Mom says, addressing both me and Ariana, but mostly me. "It is our duty to support the men in our life with love and affection. We soothe their worries. We make a beautiful home for them to return to. Knowing more than we should is dangerous for us and for them."

I blink innocently at Mom and smile a fake smile. "But why? What's so dangerous about Dad working in real estate?"

Behind her beautifully painted lips, Mom grits her teeth. To this day, no one has admitted out loud to me that Dad is Don Carlucci, head of the Barone crime family. I'm supposed to pretend I don't know. Not hear the whispers. Not notice the guns and looks of fearful respect Dad draws wherever he goes.

"Lucy, you don't need to know why something is dangerous. It's enough that we tell you that it is, and you should listen and obey."

Listen and obey. Always listen and obey, and keep my mouth shut. Never complain when I'm excluded from everything my brother is allowed to know. I miss him. I love him. I'm so freaking *jealous* of him.

"Just say why it's dangerous being us," I snap. "Because we're in the mafia."

Mom's eyes flash. "Go to your room. I won't look at you for another second. And don't you dare try and eavesdrop on your father and brother. Mrs. Monti? Escort her, please."

Mrs. Monti has returned from the kitchen, and she moves to my side with reproachful eyes. Angry tears cluster in my throat as I stand up, and Mrs. Monti walks me from the room.

As we climb the stairs, Mrs. Monti says, softly but urgently, "You shouldn't provoke your mother, miss. I don't know what you think you'll get out of angering her."

I don't know either, but the truth would be nice. Not that we're in the mafia, because that's blindingly obvious, and it's laughable that we're not

even allowed to say it out loud in our own home. What I'm hoping for is that she'll snap and tell me that she and Dad never wanted to adopt me in the first place, and that Damiano talked them into it. I'm hoping for a knife in my own heart, but I can't help it. Pretending that I'm welcome here is tearing me apart.

From my bedroom window, I watch Damiano's car leave the garage, red taillights glowing in the darkness and vanishing out of the gates as he turns up the street. Loneliness expands inside me, making it painful to breathe. I remember another set of taillights disappearing into the distance. Running after them. Screaming and crying as I begged not to be left behind.

I can't keep waiting. I can't keep being patient while Damiano asks me to trust him. Four years of secret glances and whispered *I love yous* when no one can hear. Four years of nightmares where he holds me and then sends me away. Four years of promises that nothing has changed.

I need to prove I can be his partner now. Not someday when he's done. *Now.*

Because if I don't prove my worth, if I can't show him I'm strong enough to stand beside him, what if he decides it's easier to let me go?

My heart pounding, I change out of my dress, heels, and jewelry, and put on black pants, a black sweater, and a black jacket. I take my gun out of a drawer, the gun that no one knows I have, and I put it into my jacket pocket.

Careful not to be seen by anyone, I slip through the house, into the garage, and get into my dark blue sports car. Damiano's too far away to tail him, but I think I know where he's gone. I plug "Norris Street" into my navigation app, and I follow the directions.

Twenty-five minutes later, I'm on a darker, dingier side of Malus that I've never been before. There are run-down factories, abandoned houses, and warehouses with empty lots. Just the kind of unassuming place you might want to store stolen goods. I drive slowly with my lights off, so I'm not noticed, and as soon as I see my brother's car parked up ahead, I pull over and cut the engine.

Damiano is standing by the road, speaking to two tough-looking men. They're ten or even twenty years older than Damiano, but they all seem to know each other, and they take instructions from my brother and answer his questions. I wish I knew what they were talking about.

I get out of my car and slip through the shadows toward them. Once I've heard enough of their conversation and what the problem is, I'll step forward and tell my brother I'm here to help. I belong by his side.

Him and me, that's what he promised me all those years ago.

The three men turn and head toward the warehouse. All is silent apart from the sound of my own breathing as I enter the lot and skirt the shadows by the fence. I'm keeping so close an eye on my brother that I trip on a piece of broken concrete and send it skittering across the ground.

The two strangers keep walking, but Damiano draws his gun and turns around. I duck down behind some discarded pallets, and peer through a gap at my brother. He slowly scans the empty lot, and he spies the pallets. His eyes narrow as he walks toward me.

I suck in a breath, feeling like a trapped rabbit. Damiano's armed and primed for danger. If I make one wrong move, I'm going to get a bullet.

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Damiano

Dad's orders are ringing in my ears as I approach the warehouse with Aldo and Giuseppe. *Protect Barone assets at all costs. Now is not the time for people to think they can take what belongs to us.*

He doesn't need to tell me twice. No one's going to take what's mine.

Power in Malus is shifting. Don Agnello Montoni was a powerful Barone ally, but now he's dead. Cristiano Montoni is the new Montoni don, and he hasn't made his loyalties clear. To old families, like ours? To his sister's husband's family, the Vici? Vincenzo Vici places no trust in allies of the man who slaughtered his family, and that could include us if we get too friendly with Don Cristiano. Meanwhile, the Sokolis are circling us like sharks.

The night is still and silent, until I hear the sound of a rock tumbling across the lot behind me. Aldo and Giuseppe keep walking toward the warehouse, but I turn around and take my gun out, hunting the darkness for any sign of movement.

I know someone has been here because the silent alarms were set off. Surely they can't still be here.

Behind me, Dad's soldiers open the heavy warehouse door, turn the lights on, and go inside. Yellow light floods the shadows and illuminates the lot. I keep moving forward, away from the warehouse and toward a stack of pallets to one side of the lot, partly overgrown by weeds.

A telltale shadow is cast across the ground. There's someone hiding behind those pallets. Fucking hell. Whoever broke in is still here, and I point my gun at them.

From inside the warehouse, I hear, "Aldo, is that a trip w—"

The night is ripped apart.

There's a deafening explosion, and heat scorches the nape of my neck. I'm flung forward, and I lose my grip on my gun.

Firelight is raging all around me. It's my goddamn nightmare.

As the fire roars and my head swims, I watch Lucy running into that meth house as it explodes in flames and shattered glass, over and over.

I push myself up onto my elbows and try to get my feet under me. Then there are hands on me, pulling me to my feet. Rough, violent hands.

"The Barone prince himself. Can you believe it, boys? We nearly turned the don's son into cat food."

There are nasty snickers all around me. The hands seizing me are decorated with spider tattoos.

Sokolis.

My already racing heart doubles its speed. I have no weapon, and my soldiers are dead. When Dad doesn't hear from us, he'll know something's happened, but it will be too late by then. If the Sokolis are emboldened to set deadly mantraps in our warehouses, I'm screwed.

Someone drives a van into the lot, and they drag me over to it and open the back. The dark, bare, dirty interior yawns like a tomb.

They sit me on the edge of the van with a gun to my head while they argue about my fate. Torture me, kill me, or ransom me? They look like demons with flames at their backs and the smoke belching into the night sky. Their shrill laughter and the screams of dying meth addicts echo in my ears. The stench of burning flesh reaches my nose, and my stomach rolls.

One of the men turns to me and gives me a shove. "Who's Daddy dear allying with? The Montonis? The Vicis? Or is he going it alone?"

I finally recognize the man looming over me. He has a slight lisp, because once I shoved a fork through his tongue for upsetting Lucy. When I don't answer, he punches me in the face. I blink and shake my head to clear my vision.

Then I see her.

A woman walking toward us with the warehouse blaze at her back and her body outlined in flames. A vision so beautiful that I can't breathe.

An angel.

Made from pure fire.

The men surrounding me have no idea she's behind them. She raises her hand, and for a split second I wonder if she's beckoning me. If she's come to take me to heaven.

But I'm not dead, and this isn't the rapture.

She's got a gun.

Shots burst in the night. Two of the men crumple to the ground. The third, the Sokoli I warned never to set foot on Barone territory again, starts to turn and raise his gun. To point it at my angel.

With a roar, I ram my fist into the man's stomach, and then several times in the face, slicing open my knuckles on his teeth. Wrestling the gun from him, I shoot him twice in the chest. My whole body is shaking. The fire, the explosion, and the terrible memories have sent adrenaline racing through my body.

There's a broken bottle on the ground. I snatch it up, hold it by the neck, and thrust the jagged end into the man's mouth.

"I warned you I'd take your fucking tongue," I seethe, twisting the broken glass in his mouth. I slice his cheeks and his tongue, grinding the glass into his face.

I feel a hand on my back. A voice I love dearly calling my name. I want to obliterate this man from the face of the earth. I pull the broken glass out, then stab him again. The Sokoli screams and stops moving, but I keep slamming the jagged glass into his face.

"Damiano, he's dead." A slender hand touches mine, and finally, the red mist recedes.

I throw the glass aside and snatch Lucy into my arms.

"Lucy. My love. My love." My arms are locked around her as my body shudders in relief. She's all right. She's here.

Lucy presses kisses all over my face. Her cheeks are wet with tears. "You could have been killed. I nearly lost you. If you had gone into that warehouse as well..."

We can't hold each other tight enough. Our hearts are desperate to be inside each other's bodies.

She was the one hiding behind the pallets. She followed me here. I seize her upper arms. "You could have been killed. Why did you come here?"

“Because here is exactly where I need to be,” she says fiercely. “I know we’re in the mafia. I’ll work with you. We’ll protect each other. I’ll never leave your side ever again. Never.”

I sit down on the edge of the open van with a groan and wrap my arms around her waist, burying my face in her breasts. She’s all for me. All for me, and no one else. My beautiful, untouchable secret. “If only that could be true.”

“Damiano, remember who we are. We can have whatever we want.”

“It’s too dangerous. Dad won’t allow it.”

“Dad doesn’t have to know.”

I open my eyes. A thrill goes through me. Are we talking about work, or are we talking about something else? One of my hands is curved around her waist. The other—fuck, my hand is on her ass. I should pull away. But after four years of denying myself, I can’t. Not yet. She eases herself onto my lap, her knees straddling my hips, and any remaining willpower I had evaporates.

“I’m stronger than you think, and you want me with you,” she whispers.

I smooth her hair back and look deep into her eyes. Want her with me? Or just want her? As I hold her tighter, she pants softly, and I feel myself getting hard. Lucy smells like gunpowder and sweet, forbidden fruit. She didn’t pull away the first time I kissed her. I wonder if she’d pull away if I kissed her now.

I swallow hard. “We can’t. That kind of talk is dangerous.”

“We’re the dangerous ones. I killed for my brother, just like you’d kill for me.”

I look past her at the dead men. At the bullet wounds. Headshots, clean and precise. I didn’t know Lucy had the nerve to fire a gun, let alone kill two men. No hesitation, and with a single bullet each.

Lucy is incredible.

She takes my face in her hands and teases her lips just over mine. “One day you’ll be the head of this family, Damiano. Dad won’t matter anymore. You’ll make the rules, and you can have anything you want.”

The words hang between us, heavy with promise and danger. Her lips are so close to mine I can feel her breath. The warehouse burns behind us, casting dancing shadows across her beautiful face. Smoke billows into the night sky, and somewhere in the distance, sirens begin to wail.

I should pull away. I should put distance between us before we do something we can't take back.

Instead, I groan like a man in pain and pull her mouth down to mine.

The kiss is nothing like that accidental brush of lips in the diner years ago. This is desperate and raw. I kiss her like I'm drowning and she's air. I've been waiting my whole life for this moment and can't wait another second.

Lucy gasps against my mouth, and then she's kissing me back just as fiercely. Her fingers tangle in my hair. Her body presses against mine, all soft curves and deadly strength. I taste smoke and salt and something essentially her that makes my head spin.

My hand fists in her hair while the other grips her hip. I can't get close enough to her. I want to crawl inside her skin and never leave.

When we finally break apart, we're both gasping for breath. I rest my forehead against hers, my eyes squeezed shut, trying to get control of myself.

"Lucy," I breathe. "Fuck. We can't do this."

"We just did."

"We can't do this again." My hands are still holding her close, contradicting my words. "Not like this, surrounded by corpses and burning buildings." I open my eyes and look at her, trying to make her understand. "When I make you mine, it won't be in hiding. I'm going to find a way for us to be together. Really together."

Her eyes search my face. "How? Dad will never allow it."

"I don't know yet." I cup her face in my hands, my thumbs stroking her cheekbones. "But I swear to you, Lucy. I'll find a way."

The sirens are getting louder. We don't have much time, but I can't seem to let her go.

"The Sokolis," Lucy says, and I hear the steel in her voice. "This wasn't random, was it? They set a trap."

I nod grimly. "They could have blown up the warehouse, but instead they tripped the silent alarm and waited until there were Barones inside."

"They're getting bolder." Her hands rest on my chest, and I can feel my heart pounding beneath her palms. "This isn't just about territory anymore, Damiano. They're trying to kill us one by one. They nearly killed you."

She's right. The realization sits heavy in my gut.

Lucy leans back to look at me properly. In the firelight, I can see the determination in her eyes, the fierce intelligence that's always drawn me to her. "We need to be smarter. Stronger."

"That's why I want to build alliances with Vincenzo, Rafiel, and Cristiano."

"Let me help you." She takes my hand, lacing our fingers together. "With everything. Two sets of eyes, two minds working together. We're stronger together than apart."

I start to shake my head, ready to tell her it's too dangerous, but she cuts me off.

"I just killed two men to save your life. Don't tell me I can't handle the danger. Don't protect me from the world we live in. Let me stand beside you."

I stare at her, this woman who's been by my side since we were children. Who followed me into danger tonight without hesitation. Who killed for me without flinching.

She's right. We are stronger together.

"All right," I say finally. "But we do this carefully. Dad can't know you're involved in family business beyond what he approves. He can't know you're armed or that you followed me here." I pause, my thumb brushing over her swollen lips. "That we kissed. When I make you mine, it won't be in hiding like this," I repeat.

She nods, though I can see the reluctance in her eyes. Hiding what we are to each other is the hardest thing I'm asking of her.

I pull her close again, needing to feel her against me. "Then we work together against the Sokolis. Against anyone who threatens us. But we also work toward finding a way for us to be together."

Her smile is small but fierce. "I've been waiting for you my whole life, Damiano. I can wait a little longer. As long as I know you're working toward us."

"Always. But we have to be careful. If Dad suspects there's more than brotherly and sisterly love between us—" I begin urgently.

"I understand, Damiano. But that doesn't change what you promised me."

I press my lips to her forehead, breathing in her scent beneath the smoke. "Then we have a pact. Together against the world."

"Together," she echoes, her arms tightening around me. "Always."

The sirens are very close now. I help Lucy off my lap and we both stand. My legs aren't quite steady. In the distance, red and blue lights are starting to flash against the buildings.

We pull apart reluctantly. I open the passenger door for her, and she slides inside. As I drive us away from the burning warehouse, away from the sirens and the dead men, I reach over and take her hand, threading our fingers together on the center console.

Everything has changed tonight, and we've crossed a line we can never uncross. Despite the danger we're in, or maybe because of it, I've never felt more certain of anything in my life.

This woman is mine. And I'm hers.



I MOAN SOFTLY as I awaken. My bed smells like Lucy. She came to me after another nightmare, just like she did when we were children.

I shift on the mattress, and the sheets drag against my hard cock. I linger over the memory of Lucy's delectable body in my lap as she let me squeeze her ass and press my face into her soft breasts. The way she kissed me back with desperate hunger, surrounded by fire and death. The way she looked at me when I promised her we'd find a way to be together. Really together.

With my eyes still closed, I push the sheet down and wrap my hand around my morning erection. I squeeze and stroke myself, groaning softly, remembering Lucy's lips on mine as she whispered that we can have whatever we want. I stroke my hot, hard flesh, imagining that Lucy's mouth is wrapped around my shaft as she sucks me.

Something moves in my bed that's not me.

I freeze and open my eyes. Not one foot from me, Lucy is laying on her side facing me. I've dragged the sheet from her body as well, and she's dressed in one of my T-shirts that's as long as a dress on her, and her legs are bare.

Her eyes are wide open, without a hint of embarrassment that she's caught me jerking off.

A smile tugs at her lips. "Don't stop. Pretend I'm not here."

"Fuck. What are you doing?" I hiss in a whisper. "I can't pretend you're not here."

“Then enjoy that I’m here.”

I’m frozen with my hand wrapped around the head of my swollen cock. She openly watches me, not one trace of embarrassment or shame on her beautiful face. Blood pounds in my ears and throbs in my dick. She looks so beautiful with her golden curls spread out on my pillow. She’s so close that I can feel the heat from her body.

“I dare you to keep going,” she whispers.

“You should be in your own bed,” I seethe, trying to pretend I’m angry to mask the rapid beating of my heart.

“That’s the thanks I get for comforting you in the middle of the night? It’s not my fault that you fell asleep with your arms locked around me.”

The sleepy memory of my darkened bedroom and Lucy in my arms comes back to me. She woke me from a fiery nightmare, which was worse than usual after the warehouse explosion, and soothed me with kisses on my brow. I clung to her. I never wanted to let her go.

Lucy nestles closer to me and threads her fingers through my hair. Her touch sends golden sparks through me. “You’re so hard, Damiano. You must need to come very badly.”

Her touch makes me want to give in and take what I was just fantasizing about. It would take one second to tug her underwear down her legs, if she’s even wearing any, roll her beneath me, and then I’d be between her thighs.

I scramble to remember what I said last night about being patient and careful.

Lucy trails her fingers down my chest, sending warm shivers through my body. I squeeze my cock without thinking.

“Damiano, you’re a capo in the Barone crime family. One of the most powerful men in the city. You can have whatever you want.”

That would be utterly reckless, but right now I can’t think straight. Her fingers wrap around mine on my shaft, and a pleasurable shudder goes through me. “Lucy,” I breathe. “You shouldn’t do that.”

“And you shouldn’t stare at my mouth like you want to fuck it.”

My breath catches. “I do not.”

Lucy’s lips brush mine—just like last night, that teasing almost-kiss—and heat explodes through me. “Liar. You’re not subtle when you’re horny, Damiano.”

With her hand over mine, I stroke my hand down my cock and then up again with a twist. A soft groan escapes my throat. I’m always horny around

Lucy. "You can't fucking talk."

Lucy laughs softly. She strokes my cock with me, our hands moving slowly, our breathing synchronizing as a tight, pleasurable ache spreads through my lower belly. I wrap my arm around her waist and pull her closer to me.

I'm not having sex with Lucy, I tell myself. She just happens to be here while I'm getting closer and closer to bursting all over her.

"Damiano," she pants. "Kiss me."

Her lips are mine to claim. I vividly remember how good it feels to kiss Lucy. When I'm not having nightmares about fire, it's all I dream about. The way she tastes. The desperate relief and hunger.

When I make you mine, it won't be in hiding like this.

My whole body tenses and cold sweat breaks out on my back. We promised to be careful. To be patient, to find a way to be together properly. And here I am, less than twelve hours later, about to throw it all away.

Is this how little she means to me, that I would risk her safety and happiness for the sake of getting off?

"Hey, come back to me," Lucy says, touching my face.

I release her and roll onto my back, grinding the heels of my hands against my eyes. I'm crazy if I think I can sneak around this house with Lucy without our parents finding out. Dad has eyes and ears everywhere, and if he finds out the brother and sister he adopted are screwing each other and have been lying to him, he will... God, I don't know what he'd do, and that's what scares me.

"Lucy—" I start to say, and she must hear the refusal in my voice, because she speaks over me.

"I hope my boyfriend doesn't find out about this. He'll be so jealous."

My eyes snap open, and I glare at her. Lucy is casually examining her manicure.

"Boyfriend?" I ask.

She frowns in puzzlement. "Yes, my boyfriend. I told you about him."

I sit up on my elbow. "No, you didn't. What boyfriend? Who is he?"

She shrugs. "You must have forgotten about him because of all the Jessicas and Faiths you're screwing. You go on dates just about every weekend. Do you think I've been a nun all this time?"

"I go on dates for the sake of appearances. Do you know how strange it would seem if I didn't?"

I know she's provoking me on purpose, but knowing that doesn't stop me from being incandescently jealous that someone else might be enjoying what I can't have. Last night she killed for me. She kissed me like I was her whole world. She promised to wait for me.

And now she's talking about another man?

She tries to get out of my bed, but I grab her and pull her back. She again tries to leave, so I roll on top of her and trap her in my bed with my hands either side of her head. My still hard cock is pressed against her bare inner thigh.

"Admit that you're pretending about the boyfriend, and I'll let you up."

She smooths her hands up my biceps and gently drags her nails across my shoulder muscles. It feels so incredible I have to stifle a groan.

"Why would I pretend about having a boyfriend?"

Damn it, what if she's not pretending? She's beautiful, she's twenty, and even though we made a pact last night, I haven't claimed her. Maybe she thinks our promises mean nothing. "Who is he? The son of one of the capos? It had better not be Antonio or Giovanni. I'll murder them."

A smile lingers on those perfect lips of hers. "Please don't be jealous, Damiano. I worry about his safety if you notice the hickies he's left all over my body."

I breathe hard through my nose, glaring at her. She is. She's trying to wind me up. Testing me. The trouble is, it's working. The T-shirt she's wearing covers her upper arms and down to her thighs. There are no marks on her forearms or legs. I grasp her jaw and turn her head this way and that, examining her throat. "I don't see any hickies."

"Thank goodness you haven't looked very hard," she says in mock relief. "It would make you so angry to see them."

She tries to get out of my bed again, but I put my hand on her shoulder and push her back down. "You're not going anywhere until I find out if you're making this up."

I grasp her T-shirt—my T-shirt, because she's always stealing them—and slowly pull it up. She's wearing tiny white briefs, and I swallow hard at the sight of them, and admire the luscious curves of her hips.

"Admit you're making up a boyfriend before this gets embarrassing for you."

She plays her fingers across my shoulders with a smile on her lips. "No, don't. Stop it. I'm so embarrassed."

I grit my teeth. She's mocking me.

There are no hickies on her thighs or stomach. I fix her with a stern look and keep pushing her T-shirt up, waiting for the moment she cracks and tells me that she was making it up. I expose the undersides of her breasts, and all she does is pant softly and arch her back.

I should stop. This is exactly what I told her we couldn't do. But my jealousy is a living thing, clawing at my insides.

I pull the T-shirt all the way off and toss it aside. Lucy is laying beneath me topless in nothing but a pair of white underwear. Her breasts are perfect. Pink tipped and the exact right size to fit in my palm. I examine her skin and scowl at her in triumph. "There aren't any hickies."

Her eyes are bright with challenge. "I'm not anyone else's. So show me I'm yours."

"Lucy, we can't."

"Why not?" She arches beneath me, and I feel every soft curve of her body against mine. "You promised me we'd be careful where others can see us. No one can see us in your bed."

I've never been able to resist Lucy when she looks at me like this. Like I'm her whole world, she trusts me completely, and she's mine and only mine.

I kiss her. A hungry, open-mouthed kiss, my tongue plunging into her mouth like my cock is aching to do. A kiss filled with frustration and yearning. And fear, because even with my eyes closed, I have one ear on my bedroom door.

No one can find out that we're giving in to something that's been chasing us down for years. Lucy and I can't be together longer than a few moments, but while I have her, I'm going to enjoy every drop of her sweetness.

"Damiano," Lucy pants against my mouth. Her red nails score fiery marks in my back. "Damiano, please." She whispers my name with so much need as her thighs wrap around my hips.

"If I fuck you," I whisper between kisses, "am I going to pull out and see a pretty smear of blood on my cock or not?"

Blood that means she's all mine.

"Why don't you find out?"

I sink my teeth into the flesh of her shoulder, making her cry out before I smother her mouth with my hand. Why can't she just tell me? She's

driving me crazy. If this is the only way I'll know for sure if another man has touched her, I'm jealous enough to do it.

I tug her briefs down her legs, and then grasp her thigh and slowly push it up toward her breasts, hooking her knee over my shoulder. Her pussy is spread open for me. There's a bead of precum on the tip of my cock, and it's in danger of dripping into her.

"Careful what kind of game you're playing, Lucy, because I really will fuck you." I swipe the pad of my thumb over her lips. Lucy takes my thumb in her mouth, looking me in the eye while she sucks me. Her cheeks hollow, and her wet, warm tongue curls around my flesh. A spasm goes through me.

"Oh, Jesus fucking Christ, Lucy. I want you so much." She wants me too. She's so wet. The head of my cock slides against her slippery sex. I'm so close to sheathing myself inside her.

We made a promise. Be patient. Be careful.

But all I can think about is her body beneath mine.

"Prove it," Lucy whispers, rolling her hips.

I can't take it anymore. I grasp my cock and coat it in her wetness, and then I sink into her. Not far. Just an inch. Just the tip. Not as much as I want, but as much as I dare.

Nothing has ever felt this good before. My resolve is crumbling as her inner muscles squeeze the tip of my cock. I'm going to fuck her raw, and I don't even care about the consequences.

Lucy moans as her tight channel stretches around me. "Yes, Damiano. More."

Suddenly, my bedroom door flies open. "Damiano, Dad said that you're not allowed to have girls—"

My head turns fast, and so does Lucy's beneath me. Our sister is standing in my doorway. Ariana's malicious smile fades, and the color drains from her face. She thought she was going to catch me with a girlfriend in my bed. She takes in the fact that we're both naked and I'm on top of Lucy, her thigh hooked over my shoulder. She can probably see every single fucking detail about what we're doing, including that I'm an inch deep inside the woman Ariana thinks is my sister.

Ariana's eyes nearly bug out of her head. "What the hell is happening in here?"

Lucy's fingers tighten on my shoulders, and she looks afraid. Genuinely afraid like she hasn't looked since she was ten.

We're supposed to be careful, and I've just destroyed everything.

"I'm telling Mom and Dad." Ariana whirls on her heel and marches away.

Lucy covers her face in horror. She breathes so rapidly that I think she's going to have a panic attack. "Oh, God. No, no, no."

"I'll take care of her. It's going to be okay," I tell Lucy urgently, though my heart is racing with panic.

I get up and off the bed, pull on some sweatpants, and hurry after my sister. "Ariana. *Ariana*."

She hasn't got time to find Mom and Dad before I catch her, so she bolts for her bedroom and tries to slam the door in my face. I shove it open and push my way inside. Ariana backs away from me, her expression furious and pale with shock. I don't want to be here any more than she wants me here, but her threat to tell our parents what she saw cannot be allowed to happen.

"I knew there was something weird about you two. I knew it. You've both got a screw loose. I begged Mom and Dad not to adopt a couple of traumatized street brats, and now you're screwing. You're brother and sister. I'm going to throw up."

"Nothing was happening. Look at me. Nothing was happening."

"You were naked with your dick in her. I saw everything. I want to bleach my eyeballs. There is no innocent explanation for what you were doing, so don't even try."

I pace up the room and back to Ariana. I could threaten her. I could pretend like I'm going to hurt her. She's not very brave, unlike Lucy who didn't even flinch when I stabbed a fork through someone's tongue, or when a warehouse exploded right next to her.

I've worked too hard all these years for our irritating sister to mess things up for us now. "How do I make this go away? There must be something you want."

Ariana raises her eyebrows. "You're not even going to try to persuade me? You haven't got one lie to gaslight me with? My eyes were playing tricks on me. She was helping you with a tight hamstring. Put some effort in, you disgusting freak."

I clench my jaw. We were playing a game, and it got out of hand because of my jealousy. Lucy shouldn't wind me up about other men touching her. She knows it makes me crazy. "I don't care enough about you

to convince you one way or the other. Just tell me what you want to keep your mouth shut.”

Ariana folds her arms and considers me with narrowed eyes. She’s silent for a long time while my pulse pounds in my ears. “I want a favor.”

“What favor?”

“I haven’t decided yet,” she says with a shrug. “I’ll let you know when I think of something worth my silence. It’s going to be good. If Mom and Dad find out about the disgusting things the two of you are up to, they’ll send Lucy far, far away. They can’t have a dirty, shameful scandal surrounding their perfect boy.” Her eyes widen in a taunt.

I wonder how dangerous it is to promise Ariana a favor, any favor. But this is my fault, and I have to fix it. I haven’t got any choice but to agree.

“Fine,” I say through gritted teeth. “And I have your word that you’ll keep what you saw to yourself?”

She smirks at me. “It’s interesting that you know what you’re doing is disgusting and wrong, and you’re trying to cover it up.”

I take a threatening step toward her, and she moves away with a yelp. Her back hits her bedroom wall. Speaking in a low voice, I warn her, “You can have your favor, but if you go back on your word to me, I will make you pay. You’re my sister, and I’m not going to hurt you, but if you cross me, I will find out who you love, I will break them, and I will make you watch. I will grind your heart under my heel. Do you understand?”

Her face creases in fear, and she trembles as she looks up at me. “You’re a fucking psycho.”

I spread my arms and give her a cold smile. “I’m who our father wants.”

I drop the smile and slam out of her bedroom.

When I get back to my bed, there’s no sign of Lucy. I slide my hand across the sheets and feel the warm spot left by her body. I miss her already. I lay down in Lucy’s lingering warmth and breathe in deeply, my fingers tracing over the sheets like she’s still with me. My fingers brush cotton, and I crumple Lucy’s underwear in my fist. Drawing them up to my face, I inhale, and groan.

Lucy.

She smells like everything I want.

I sit up, push down the waistband of my sweats, and take out my cock. With one hand holding Lucy’s underwear to my face and breathing in her scent, I pump myself furiously. Fast and hard and desperate. If we weren’t

interrupted, I could have been making her mine right now. I could know by now the sounds she makes. How her face transforms in pleasure. If she'd say my name over and over or just gasp it once, her nails digging into my back. My beautiful, perfect Lucy.

I come in long, wet ribbons across my sheets.

Panting, I stare at the mess I've made. I wonder if she's on the other side of this wall, doing exactly the same thing as me, feeling just as lonely and frustrated.

I sink down onto the bed with a groan.

We were caught. We nearly lost everything. We could still lose everything because I couldn't keep a tight hold of my jealousy.

I'm already failing her.

My phone rings, and I glance at it on my nightstand. It's Dad, no doubt wanting to talk business. He only ever calls me if it's business. I'm going to have to pull myself together and act like this is a normal day in front of Don Carlucci, the brutal and unforgiving head of the Barone crime family.

Lucy and I will find a way to be together because we're stronger together than apart.

I just have to stop being so fucking weak.

Lucy

I punch the boxing pads my personal trainer is holding up so hard that he finally waves them in surrender. “Whoa, Lucy. I’m beginning to think you’re trying to kill me.”

I swipe my sweaty brow with my forearm and unfasten my boxing gloves. “Sorry. I’ve got a lot on my mind.”

Like the fact that my brother is icing me out again. Ever since Ariana caught us, Damiano’s been treating me like I’m made of glass. We promised that we’d work together and be stronger together. He kissed me by the flames and promised he’d find a way for us to be together.

And now he won’t even look me in the eye.

“Whose face were you picturing?”

“I was thinking about my family,” I fume.

He grins. “That’ll do it. Hit the showers, and I’ll see you on Wednesday.”

I apologize again and thank him for the session, then I head to the locker room. Ninety minutes of kickboxing and weight training hasn’t quelled the snarl of furious emotions inside me. I haven’t managed to speak to Damiano in private ever since we were in his bed. Every time Ariana looks at me, her lips curl in disgust. Mom and Dad haven’t screamed at me or thrown me out of the house, so I guess that means she didn’t tell them that she found her siblings in bed together.

Yet.

I wish I knew what Damiano said to silence her.

I take off my sweaty workout clothes and get into the shower, blasting the water as hard as it goes. It's not fair. We finally sneak around and get hot and heavy in his bed, and we're immediately caught. He was about a second from sinking all the way into me and claiming me as his. I've been saving my virginity my whole damn life for him.

Ariana's expression of horror as she saw him on top of me has probably driven itself deeply into his psyche, a little taste of the nuclear meltdown that will occur if Mom and Dad ever walk in on us in bed together. I've never gotten along with my sister, but right now, I could strangle her.

I angle my neck left and right under the spray. Maybe it's time our secret came out. Dad couldn't be that angry with us for lying to him for all these years, could he?

I bite my lip. I don't know my father as well as Damiano, but I know enough to be afraid of him. It's a stupid idea to tell him the truth. If he found out we've been lying to him all these years, Dad would be furious. Murderously angry.

I stand for a long time under the hot spray. Every scenario I play out in my mind—honesty, secrecy, lies—ends up with me being thrown out of this family and never seeing Damiano again. Or I'm killed.

I'm playing with fire, but I'm not ready to stop fighting. Damiano's love isn't the only thing I crave. I refuse to be married off to a stranger of my father's choosing. I want to prove my worth in other ways and stay right by Damiano's side as his equal.

That night when I arrive in the dining room, Damiano is the only one there. As our eyes meet, there's an expression of naked hunger in his eyes. The same look he had by the burning warehouse before he kissed me. We move closer to each other, and then we're in each other's arms.

Our first real embrace since Ariana caught us.

"I missed you," he breathes. He takes my face in his hands and presses kisses all over my cheeks, forehead, and throat. Pulling back, he sucks his lower lip into his mouth, desperate for my taste. Claiming it from everywhere but my lips.

My hands clench on his shoulders. *I know you want to, so just kiss me.* But I've begged him enough. If he won't claim my lips, that's his loss. I have other things on my mind.

“So, about you and me,” I say lightly.

He immediately tenses, but his eyes drop to my mouth, and his thumbs caress my bare shoulders. “You and me?”

“Family business. Mafia business. I told you, I want in.”

Damiano watches me for a long time. I hold my breath, bracing for him to refuse me, readying my arguments why he’s wrong.

He glances around to make sure we’re alone. “The places I go, women are viewed as property, not people. I don’t like it, and I don’t agree, but that’s the way things are in Malus.”

“I don’t care what anyone thinks about me, except for you. I want to do this for me.”

“It’s dangerous.”

“Damiano, you don’t have to take me to a gunfight.” I pause, and I know we’re both remembering the Sokolis we shot and killed. “I’ll check on warehouses with you. Fill out spreadsheets. Clean guns. Anything. Just as long as I’m with you and not stuck at home collecting dust like a brainless ornament.” I step closer, holding his gaze. “Didn’t I prove my worth to you when I saved your life?”

He caresses my face, and there’s so much love and warmth in his eyes. From the first day I met him, all Damiano wanted was to make me happy. “How would you like to help me make three million dollars tonight?”

My heart pounds with excitement. Three million dollars? I might live in luxury, but I don’t have any money of my own. If I helped him make three million dollars, it still wouldn’t be my money. It would belong to Dad, but I’d know that I’d helped the family without needing to put a ring on my finger and say *I do*. It’s a step toward the life I want. The life Damiano and I promised each other. “How many people will I need to shoot?”

Damiano takes my jaw between his thumb and forefinger, admiring me with a sleek smile on his lips. His head dips down, flirting with the idea of kissing me, and I can’t stop my lips from parting as I lean into him.

“With a face as beautiful as yours, sis? You won’t need bullets. They’re already done for.” He places his lips against my ear and whispers seductively, “After dinner, put on your black velvet dress and some heels. We’re going to the Corinthian. And don’t tell Dad. This is going to be our secret.”

I shiver with anticipation.

There are footsteps outside the dining room. Damiano gives me a final squeeze, and then we break apart.

All through dinner, I can barely contain my excitement. The Corinthian is one of the swankiest hotels in Malus, and my mind races with possibilities. Are we meeting people there? Are we robbing the place? Running illegal poker games in the penthouse? The warehouse explosion hovers at the edges of my thoughts. The Sokolis are trying to kill us, but Damiano promised he'd keep me safe, and I trust him.

After dinner, I come downstairs fluffing out my curls and reapplying my lipstick. Damiano has already taken his car out of the garage, and I meet him outside as he's putting a briefcase in the trunk.

"What's in the case?" I ask as I saunter toward him, the slinky, strappy black dress clinging to my curves. The night feels electric, like anything could happen. My heart is pounding.

Damiano takes a slow, appreciative look up my body like I hoped he would. The only attention I crave is his. He opens the passenger door for me. "Beautiful, my love. You'll find out."

As we drive out the gates, Damiano reaches over and rests his hand on my leg, slowly stroking my soft inner thigh. I smother a pant and wonder what he'd do if I parted my knees and drew his hand higher between my legs. Heat sparkles through me as I imagine Damiano doing just that. Pulling aside my underwear, exploring how wet he's making me, and then pushing his fingers inside me as he drives. One of my hands pressed against the window of the car, the other hand braced against the seat, while he brings me to orgasm as we drive through the streets of Malus.

Blood rushes to my head and my clit. I want that so badly I think I might explode. Is Damiano thinking about how close we were to having sex? I haven't been able to stop thinking about it.

Wetting my lips, I say, "About what happened the other morning—"

"We don't talk about what happened the other morning," Damiano says in a hard tone, his hand tightening on my thigh. "I'm taking a risk bringing you with me tonight. Do you know what the family lawyer told me once? Damiano, don't break the law while you're breaking the law."

"What does that mean?"

"If you're going to speed, don't be drunk. If you're going to run an illegal gambling club, keep the drugs away. Otherwise you're making it easy for the cops to catch you and for judges to double, triple your sentence.

If we're going to do this we can't..." He picks up my hand and presses a kiss to my palm. "Do *this*."

"And if you want me so much you can't help yourself?"

Damiano flicks a glare at me before turning his attention back to the road ahead. "Stop tripping my jealousy, and we'll be fine."

I toss my hair back in anger. Is that what he's told himself? All he's feeling is jealousy? Well, I'm not going to beg. Damiano should be the one begging me.

He will be the one begging me.

"This isn't a game," he says in a gentler tone, meshing his fingers through mine. "This is Barone crime family business we're messing with. We have to take things slowly and carefully. Fly under Dad's radar. You haven't seen what Dad's capable of when someone crosses him. I have, and it's brutal."

"What is he capable of?"

There's a flicker of misgiving in my brother's eyes. "Pray you never find out. But I won't let anything happen to you, I promise."

"Why are you willing to risk Dad's anger if he's so dangerous?"

His expression is heartfelt as he takes his eyes off the road to caress my cheek. "Because I miss you."

My heart glows. "I've missed you too."

He presses the accelerator, and the car speeds forward, and he smirks at the road ahead. "And because I'm Damiano fucking Barone. I'm the chosen one."

I roll my eyes. "Your arrogance is off the charts."

He presses another hungry kiss to my palm. "You love it."

As we enter the Corinthian, Damiano is greeted with a deferential, "Mr. Barone," from a man I presume is the manager. I'm introduced as his sister, and the manager shows us up to the penthouse in the private elevator. I feel a tingle of anticipation as Damiano secretly strokes my waist behind the man's back. Just what does my brother have planned for us in a penthouse hotel room at night?

"I will send your guests up as soon as they arrive, Mr. Barone," he's told, and then the man leaves us.

I turn to Damiano. "Our guests?"

With a mysterious smile, Damiano carries the briefcase into the master bedroom and beckons for me to follow him. He puts it on the bed, unlocks

it, and reveals the contents. They sparkle like nothing I've ever seen before. It's jewelry. Dozens of pieces of fine jewelry. Necklaces, earrings, and bracelets, all stunning and of high quality, and perfectly cut and mounted.

"These are beautiful," I breathe.

"Almost as beautiful as you."

I raise my eyes to his. "Are they stolen?"

Damiano rubs his slightly stubbled jaw, lips curving in a smile. "By the Barones? No. By the previous owner, or the one before that? Possibly. Probably. They were given to Dad by various people to pay off loans and discharge favors. Now, they can only be sold privately."

He lifts a platinum necklace with both emerald and round-cut diamonds and fastens it around my throat. Fine jewelry. This side of the Barone crime family business is perfect for me, and Damiano has no idea how much. I didn't just take up shooting and kickboxing as my hobbies. I wanted to go to college, but Mom refused, saying that most degrees would be a silly waste of time for me, and I should learn to cook or keep accounts. I loathe cooking, and spreadsheets make me cross-eyed, but I researched other courses. History. Literature. Art. My attention was snagged by a course in gemology and jewelry design, which needed both technical and artistic skills. I thought I could do well at it, and it seemed like something our family might value. Mom is always dripping in jewels, and because learning about jewelry seemed harmless to her, she agreed. I don't think Damiano ever noticed what I was studying.

I move over to a mirror and stroke the diamonds around my throat as I examine them closely. They look like VVS1 or VVS2 quality. Maybe even FL. Flawless. "Beautiful. This necklace must be worth close to two hundred thousand dollars."

Damiano checks the notes from the briefcase, and his eyebrows lift in surprise. "That's exactly what it's valued at, one hundred and ninety thousand. How did you know that?"

I smile and shrug one shoulder. I'm not ready to admit how easy this is going to be for me. "A lucky guess."

He puts the notes aside. "A dozen very rich and dangerous men will soon be arriving to bid on these jewels, but maybe tonight will be too tame for you. No exploding warehouses. No shoot-outs."

I turn back to the case and examine the jewelry, pretending to be only mildly interested in them. "It's fine. I presume you want me to model the

jewels for these rich and dangerous men?”

“Yes. They’ll fetch an excellent price on their own, but with you modeling them, we can make the price skyrocket. If you find that insulting, I’ll understand.”

“I’m not insulted in the slightest. This is the perfect first night on the job for me.”

He smiles. “Wonderful. Be sure to stay on your guard. This is an auction, but you never know how things are going to go down.”

I step closer to my brother, put my hand inside his jacket, and feel the gun holstered under his arm. “Can I have a gun?”

He smiles down at me. “A gun doesn’t go with that outfit, my love. Some Barone soldiers will be arriving soon. We’ll protect you.”

After the warehouse explosion, I know he means it.

I can be so much more than a living jewelry stand tonight, but this is an important first step for us. I return his smile as a thrill of excitement goes through me. “Then let’s make some money.”

“The jeweler will be arriving soon, and then we can set up.”

But the jeweler doesn’t arrive, and Damiano paces up and down while he tries to reach the man on the phone. Finally, he puts his phone away with a muttered curse. “What the fuck am I supposed to do now?”

“We have the jeweler’s notes. I’ll introduce the pieces and point out what makes them special, and you can run the auction.”

Damiano thumbs through the paperwork. “I don’t know, Lucy. Some of this stuff looks complicated.”

“I can handle it,” I assure him, suppressing a smile. “Tell me in which order I should model the pieces, and I’ll remember the carats and reserve prices.”

Damiano assesses the case of jewels while rubbing the back of his neck and looking bewildered. “I have no idea about the order. The jeweler was supposed to take care of that.”

“Then I’ll choose. To start with, something high quality and eye-catching.” I select a heavy ruby pendant and put it on, nestling the sparkling red stone between my breasts. “What do you think?”

Damiano caresses the ruby, and his touch lingers, warming the stone. “Beautiful,” he murmurs, his eyes growing darker and heavy lidded. I know he’s remembering what I look like naked. Right now, he’s imagining what I’d look like naked wearing just this ruby necklace. Has he been dreaming

about how I tasted? How it felt to be one thrust away from burying himself deep inside me?

Damiano's fingers move lower. He cups my breast and rolls his thumb over my nipple through the black velvet, making me shiver in pleasure. I'm not picky where and how I lose my virginity, as long as it's to him. I don't need rose petals and candlelight. Bent over a king-size bed in the Corinthian, Damiano's hand clamped over my mouth while he fucks me fast and hard with a dozen men waiting for us in the next room sounds amazing, actually. He makes me so wet that I doubt it will hurt for longer than one thrust, and then it will be all pleasure.

There's the sound of the elevator opening. A moment later, Dad rounds the corner and sees us, followed by four of his men in suits.

Damiano snatches his hands from my body and steps away. One day, he won't have to hide what I mean to him. He'll be able to touch me without pulling away like he's been burned.

"Dad. We agreed I'd run the auction tonight," Damiano says.

I pretend to be fascinated by the jewels in the case. Dad glares at me and then turns to my brother. "What is your sister doing here?"

I calmly reach for the ruby earrings that match the pendant and fasten them to my earlobes.

"What does it look like she's doing? Lucy's helping me."

"You know the rules. You do not involve our women in our business."

"It's a jewelry auction, and Lucy's beauty makes these stones even more precious. I made a business decision."

Dad's opening his mouth to tell Damiano that I can't stay, but Damiano speaks over him. "The jeweler bailed. I need Lucy."

Dad closes his mouth. "Fine. Afterward, take her straight home. You and I will speak about this tomorrow."

I cast Damiano a worried look, hoping I haven't gotten him into trouble. There's no time to think about it now because the guests have started to arrive, and Dad and Damiano go and meet them.

I'll just have to make sure tonight goes perfectly so Dad has nothing to reproach my brother for come tomorrow. I'll prove I can be an asset to this family.

I study the jeweler's notes and lay the pieces out in the order that I'm going to present them. When Damiano comes to say that they're ready for

me, I emerge from the bedroom and head down the corridor, tucking my blonde curls behind my ears so that the ruby earrings can be seen.

In the large sitting room, a dozen hard-looking men in suits with tattoos peeking out beneath their sleeves are settled into the sofas and armchairs, sipping from tumblers of whiskey. There's only one other woman present, around twenty-five and wearing a low-cut dress. The man she's with is in his fifties. He's wearing a wedding ring, and she isn't.

I take a seat in the armchair that's facing the room, demurely crossing my legs at the ankles. With a smile, I tell the men about the ruby set, pointing out the high-quality stones, the unique design, and the provenance of the pieces, which is French. I recognized the maker's mark.

As I speak, I look around, and I realize I recognize some of the men. My best friend Adora's older brother is here, a big man with tousled golden hair. Cristiano Montoni is handsome and appealing, until you notice his cold, hard eyes. He's the new Montoni don.

Don Vincenzo Vici, a sleek, dangerous assassin, is here as well, but sitting as far away from Cristiano as possible. The previous Montoni don, Adora and Cristiano's father, murdered his family. Despite this, the bloodthirsty man married my sweet friend. I wonder why he's here tonight. He's not a man I expected would be interested in expensive jewelry.

Damiano starts the bidding at the reserve price while I sit with my hands loosely clasped in my lap, smiling at the men. Dad's expression is sour, but I'm determined to show him that I am an asset, not a hindrance.

The set sells for nearly twice the reserve price. Damiano catches my eye as I get to my feet, and I can tell he's pleased. My head is high as I leave the room to put on the next set.

In between modeling pieces, I listen to the men talk, trying to discern their names and how they fit into Dad and Damiano's world. The man who is here with his mistress is called Mr. Cattaneo. A man who's more interested in staring at my breasts than the jewelry is Mr. Dimitriou. He buys three necklaces and four sets of earrings for an eyewatering amount of money. I think he's trying to impress me, but I keep my attention averted from him as much as possible in case he gets the wrong idea. He's not bidding on me, he's bidding on the jewels.

Vincenzo Vici hasn't made one bid the entire auction, but when I finish talking the men through the amber-colored diamond earrings I'm wearing, I turn to him. "Don Vincenzo, have you noticed that these diamonds are the

same color as Adora's eyes? The color is very rare, and they're known playfully as pumpkin diamonds, but I think these are closer to amber."

Vincenzo has been looking overwhelmed by all the talk of cuts and carats, but now he seems interested. "Do you think my wife would like these? I want to buy her something, but I have no fucking idea what I'm doing." He laughs, a surprisingly good-natured laugh for such a dangerous man, and I find myself warming to him.

"I think she would love these earrings," I tell him.

Don Vincenzo nods. A few minutes later, he makes the winning bid, and he's the proud owner of the pumpkin diamonds.

"You know about jewels," Mr. Cattaneo remarks.

"A little," I say, with a modest smile.

He pats his mistress's thigh. She's a platinum blonde in a short skirt with very long nails. "I bought Gwynne a bracelet recently. Cost me a fortune, but I think you'll agree that it was worth every dollar. Show it to Miss Barone, Gwynne."

The mistress turns pale. She hesitates and then undoes the clasp on her bracelet, handing it to me with a nervous smile.

I take the piece and examine it. The bracelet has a beautiful gold setting that was made with a great deal of expense and care, but the rubies make me pause. They're all pinkish red instead of the classic stoplight red, and there's not one flaw in any of them. They're too perfect. Type II gems like rubies often have tiny inclusions.

I cast a surreptitious glance at the mistress. Sweat is shining on her brow, and she's white-knuckling her hands in her lap. From the woman's reaction to me studying the stones, my guess is that at some point this bracelet contained authentic rubies, but someone replaced them with lab-grown stones. Mr. Cattaneo is beaming at me, and I hate to think how his expression would change if I told him the stones are fake. At best, he'll dump his mistress. At worst, he might hurt her. Ariana's nasty warning that a woman is at a man's mercy is ringing in my ears.

I pass the bracelet back to her with a smile. "It's a beautiful bracelet, Mr. Cattaneo. You made an excellent purchase."

Mr. Cattaneo looks happy, the mistress looks relieved. The mistress's affections have no doubt been secured for a long time by the rubies she pawned.

I present the final set with extra care, speaking in detail about the marquise-cut canary diamonds haloed by round-cut clear diamonds. The set includes a necklace, earrings, ring, and bracelet. I saved the best for last.

“This set is my personal favorite,” I say, touching my fingertips to the diamonds at my throat. “Elegant, unique, and the canary diamonds are exceptional quality.”

“The lady has good taste,” Mr. Dimitriou tells me, and I give him a polite smile before looking away.

Damiano is staring at me, his mouth parted. It’s the way he looks at me when he thinks no one is watching, but right now, we’re in a room full of people. I widen my eyes at him slightly to tell him to pull himself together, but he doesn’t get the message.

“Let’s get on with it, Barone,” Cristiano prompts him when he’s been silent for several minutes. “I want to bid on these.”

Damiano looks around the room and then back at me. “There’s been a mistake. These pieces aren’t for sale.”

I frown at my brother. There was nothing in the notes about that.

“You’re kidding. Why not?” Cristiano asks.

“Because I want them for Lucy.”

Dad clears his throat. “Damiano, I told you that I want all these pieces to sell at auction tonight.”

“I know. I’ll buy them.”

I stare at my brother. Why is he doing this?

Cristiano isn’t done arguing with him. “It’s only fair to put them in the auction now we’ve seen them.”

A muscle tics in Damiano’s jaw, but he smiles at Cristiano. “Of course. The bidding starts at...?” He looks expectantly at me.

“Seventy-five thousand,” I reply.

“Thank you,” Damiano says. “I’ll make the opening bid. Two hundred thousand.”

Cristiano’s eyes flare in anger, but other than that, he’s as still as stone. The seconds tick past in silence.

Damiano glances around the room. “No other bids? Then I’ll consider myself the winner. Thank you everyone for coming tonight. I’ll have your pieces delivered to you as soon as your payments have cleared or cash has been handed over.”

I take a quick glance at Dad, wondering if he's happy about how tonight went. I spoke intelligently and in detail about every piece, and I was able to answer all questions. I haven't been keeping track of the bids, but I think we've made more than Damiano's targeted three million, even without his impulsive two-hundred-thousand-dollar bid.

Dad is gripping the arms of his chair, and he looks tense and displeased, and my insides shrivel up. I know he'll never love me like he loves Damiano, but what do I have to do to convince him I'm a valuable asset to this family? I'm starting to believe that it's impossible.

I head back to the bedroom, and Damiano follows me.

As soon as we're alone, like a starving man, he pulls me into his arms and presses kisses to my throat. "I've never seen you like that before. You had the whole room wrapped around your little finger. You were magnificent."

I twine my arms around his neck and smile. I'm happy, and Damiano is happy, even if Dad isn't. "I'm glad I could help, and I hope we can do it again sometime. All the time. I hate being parted from you."

"I hate being parted from you too."

I touch the necklace around my throat and look up at him. "Why did you buy these for me?"

Damiano presses another kiss to my throat. "Because I've never seen you look more beautiful. Why didn't you tell me you're a jewelry expert? I know you didn't get all that information from the notes."

"I studied gems and jewelry after high school. I thought you knew." I play with his tie, still smiling. "I think you made Cristiano Montoni angry."

"I don't give a damn. I'll go and get all those millions from our guests, and then we'll go home."

I pack away the jewelry and give the locked briefcase to one of Dad's armed men, then go in search of the bathroom. It's not until I've turned a corner and I'm out of sight of the living room and Damiano that I realize someone has followed me.

Mr. Dimitriou, and from the expression on his face, he's delighted that he's found me alone. "You know a lot about gemstones. It's impressive."

"Thank you, but I have to get back to—" I break off with a gasp as Mr. Dimitriou reaches for my ass and squeezes me like I'm a piece of fruit at the grocery store.

“Is jewelry a particular interest of yours?” he asks while staring at my breasts and blocking my way with his other arm.

“Get your hands off me,” I seethe, anger burning in my cheeks. Damiano is the only man who’s ever touched me like this. He’s the only man who’s allowed to touch me like this. From him, it feels completely different. Mr. Dimitriou is making me feel dirty, and I don’t know what I want to do more, cry or throw up.

Mr. Dimitriou crowds me closer to the wall. “That’s not polite when I just dropped several hundred thousand dollars on the jewels you were hawking.”

“And because you bid on the jewels, I’m supposed to let you grope me?” I pull out of his grasp and slap his face as hard as I can. “Go fuck yourself, and your money.”

Dad rounds the corner just in time to see me swear at Mr. Dimitriou and hit him.

With burning eyes, Dimitriou dabs at his lip and turns to Dad. “This bitch lacks manners. I didn’t expect to be so insulted.”

“And I didn’t expect to be groped by someone as old and ugly as you,” I snap, and his face turns red with fury.

Dad seizes me by the upper arm, marches me back to the bedroom, and forces me into a chair. “You will sit there, and you will not move. I will deal with you when everyone has gone.”

“But I—”

“Not another word, Lucy.” He leaves and slams the door behind him.

I clench the seat of my chair, fuming silently while I listen to the voices in the next room slowly fade away as everyone leaves.

Finally, I hear Damiano exclaim, “He did what to Lucy? Where’s my sister?”

Damiano bursts into the room, his curls falling into his sparking eyes. He sees me sitting in the chair, strides over to me, sinks to one knee, and takes my hand. Reaching up to cup my cheek, he asks urgently, “Are you all right? Did he hurt you?”

I admire Damiano’s handsome, upturned face. “Just my dignity. I can’t believe he had the nerve to grab my ass while you and Dad were here.”

His eyes darken. “That bastard touched you?” He gets to his feet and presses a kiss to my brow. “I’m so sorry. And I’ll make him even sorrier.”

I glare at Dad, who's followed Damiano into the room. This is the proper response when someone in your family is sexually harassed. Kisses and promises of vengeance.

"Damiano, take your sister home and never bring her around the family business again. She doesn't know how to handle herself."

Anger pumps through my blood. I stand up and face Dad. "I don't know how to handle myself? I've been groped, but I didn't stab that old lech in the neck. I think that deserves a medal. Oh, that's not the only violence I prevented tonight. We were so close to a public humiliation for one of your guests, but I smoothed it over."

Dad's eyes narrow. "What public humiliation?"

I can feel Damiano's strong, solid presence behind me, backing me up. "Mr. Cattaneo's mistress's bracelet. She was sweating like crazy when I was examining it because the rubies are fake. Someone must have sold the real stones and replaced them with imitations. I didn't want Damiano to spend the rest of the night dismembering the mistress's murdered body in the bathtub, so I pretended the rubies were authentic. Tell me again how I can't handle myself in your world."

"I see," Dad says icily. "So it's worse than I thought. You lied to protect a whore, slapped a guest, and provoked your brother into angering the new Montoni don. Dimitriou expects an apology from you, and you will give it to him."

My nails dig into my palms as humiliation courses through me. Why must Dad take everyone's side but mine?

"Lucy is apologizing to that piece of shit over my dead body," Damiano seethes. "Dimitriou is going to write my sister the most groveling and sincere apology a man has ever given a woman, or I'm going to cut off his fingers. Lucy is family, and we protect family. What's more, you should be thanking Lucy for her hard work. We brought in four and a half million dollars tonight, which is far more than what the jeweler told us to expect. It's all because of her."

My chin lifts slightly as I hear how proud Damiano is of me. At least someone in this room knows my worth.

How am I going to make Dad see it too?

Dad is a businessman. The only way I'm going to get through to him is with cold, hard figures. "Dad, I'm an asset, not a hindrance. If you've got more business involving gemstones, I'll take care of it for you, unless you'd

rather lose a considerable cut of a valuable enterprise to someone outside the family? What was the jeweler going to take tonight? Twenty percent?"

"Twenty-five," Damiano says.

"I'm not taking any cut," I point out. "All that money is staying in the family, and I want nothing in return except to be allowed to help." Actually, what I'd like is a thank-you and a little bit of goddamn sympathy when I get groped. But baby steps.

Dad looks at me for a long time while I hold my breath. Finally, he turns to Damiano. "Be downstairs in my study tomorrow morning."

Without another word, he leaves the penthouse.

My hope deflates like a balloon. I really thought that I was going to get some acceptance from Dad tonight. He would be impressed with me and tell me I did a good job, but he can't get past the fact that I'm a woman, and mafia women belong at home.

Damiano puts his arms around me and presses his lips to my forehead, surrounding me with his warmth and love. "You were amazing. I couldn't have done it without you."

I smile weakly. "Thank you. At least someone appreciates me."

He takes my face in his hands and caresses my cheeks with his thumbs. "Never doubt it. Did you really slap Dimitriou and tell him to go fuck himself?"

"I did."

He chuckles. "That's my girl. I love to see your eyes shining like they did tonight."

A warm feeling spreads through my belly, and my heart starts to race. We're pressed against each other, and Damiano's face is just inches from mine.

He takes my chin between his thumb and forefinger and lowers his mouth to mine. Butterflies riot in my belly, and I pant lightly in anticipation.

For a moment, I think he's going to kiss me. Really kiss me.

His parted lips brush over mine, the lightest of touches while our breaths mingle. Flames lick at my core, and I wait for him to pull us both into bliss and kiss me. His eyes are closed, and his lashes are dark against his cheeks, but he doesn't capture my lips.

He's tormenting us both. Punishing himself for what happened with Ariana. Denying us both what we promised each other.

“Let’s get you home,” he whispers, eyes still closed, lips moving over mine. “I have an apology to get in writing for you.”

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Damiano

“**W**as last night her idea? Don’t lie to me to cover for your sister.” Dad glares at me from behind his desk, his hands gripping the arms of his chair. Hostility is rolling off him in waves like I’ve never known from him before. Not aimed at me, at least.

The feeling is mutual. I fix my gaze at the wall just above Dad’s head so he doesn’t see the anger burning in my eyes. Lucy and I made him millions last night, and he hasn’t said thank you or asked if Lucy is all right after being groped.

“It was my idea for Lucy to help me sell that jewelry,” I tell Dad.

“Then your idea was a disaster,” he bellows. “Lucy lied to protect a thief, and she offended two important associates. If you wanted a woman to model the jewels, you should have paid someone who could keep her smart mouth shut. Someone who didn’t care if she was groped.”

“I don’t want anyone to be groped,” I snap.

“You can’t expect the men of Malus to behave any differently, which is why we keep our women away from them.”

I look off to the side, fuming. Dimitriou shouldn’t have dared laid a hand on her, and I should have kept a closer eye on my sister. I won’t make the same mistake next time.

“Your mother and I have frequently discussed Lucy’s constant disobedience,” Dad continues. “Her snooping. Her sour moods.”

“She’s bored and frustrated. She doesn’t like being left out of things.”

“It’s for her own safety, and yours. Women make you weak, Damiano. They’re either a target for your enemies or a ball and chain that drags you down. Never forget that.”

Lucy is my fiery angel, raining death upon my enemies. She saved my life at the warehouse. She saves my life every night when she comes to my bed and chases away my nightmares.

I can’t live without her.

I can’t breathe without her.

“I don’t agree. Lucy knows how to handle herself. She doesn’t make me weak, she makes me stronger.”

“She made you look like a fool in front of the men I have to do business with.”

The men who were in that penthouse last night were all important for Barone family business, but none more so than Cristiano Montoni and Vincenzo Vici. Now’s as good a time as any to tell Dad my plan for the future. “Lucy did no such thing, and I want to talk to you about the new Montoni and Vici dons. You knew their fathers, but I know the sons. I can strengthen our ties with them, and the Lucanias as well, through Rafiel. Just give me the chance to prove myself, with Lucy by my side.”

Dad shakes his head impatiently. “You don’t know what you’re doing. I’ll handle those weak little boys.”

I clench my teeth in frustration. Weak little boys. Is that what he thinks of me as well? “Don’t underestimate them, and don’t patronize them either. I’ve known them all for years. Why not me? I’m going to be the head of this family one day. It’s time I was allowed to start doing things my way.”

It’s completely the wrong thing to say.

Dad’s expression changes from annoyed to dangerously angry, and his eyes turn blacker than black. It’s the same look I’ve seen right before he has one of his men killed.

He presses his hands to his desk and slowly gets to his feet. “I’ll do you the mercy of pretending you didn’t just say that, Damiano. I’m head of this family, and you will follow my rules. My wishes. My instructions. To. The. Letter.” He jabs his finger into the wood to emphasize his words. “Why are you suddenly defying me?”

Frustration coils through my muscles, and I say through clenched teeth, “It’s only right that the don’s son has some power of his own.”

Dad comes around his desk toward me. “I know what’s gotten to you. A woman. It’s always a woman. Lucy is a terrible influence on you, and she’s been pouring poison into your ear. It’s time you stopped spending so much time with your sister.”

“My ambition is all my own,” I retort. “And family is important. You said that to me the day you adopted us.”

“Loyalty to the whole family, not just your sister.” Dad stares hard at me, trying to intimidate me like I’m just another of his capos.

I refuse to look away. “My loyalty to the Barones has never been in question.”

He watches me closely for a moment longer and then strides away. “See that it stays that way, or both of you will suffer the consequences.”

I watch Dad go, my fists clenched in fury. How dare he question my loyalty after all I’ve done for this family?

Lucy hasn’t come downstairs yet, so I go up to her bedroom. As I raise my fist to knock on her door, Ariana emerges from her room in her horse-riding gear. She gives me a dirty look when she sees that I’m about to enter Lucy’s room.

“Sister-fucker,” she whispers under her breath as she passes.

As far as I know—and I would know by now, because Dad would have flown into a rage and hurt Lucy—Ariana hasn’t breathed a word about catching me and Lucy in bed together. It had better stay that way. I haven’t figured out who Ariana loves, but there must be someone, and I won’t hesitate to use them against her if she goes back on her word.

Teeth grit, I knock on Lucy’s door.

“Who is it?” she calls.

“Me.”

“Is that my dear, darling brother who loves me?” she calls in a singsong voice.

I can’t help but smile. “Who else?”

“Then come in.”

I go inside and close the door behind me, and I’m several strides into her room before I realize that Lucy is naked. She’s laying on her stomach on her bed, feet in the air and crossed at the ankles as she reads a book. She’s wearing nothing but the canary diamonds I bought for her last night. Her breasts are cuddled into a fluffy white cushion. My eyes latch on to the lush swell of her bare ass.

Jesus Christ.

I glance at the bed canopy. The window. The floor. Back at her.

She's laid out like a goddess.

Lucy swings her feet back and forth with a teasing smile on her lips.

"What's wrong, Damiano?"

She knew I'd have news for her this morning. She laid herself out like this just to torment me, and this girl has the audacity to call *me* a troublemaker.

I take a package out of my pocket and toss it to her. "This is for you."

Lucy sits up elegantly in mermaid pose, revealing her bare breasts. She unwraps a bloodstained letter and a small plastic bag, and her nipples tighten in the cool air. Heat and desire wash over me.

Lucy opens the letter and looks at me over the top of the page. She pats the bed beside her. "You can join me if you want."

I glance at the door, wondering if we'll get caught again. Mom and Dad don't come into Lucy's room, and Ariana has gone out. What's so wrong about sitting with my sister?

I clear my throat and push my hand through my curls, trying to act nonchalant as I saunter toward her bed while my heart is racing. I don't know why I bother because Lucy doesn't care. I must be trying to conceal what I'm doing from myself.

I sink down onto the bed next to her as she reads the letter, and I'm completely captivated by the sight of all her warm, naked flesh up close. The jewels glitter against her body. I reach out and trace her collarbone with my knuckle. I've never seen a woman more beautiful than her.

Lucy reads aloud. "*Dear Miss Barone, I offer my sincere apologies to you for the offense I caused...* His handwriting is shaky. How many of Dimitriou's fingers did you cut off?"

I lean in close, inhaling her perfume, and press a kiss against her throat. "Why don't you count them?"

She peers inside the plastic bag. My sister doesn't scream at the sight of severed digits. She looks amused, like I knew she would. "Three fingers. My, my, Mr. Dimitriou is a stubborn man."

"He apologized as soon as I showed him the knife, but I thought he needed to be taught a permanent lesson."

Lucy gives me a mischievous smile. "Wicked man."

I rub the tip of my nose against hers. "Me? The brother who loves you?"

“Will Dad be angry that you did this?”

I bury my face in her hair, closing my eyes and breathing in deeply. “I don’t care.”

She eases onto her side, wrapping her arms around me and drawing me down onto the bed with her. My lips find her neck. I kiss her slowly, admiring the sparkling diamonds around her slender throat. My hands rove over her as I listen to her soft gasps of pleasure. It’s just a brotherly hug.

A brotherly hug with her breasts arched into my chest and both my hands cupping and kneading her plump, tender ass.

Yeah, right.

What the hell is going to become of us?

“Things are happening in Malus,” I say, my lips against her throat, my hands still squeezing her. I rock my hips and imagine my hard cock thrusting inside her. Teasing her. Tormenting myself. “Things that I want to control. I’m going to arrange a meeting with the new heads of the other Malus families. Dad’s not the right person to meet with them, and we need to protect and build what’s ours. Yours and mine. So I’ll do it myself.”

“Yours and mine?” Lucy whispers, wrapping her arms around my neck.

Dad won’t be around forever. Lucy and I are the future of this family, and I promised her that when I’m done, everything will be different.

She gasps as my fingers delve deeper and find her sex. I find the slippery hollow of her core, and torture myself with how wet she’s getting. “That’s right,” I murmur, tracing my lips over her throat. Wondering if I dare push my fingers deeper.

“And what about me? Are you going to order me to stay at home?” she asks, breathing faster.

I smile against her throat. “Do you think Dad would take Mom if he were meeting with Don Cristiano, Don Vincenzo, and Rafiel Lucania to discuss the future of Malus?”

Hurt and anger suffuse her voice. “Are you going to treat me the way Dad treats Mom? I hate it. She enjoys being left out of everything, like she doesn’t have a brain of her own.”

“Then it’s a good thing I’m not Dad.”

Lucy looks at me in surprise. “You mean...?”

Dad lecturing me from behind his desk like I’m just one of his men and not his trusted son and heir stings. But I trust Lucy. I grasp her curls,

making her surrender her mouth to me, but not quite kissing her. “I want you with me. Will you come with me, my love?”

“I always want you,” she breathes, and then corrects herself. “Want to be with you.”

“Then be with me, my love.” Rolling on top of her, I reach between her legs, stroke along her sex, and find her clit, teasing her slowly. She licks her lips and opens her legs wider for me. Every circle of her clit makes her breathe faster.

“Damiano, please,” she whispers.

I’m enraptured by the glorious surrender on her face. She moans louder the more aroused she gets, and I have to keep shushing her. I press a kiss to her panting mouth. “Shush, my love.”

She nods urgently, but then another wave of pleasure takes hold of her, and she moans again. Lucy can’t or won’t remember to keep her voice down, so I take my hand away.

“No. Please don’t stop. I’ll be quiet,” she whispers urgently.

“You promise?”

She sinks her teeth into her lower lip and nods, pleading with her eyes.

“You’ll keep quiet while I fuck you with my fingers?”

“I will. I swear it.”

“You want me to fuck you with my fingers?”

She seizes fistfuls of my shirt. “Yes. Yes.”

I love when she’s needy for me. I crave it like oxygen. I need to seal this promise to each other by making her come. With a hand pressed over her mouth—because I know Lucy can’t keep her voice down to save both our lives—I ease my middle finger into her. She whimpers around my hand as I start to pump my finger into her. A groan of my own escapes my lips. Her pretty pussy is so tight and slippery around my finger. I add another finger, her moans muffled by my hand. I keep moving my fingers in shallow thrusts and rubbing the spot behind her clit. Her wetness is all over my hand.

Lucy escapes my smothering hand and cries out.

“You can’t help yourself, can you?” I seethe, clamping my hand over her mouth again. “Goddamn little troublemaker who can’t keep quiet while I fuck your tight pussy with my fingers. I should just shove my cock down your throat so you can’t make a sound.”

Her eyes flash with pleasure, like she likes the sound of that.

All in good time. I'm having too much fun blasting her with my fingers.

"I'm so good to my pretty Lucy, aren't I?" I whisper, pumping in and out of her. "I'm so fucking sweet to my brat. You're going to come so hard to show me how grateful you are."

Lucy nods as much as she's able with my hand pressed over her mouth, and then her face flushes red. Her core clenches on my fingers, and her back arches as she comes, her breasts thrust upward. Fuck me, she's magnificent. I keep thrusting my fingers. I don't stop until her legs are shaking.

I take my hand away and lean over her, power and victory surging through me. I'm going to take what I want from now on. Lucy. Malus.

Everything.

"Good girl," I whisper, pressing kisses to her damp, cooling skin. "So fucking pretty when you come. We're going to show everyone in Malus who the real Barones are."



I KEEP my arm tight around Lucy's waist as we enter the restaurant. It's closed for the night, and the lighting is dim. Most of the chairs are already upturned on tables, and the waitstaff has gone home. This was the most neutral place we could agree on for our meeting, at the edge of Barone and Vici territory, and not far from Montoni streets. I'm armed, and so is Lucy. So are our invited guests, and we each have a handful of soldiers outside. It's not a friendly meeting, but it's not a hostile one either.

At least, I'm hoping that's the way it's going to go.

"You're sure about this?" Antonio had asked me in the car on the way here, concern etched on his face.

"The Sokolis are getting bolder every week," I'd told him. "And Dad's stuck in the old ways. If I wait for his permission, we'll all be dead."

Antonio hadn't looked convinced. Neither had Giovanni. They're loyal to me, but they both know I'm going behind Dad's back. If this goes wrong, we're all fucked.

Our guests are already present, sitting around the table in the middle of the room with drinks before them. Don Vincenzo Vici, his hair slicked back and wearing a black suit and tie that no doubt conceals an array of weapons.

Don Cristiano Montoni, dressed in an expensive black V-neck sweater with the sleeves pushed up past his elbows. Rafael Lucania, with an easy smile but sharp eyes, wearing a tight white T-shirt and sporting so much ink there's not a bare inch of skin on him.

There are guns and phones among the glasses of whiskey. Rafael's motorcycle helmet is on a table nearby. Vincenzo swigs from a beer bottle. Dad would hate this. There's no assembly of dozens of capos in a show of authority. No formal greetings and stiff tradition. He's too old-fashioned, and he would patronize and insult these men for not being like their fathers.

But their fathers are dead or locked away. We are the new Malus. Fresh blood.

The new leaders.

As Lucy and I approach, her side pressed tightly to mine, Cristiano casts a speculative gaze over my sister, which lingers too long for my liking. Lucy is wearing the canary diamonds that Cristiano wanted to buy.

His eyes narrow. "I didn't know we were bringing our women."

"That's not his woman," Rafael tells him. "That's his sister."

Cristiano looks pointedly at my arm around her waist. "Sister. Sure. Nice to see you again, Miss Barone. Does your brother ever let you out of his sight?"

"Never," I answer for her, in a tone that tells him he's stared long enough. The new Montoni don is unmarried, young, and arrogant, and he can look elsewhere for his bride.

I pull up another chair for Lucy and sit down beside her at the table. Rafael offers her a glass of white wine, but she shakes her head and accepts water instead. I do the same. Tonight isn't social, and I want to keep my head clear. I called this meeting behind my father's back. If it's a success, I might get away with it without my viper tattoo being burned off with a hot poker.

If it goes to hell, I'm fucked, and so is Lucy.

"So why have you called us all together, Damiano?" Rafael asks. "Is this a murder mystery night? Are we going to solve a crime?"

Vincenzo's lips tilt in a smile. "A murder? I probably did it."

"No games," I assure the men. "I thought it was about time we all sat down together as friends. We five are the future of Malus."

Vincenzo glances at Lucy. "Your sister included?"

I reach for her hand and hold it. "My sister included."

“Just because things have always been done a certain way, it doesn’t mean they have to stay that way,” Lucy says, gazing at each of the men. “We’re tired of the old traditions, the old rules. Aren’t you?”

“Barone business is Barone business,” Rafael says with a shrug. “I don’t have a problem with you.”

“Sure,” Vincenzo says softly, but without feeling.

Cristiano says nothing, and I decide to take that to mean he’s not going to cause a fuss about Lucy being present.

I get straight to the point. “There’s been a lot of bad blood in Malus. Understandable tensions between our four families. The Barones have been feeling outside heat from the Sokolis, and some of you have been getting it from them, the Dervishis, or both. I think it’s time we reminded them that it’s our city. Not theirs.”

“And how are we going to do that?” Cristiano asks, with ironic emphasis on the *we*.

“That’s what Lucy and I were hoping we could discuss.”

“If we’re going to work together, we have to trust each other. You really think that’s possible?” Vincenzo asks in an icy voice, glancing at Cristiano.

“I would have a hard time trusting the son of the man who murdered my family, but you have Adora in common. You have Malus in common. The sins of the fathers do not have to be laid upon the children.”

Vincenzo glances at Lucy’s hand, which is resting lightly on my forearm. “Easy words, Barone. Cheap words. If my father had murdered your sister, you wouldn’t be sitting with me having a friendly little drink.”

My chest feels tight at even the suggestion that someone might hurt Lucy. “I understand how hard this is for you.”

“You understand shit,” Vincenzo seethes.

Rafael sits back with a shake of his head. “Something about this doesn’t feel right. We’re all heads of our families, in one way or another. You’re not, Damiano. I have a hard time believing Don Carlucci would send a woman into negotiations. I don’t believe you have the authority to speak for your father.”

“Who said my father sent me?” I ask, my voice hardening.

“Will Ariana be coming to meetings next?” he asks with a lift of his brow.

“She’s not your business either.”

Rafael’s face hardens with dislike.

“Rafiel, I thought you didn’t have a problem with me,” Lucy says.

“I don’t have a problem with you. I have a problem with Damiano. This meeting is bullshit. It’s obvious that Damiano is making a power play against his father and wants to drag us into it.”

“You think so?” Cristiano asks. He’s smiling, but it’s a cold, taunting smile. “Or maybe Damiano doesn’t go running for Daddy’s approval for every little decision he makes. That must be tiring when your father is in prison.”

“Fuck you,” Rafiel seethes.

This isn’t going down like I’d hoped. After so much bloodshed and animosity, maybe it’s too late for any amity between our families.

I hold up a hand before Rafiel and Cristiano can lunge over the table at each other. “Last time I checked, we don’t need our parents to drive us to playdates. I don’t have to get anyone’s permission on who I call my friends. I decide that for myself.”

“So you want us all to be friends?” Vincenzo asks, disbelief etched on his face.

“Friendship for our mutual benefit,” Lucy says. “A clean slate for the five of us without the mistakes our fathers made hanging over us. Openness and trust. Maybe we can start there.”

The men exchange glances. They seem doubtful, but at least they don’t get up and walk out.

“What does trust look like to you?” Rafiel asks us.

“Trust means open communication about the shit that’s going down in each of our territories,” I reply. “We help each other. No secrets.”

Rafiel’s expression darkens as if that’s already a deal-breaker. I wonder what secrets he’s protecting.

“Trust means no backstabbing,” Lucy adds.

“But I like stabbing,” Vincenzo deadpans.

She ignores his joke—at least I hope he meant it as a joke—and continues, “No seizing money, power, or territory from each other. We settle our disagreements with words, not bullets.”

Cristiano doesn’t move, but a muscle in his jaw subtly tightens. Rafiel and Vincenzo are trying to rebuild their devastated families and shattered trust. It’s going to be hard, but I think I understand them. Cristiano is the wildcard. I know little about the Montoni don and his ambitions, but if he’s

anything like his scheming, murderous father, we're all going to have a big fucking problem.

There's a tense silence as we all look warily at each other.

Lucy sits up and puts her hands on the table, looking at each of the men in turn. "That's something to work toward. How about we start with something simpler? What's something the Barones can do for you? A show of good faith from me and my brother."

Rafiel opens his mouth, hesitates, and then closes it again.

Interesting. He wants something from us, but he won't ask. Because he doesn't trust us? Or because he's reluctant to expose a weakness?

Neither Vincenzo nor Cristiano say anything either.

"It's something to think about," I tell them. "We all have problems with the Sokolis and Dervishis that we're dealing with. If you ever need the Barones' help, I want you to ask for it. Meanwhile, let's drink to peace and prosperity for our families." I hold up my glass in a toast.

There's a short silence, and then Vincenzo raises his beer bottle and says bitterly, "To our families. What's left of them."

Cristiano doesn't miss the dig at his father's misdeeds, but he raises his glass. "To our families."

Rafiel shakes his head as if he thinks this whole meeting has been pointless, but he lifts his glass. "Sure. Whatever. Our families."

Finally, Lucy's glass joins ours. As reluctant as the toast is, at least we're exchanging words and not more violence. It's a small step toward a stronger Malus for all of us. A stronger position for me and Lucy within our family.

I start to breathe more easily. My heart even lifts a little.

A deafening crack shatters the air.

The glass I'm holding explodes into shards. A red-hot line of fire streaks across my forearm.

There are several more cracks, and some of the restaurant windows splinter and shower pieces of glass all over us. I grab Lucy and pull her beneath the table.

We're being fired upon from the outside.

"I knew it, it's an ambush," Vincenzo roars, somewhere above my head. "I'll fucking kill you, Barone."

There's the sound of him and the others returning fire. In my arms, Lucy is chalk white, but she's not panicking.

“Stay down,” I tell her, and reach inside my jacket for my gun.

I can hear Antonio and Giovanni shouting outside, then more swearing in Italian in voices I don’t recognize that must belong to Vincenzo’s, Rafiel’s, and Cristiano’s men. I sit up slightly to get a look at what’s happening, and something red and flaming hurtles through a smashed window. It’s a glass bottle filled with clear liquid with a burning rag stuffed in the end. Molotovs are not the weapon of choice for any of the Malus families. We’re under siege by Sokolis.

The bottle smashes, setting the white linen and chairs alight. Several more Molotovs are thrown inside from different locations. The fuel from the smashed bottles spills everywhere and instantly ignites.

Cold sweat breaks over me. Screaming fills my head. The Sokolis keep using fire against me like they know my personal fucking trauma.

As smoke fills the restaurant, the flames roar, driven higher and higher by all the fresh oxygen coming in through the smashed windows.

Heat scorches my face. We have moments until we’re suffocated or burned alive.

Beside me, Lucy whimpers in fear, and the sound rouses me out of my panic. For years, Lucy has soothed my nightmares and brought me back from the brink. She saved my life when the Sokolis blew up the warehouse. Now it’s my turn to save her. I brought her into this danger, and I’m the one who has to get her out.

The smoke has rimmed her eyes with red, and we’re both coughing. I seize her hand and pull her toward the back of the restaurant. “This way, quickly.”

She nods and squeezes my hand, her other arm shielding her face.

Both of us keeping low through the sparks and smoke, I lead her through the kitchen and toward the back door. My gun is in my hand, pointed straight ahead, when the exit is yanked open. I see a man with a spider tattoo and a gun. Before he can aim at us, I shoot him in the head, and he goes down. Lucy and I step over his corpse.

Out in the parking lot, the Sokolis are already turning tail and running. But the damage is done.

“Antonio!” I shout, scanning the chaos. Where is he?

Giovanni appears through the smoke, blood streaming down the side of his face from a cut. “Damiano! Antonio’s hit.”

My blood turns to ice. I race toward where Giovanni is pointing, Lucy right behind me. Antonio is slumped against his car, clutching his chest. Blood blooms across his white shirt, spreading fast.

“No, no, no.” I drop to my knees beside him. “Antonio. Antonio, look at me.”

His eyes are glazing over, his breathing labored and wet. The wound is high on his chest. Lung, maybe heart.

Fuck.

“We’re going to help you,” I tell him, pulling his arm across my shoulder to support his weight. “Stay with me.”

Lucy is there, her gun in hand, eyes scanning for threats. “We need to get him to a hospital. Now.”

“They knew,” Antonio whispers, his voice barely audible. “They knew we’d...be here...”

Dread settles in my gut. He’s right. This wasn’t random. The Sokolis knew exactly where to find us.

Someone talked. Or someone was watching.

“Save your strength,” I tell him as Giovanni helps me get Antonio into the car.

Behind us, Cristiano and Vincenzo emerge from the burning restaurant, weapons still drawn. Rafael is with them, his white shirt stained with soot and blood—not his own, from the looks of it.

“We got two of them,” Vincenzo reports grimly. “The others scattered.”

“They saw all of us,” Cristiano adds, his cold eyes meeting mine. “They know about this meeting now.”

“Which means war,” Rafael says flatly.

But I can barely process their words. All I can see is Antonio’s blood soaking through his shirt as we get him into the car.

“Drive!” I shout at Giovanni, and we tear out of the parking lot.

Lucy is in the back seat with me and Antonio, immediately pressing her hands to his wound. Her dress is already soaked with blood, but her hands are steady.

“Stay with us, Antonio,” she says, her voice surprisingly calm. “You’re going to be okay.”

My phone rings. It’s Francesco. Fuck.

“Is my son with you?” he demands before I can even say hello.

“He’s hurt. We’re taking him to St. Mary’s now. Get there as fast as you can.”

“How bad?”

I look at Antonio’s pale face, the blood soaking through Lucy’s dress as she tries to stem the flow. “Bad. I’m sorry, Francesco. We were ambushed. Sokolis.”

“I’m on my way. Where were you ambushed? Who else was there?”

I explain about the closed restaurant and sitting down with Vincenzo, Cristiano, and Rafiel.

There’s a long pause. When Francesco speaks again, his voice is deadly calm. “Don Carlucci said nothing about this. He knew nothing about this, did he, Damiano? He will want to know why you were meeting with the other dons.”

His hard tone implies that he’d very much like an explanation as well.

“I know.”

“Then you better have a good explanation ready.” He hangs up.

Lucy looks at me, her face streaked with Antonio’s blood. “This is bad, isn’t it? Not just Antonio. Our father...”

“It will be okay,” I tell her, but I’m actually thinking, *He’s going to lose his mind*. I squeeze her shoulder. My other hand stays on Antonio, as if I can will him to live through touch alone.

As I look at her in the back of the speeding car, Antonio’s blood on both of us, his labored breathing filling the silence, I know with terrible certainty that tonight has changed everything.

Damiano

Antonio might not make it through the night. I'll never forget Francesco's face as they wheeled his son into surgery. The accusation in his eyes. The way he couldn't even look at me before following the gurney through those swinging doors.

This is all your fault, his silence said.

My heart doesn't stop pounding, even when we're safe within the high iron gates of the Barone mansion. The house is quiet and dark as Lucy and I come into the kitchen through the garage. It seems like there's no one else home. Antonio's blood is still under my fingernails. Still soaked into Lucy's dress. As I raise my hand to push it through my curls, she captures my wrist gently.

"Damiano, you're bleeding. Let me see your injury."

She helps me out of my jacket and rolls up the bloody sleeve of my shirt. A bullet has grazed my flesh close to my viper tattoo. So what if I'm bleeding? A bullet might have hit Lucy. She could have died.

"Fuck, I need a drink." I pull a bottle of vodka out of the freezer, slosh a hefty serving into a tumbler, and knock half of it back. It burns down my throat like fire and ice.

"Please let me take care of you," Lucy says, with big, worried eyes.

I take another mouthful of vodka, wishing I could forget the sight of Antonio bleeding profusely in the back of the car. It could have been Lucy,

bullets tearing through her because I wasn't able to protect her.

"Damiano, say something."

"That was a disaster from start to finish."

Lucy nods in somber agreement. She takes the glass from me and swallows a pensive sip. "Being ambushed like that was terrible timing. Vincenzo is going to have difficulty believing we had nothing to do with this. Cristiano is going to be suspicious. He already doesn't trust us. But Rafael has known us for years. Surely he won't believe that you knowingly risked putting me in the path of a Sokoli bullet for the sake of killing men who would be better off as our allies. Let's reach out to him first when the dust settles."

Lucy's talking about tomorrow and the next day and the day after that. About salvaging the alliance we just formed, but I'm still trapped in the back of that car, watching Antonio struggle to stay conscious.

Blood drips down my arm and splashes on the tiles.

Lucy puts the glass down and gently takes my hand. "Damiano, you're bleeding worse than ever. Let's get you cleaned up."

I let her tug me along the hall and into the downstairs bathroom, where she sits me on an upholstered chair next to the sink and pulls a first aid kit from the lower cabinet. Kneeling before me, she cleans and applies antiseptic to my wound. Her touch is tender. She's the only person in the world who cares about me. Who truly loves me.

Like a wife.

I take a ragged breath as my eyes rove over her beautiful face. "Why do you keep letting me do this to you?"

"Do what?" she asks, smoothing antiseptic cream across my cut with a pinkie finger.

"Putting you in danger."

"I don't let you do anything, you silly man. I choose things for myself, and don't you dare panic and change your mind about us now."

"I'll never forgive myself if something happens to you. If you get hurt by the Sokolis, if Dad finds out that we're not related like we've been pretending to be, he'll do something terrible. We can't—"

Lucy stops my words with a kiss. "Stop catastrophizing, Damiano. Do you want me or not? Do you love me with your whole heart?"

The scent of gunpowder and blood clings to us, and the vodka burns in my belly. "Of course I do. To the ends of the earth."

I wince as the antiseptic stings my wound. Lucy notices my breathing change, and she caresses my cheek apologetically. "I'm sorry I'm hurting you. I'm nearly finished."

"You could drive hot spikes under my nails, and I'd say thank you, my love."

She smiles, wrapping a bandage around my forearm and securing it firmly. Then she sits back on her heels with her hands on my thighs, gazing up at me. "I know it was difficult for you to take me with you tonight. I know you're afraid for me, but I worry about you just as much. Remember, this is what I want. To be by your side and die by your side if it comes to that."

"Do not speak of dying," I order her sharply, seizing her shoulders.

"I'm not afraid of anything when I'm by your side."

"Well, I'm fucking terrified of losing you."

"Walking into that room on your arm tonight, as your equal, I felt prouder than I ever have in my life. Closer to you than I have in our whole lives. Proud, and powerful as well. I'm not letting anything come between us. Not fire. Not bullets. Not anything."

I take her face in my hands with a groan and press my forehead to hers. She's so fierce that I can't help but love her.

We just survived another ambush. Antonio is fighting for his life in surgery. The alliances I tried to build tonight have already crumbled. Francesco no doubt has already called Dad. Dad is going to rage at us for what we've done.

But none of that matters right now. Not when she's looking at me like this.

"The whole world can go to hell. You and me. That's all that matters."

I tilt her chin up and press my lips to hers. Lucy kisses me back and deepens the kiss. Her hands caress my chest and slide down my body.

"We can have whatever we want," she whispers, unthreading my belt.

My heart is pounding again, but for a very different reason. With gentle hands, she pushes me so I'm sitting back in the chair, and she pulls out my rapidly hardening cock. Her slender fingers, with their wine-red nails, stroke my girth, the veins standing out along my length. She always makes me feel loved. Always makes me feel desired. I cup her cheek and caress her softness.

She's just the same as she was the first day I found her. Fierce and beautiful, huddled on the edge of life-ending consequences. She didn't see the danger she was in that day, and she still won't see it now. Is it my curse, always to sense the danger around us while she shrugs it off?

How many more times can I pull her back from the brink before something terrible happens?

Lucy runs her tongue along my length, and my head falls back with a groan. She sucks on the tip and then takes me deeper in her mouth. She presses a kiss to the underside of my cock and then licks it. "You'll have to help me. I've never done this before."

"You're doing amazing," I breathe, gazing down at her, my hand lost in her curls. "So fucking beautiful with my cock in your mouth."

Lucy parts her lips and pushes me into her mouth, sucking slowly up. Deeper still, and then slowly up again, her cheeks hollowing. She moves at a leisurely pace, and I'm totally enraptured.

"That's perfect, my love," I groan, cradling her head in my hands. "Just like that. Take your time with me."

She starts to move faster, and heat and pleasure spiral through me. I want to let her control this, but when I feel myself hit the back of her throat, my self-control snaps.

I stand up and move forward so I can brace my hands on the wall, and Lucy eases herself back until she's pressed against it. I plunge my hand into her hair and thrust with my hips.

"Look at me," I command. She opens her eyes and gazes up at me, and the look she gives me sends pure desire flooding through me as I fuck her face. "You're mine. All mine. No one else gets to see you like this."

I can never stop wanting her. Loving her. Needing her. Her hands clench and caress my belly as my cock moves in and out of her mouth.

"That's it, my love. Take all of me. You're so good for me."

I don't want to come down her throat. I want to see myself coating her tongue before she swallows me down.

I take myself in my hand, fisting my length furiously. "Open your mouth. Stick out your tongue."

Panting, she opens her reddened mouth and shows me her tongue. I jerk my cock in my hand several times, and then come with an animalistic growl, hot spurts of cum spilling into her mouth.

"Swallow it. Every drop. That's my good girl."

Lucy's eyes lock with mine as she closes her mouth and swallows, her throat working. When she opens her mouth again to show me it's empty, I groan at the sight.

I should hear it. The sound of a car pulling up outside. The garage door opening. Footsteps.

But I'm too lost in Lucy. Too caught up in the taste of her, the feel of her, the desperate need to claim her after nearly losing her tonight.

We should stop. We're not in my bedroom. We're in the downstairs bathroom where anyone could walk in.

But I can't stop. Not when she's looking at me like that.

The bathroom door flies open.

"Damiano, there's blood out here. Francesco called me and said—"

Dad freezes in the doorway. Mom is right behind him, her hand flying to her mouth.

Time stops.

I'm standing over Lucy, my cock still in my hand, cum on her lips. She's on her knees before me, her dress stained with Antonio's blood, her eyes wide with horror.

There's no explanation. No excuse. No way to pretend this is anything other than what it is.

Mom takes a deep breath and screams. A bloodcurdling, hair-raising scream that echoes in the small, tiled bathroom and spears through my skull.

I've witnessed Dad calmly smoke cigars as men have been tortured in front of him, their bones broken and bodies mutilated. Now, the color drains from his face until his complexion turns gray, and his mouth sags open. He tries to speak, but his voice is hoarse. The bottom falls out of my stomach as he screws his eyes up, curls into himself with a fist pressed over his chest, and groans in pain.

Lucy shoots to her feet with a cry of alarm. "Dad, are you all right? What's wrong?"

I shove myself back into my pants, zip up, and grasp Dad's arm. "Dad? Can you hear me?"

Mom pushes me and Lucy out of her way. "Carlucci? Darling, what's wrong? You two, get back. Give him some air."

Lucy and I hover behind Mom, exchanging terrified glances. Did we do this to Dad? We did this. He's having a heart attack because he caught his

children fooling around together, and who can blame him, considering what he believes about us? I fumble for my phone. “I’m calling an ambulance.”

Dad seems like he’s going to collapse, and then his face clears and he straightens up. “Put that phone away, Damiano. I’m fine.” His eyes are burning with fury, and they fall on Lucy. His teeth clenched, he seethes, “Get her out of my sight.”

Like hell. Dad’s putting all the blame on my sister when it was both of us in this bathroom. “Wait, Lucy isn’t the one who—”

Mom’s eyes flash, and she seizes Lucy viciously by the hair and drags her out of the bathroom. “You little whore, polluting this family with your corruption. How dare you behave this way under our roof.”

Lucy screams in pain and fights Mom every step of the way. I try to go after her, to save my sobbing sister from being violently manhandled, but Dad seizes me by the shoulder. “You brought your sister to a meeting of Malus families? The Sokolis saw her, and you didn’t kill them all?”

I’m blindsided by the wrenching change of subject. He knows about that?

Dad shakes me. “Antonio was shot tonight because of your arrogance. Francesco’s son is fighting for his life in surgery right now. And you came home and did *this*?” He gestures furiously at the bathroom. “Lucy was supposed to sell a few jewels for us, not meet the next fucking dons of the most powerful families in Malus. You went behind my back, Damiano. You’ve put your mother and your sisters in danger. What you have done is unforgivable.”

He shoves me out of the bathroom, surprisingly strong for a man who was gasping for air and clutching his heart just moments ago. Distantly, I can hear shrill female voices. I have no doubt that Mom is ranting at Lucy and calling her names while Lucy sobs wretchedly. I want to go to her, but I have to wait until Dad has finished taking his wrath out on me. Otherwise, he’ll do it to Lucy. My only chance to keep my sister safe is to convince Dad that I acted reasonably tonight, and then he can talk Mom into forgetting what she saw in the bathroom.

Inside Dad’s study, he rounds on me, his eyes black. He’s breathing hard like an angry bull. “Tell me why I had a phone call from Francesco telling me his son Antonio was shot by Sokolis tonight. Explain to me in explicit fucking detail, Damiano, why you were in an empty restaurant with Don

Cristiano, Don Vincenzo, Rafiel Lucania, and your sister. You were doing what I told you not to do, weren't you?"

I keep my chin raised and stare straight ahead. "I was."

"If you weren't my son, I'd take a blowtorch to that viper tattoo on your arm and put a bullet in your head. Do you realize how this makes me look in front of my capos? Francesco's son might die, and it's because you went behind my back to play at being don."

"Tell them it was your idea."

"It was my idea to take Lucy with you?" he bellows.

I keep my voice strong and steady but don't raise it. I don't want it to sound like I'm challenging his authority. "Lucy is best friends with Adora Vici. Lucy has connections with Vincenzo Vici and Cristiano Montoni through Adora that I don't have. It made good strategic sense that I took her with me."

"Do not stand there and feed me bullshit," Dad rages. "You're not even going to pretend you're sorry for what you've done?"

"I'm sorry about Antonio, but I'm not sorry that I tried to make allies for the Barones."

Dad raises his hand and backhands me across the face. I see the blow coming, but I don't try to protect myself. He hits me with full, furious force, making me stagger. Pain explodes in my cheek. I blink hard and shake my head, then I straighten up and fix my eyes on the wall again.

Don't react.

Don't let him see how much I want to return his blow with one of my own.

Take his violence for Lucy.

"What do you think those Sokoli men are telling their *krye* right at this moment?" Dad shouts. *Krye* is their word for boss. "They are telling him, Lucy Barone knows what Don Carlucci and his son are up to. Lucy Barone can be captured, raped, and tortured until she tells us all she knows. They will be saying the same thing about your mother and Ariana. They are all in danger now. What the fuck were you thinking?"

My stomach drops. "It wasn't my intention to put them in danger. We can protect them."

"Keeping them away from our family business was protecting them, and you just ruined that. And then in the bathroom... Lucy... Your sister was... I can't even say it. I have never been more disgusted and ashamed of you,

Damiano. My own son. A good-looking boy who can have any woman he wants. I don't understand." Dad paces up and down. "I knew there was something wrong with that girl. She's too attached to you. Too dependent. Like a goddamn shadow. She seduced you, didn't she? She got her claws into you like a fucking witch."

"She's your daughter," I exclaim. "Don't talk about her like that. What's been going on between us is my fault, not hers."

Dad rounds on me with a snarl. "Do you really expect me to believe that? You have other women. You have friends. Lucy haunts this house. She does nothing and has no one but you. She's latched onto you like a demon, and if you're not careful, she's going to drag you down to hell. I won't let that happen."

I step up so we're face to face.

"It was my fault. Deal with me however you see fit, but leave Lucy out of it. Mom already frightened and upset her enough. I'll do whatever it takes to prove that Mom, Ariana, and Lucy are safe, and that Lucy isn't dangerous. I'll kill every Sokoli myself."

"I'm supposed to trust you, knowing my own son is morally degraded? I have put up with so much from that disobedient, sour-faced girl because she is your blood and you are my son, but now she has crossed the line."

Should I do it? Tell Dad that we're not actually related, and that we've been lying to him all these years? But that would make Lucy more vulnerable than ever. Her supposedly being my blood is all that's keeping Dad from storming upstairs and wringing her neck.

"Dad, listen to me. I have given you my *life*. I will keep giving you everything, as long as all of us remain a family under this roof."

The words taste like ash. Lucy isn't my sister. She's never been my sister. She's the woman I love, but I just swore to Dad we'd stay family.

Dad paces up and down in silence, and I keep my lips sealed, hoping against hope that what I've said gets through to him.

Finally, he pushes his hand through his hair, straightens his cuffs, and seems to come to a decision. Turning to me, he says, "This is what's going to happen. Lucy is going to take a job overseas with one of my associates. You will not know where or with whom, and you will cease to have all contact with her. You will never speak to her again, and you will focus on protecting your mother and Ariana. I will not hear one word of argument

from you about this. I am this close to beating that girl senseless and throwing her into the gutter. You are both lucky that I have not killed her.”

My vision blurs at the edges as Dad threatens Lucy.

Suddenly I’m not in Dad’s office anymore. I see it with terrifying clarity. Lucy screaming as fire engulfs her. Her skin blistering. Her hair ablaze. Her beautiful brown eyes wide with terror and pain as the flames consume her flesh. She’s reaching for me, begging me to save her, but I’m not there. I’m powerless, while she burns alive.

My fault. All my fault.

Cold sweat breaks over me. The smell of smoke fills my nostrils even though there’s no fire here. Just the memory of it. And the screaming.

Always the screaming.

A shout bursts from my lips. “No! You won’t touch her, and you won’t send her away.”

“Damiano, I am warning you,” Dad growls. “Not one more word.”

I breathe hard and fast. He means it. He’ll kill her. But if Lucy is sent away to an unknown place, she’ll have no one to protect her and I’ll never see her again. The thought is a knife in my heart.

“Dad, listen to me,” I say urgently. “Lucy must remain in Malus. I need her. I love her.”

“You should have thought of that before you took her to that meeting. If she’s captured by Sokolis, at least she won’t be able to reveal much.”

I leap on his words and lie through my teeth. “Lucy knows everything. I told her all about the family business. Every single one of our secrets.”

Dad looks at me like I’m an insect he dearly wants to crush under his shoe. “How could you be so stupid, Damiano? Or was this your plan all along, to feed your sister secrets and tie my hands?” He rubs a hand over his face, shakes his head, and moves around behind his desk. Planting his hands on the wood, he addresses me. “I’m not having her in this house. If Lucy can’t leave Malus, then she will get married. She needs a man who can keep her under his heel as I have failed to do. A man who will keep her away from my son.”

My mouth goes dry. Lucy marry someone else? Watch another man take the woman I love away from me? That night outside the diner, I promised her we’d be together. I held her in my arms at the burning warehouse. I took her to the auction. To the restaurant. I put her in danger again and again because I couldn’t stay away from her. Because I love her.

But I'm not don. Dad still holds all the power.

For now.

As though he can read my mind, Dad reaches into a drawer and pulls out a gun, and the weapon glints menacingly in his hand.

He aims the gun directly at my chest. "Or you can keep arguing with me, and she'll get a bullet."

I stare at the gun as blood pounds in my ears. At my father's cold, merciless eyes. The very first moment I laid eyes on Mom and Dad in the group foster home, I should have known what they were offering me was too good, too perfect, too *dangerous*. But I was blinded by hope. All I could see was a wonderful new life for Lucy, not knowing that it would one day lead to our destruction.

"I'll find someone suitable," Dad continues. "Someone who can control her. Someone loyal to me. And you will smile at the wedding, Damiano. You will congratulate the groom. You will kiss your sister on the cheek and wish her well."

I see it. Lucy in a white dress. Another man's ring on her finger. Another man's hands on her body. Another man taking what's mine. The image makes bile rise in my throat.

"And you will never touch her again. If I ever catch you with Lucy again, I will kill her. She'll disappear, and you'll never know where I buried the body."

Every word is a knife in my heart. I want to grab that gun and shove it down his throat. I want to tell him that Lucy is *mine* and no one else will ever touch her. But the gun is pointed at her heart, not mine. I know my father. He'd do it. He'd kill her to prove a point. To maintain control.

"And, Damiano? If you ever try to kill me, or if by some small chance you succeed, my men will kill Lucy. I'm going to give them the order right now, so you had better not think about doing anything stupid."

The perfect plan for us to be free, for me to become don and marry Lucy, dies before my eyes.

"If you murder Lucy's groom, my men will kill Lucy. Are we clear?"

Doors slam shut in my face, one after another. Chains wrap around my body, holding me cruelly in place. Rage burns in my heart, and I feel like I can't breathe.

I did this.

I saved Lucy only for my love to become a death sentence.

Dad's eyes bore into mine, the gun aimed squarely at my chest.

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Lucy

My cheek burns from Mom slapping my face. Twice. Once for fighting her all the way to my bedroom. And once because I've made myself Damiano's whore.

Mom stands before me, shaking with rage from the top of her head down to her pointed stiletto shoes. Her beautiful face is twisted in an ugly grimace.

"How many times?" she seethes, her nostrils white and pinched. "How many times have you screwed your own brother?"

I hold my hand to my stinging cheek and stare at the ground. I'm totally humiliated and aching with worry for Damiano, but I won't be made to feel ashamed for what we've done. I won't let Mom turn it into something sick and twisted. When Ariana walked in on me and Damiano in bed together, my heart dropped so fast I thought I was going to pass out.

But this is a thousand times worse, and I don't know how I'm going to fix this.

Mom grabs my shoulders and shakes me. "I asked you how many times, you disgusting girl. Was that the first time? Has it been going on for years right under our noses?"

Dad must be saying these same things to Damiano right now. I imagine him burning up with shame for what we've done, and it breaks my heart.

I pull away from Mom, and I keep my mouth closed. I wish it had been going on for years. I wish Damiano had taken my virginity the first time he kissed me. I wish he'd fucked me every night and told me he loved me every day. That would make all this pain worth it. I have been given crumbs, and now even those are going to be taken away. Damiano is the only one in the world who makes this cold, suffocating house bearable for me.

This life bearable for me.

Mom flings up her hands impatiently. "You won't speak? Then I can only assume the worst. You have corrupted Damiano with your wicked ways. How, I can't understand. You're sullen and hostile and you chase men away with one sour look. Damiano is good-looking and charming. He could have any woman he wants, but we find the two of you... You down on your..." She covers her mouth and shakes her head, as though she's trying not to be sick.

I clench my fists by my sides. I need to keep my mouth shut and just endure Mom's vicious words. I can't cause more trouble for Damiano by having a screaming match with Mom. Right now, he'll be convincing Dad that we made a mistake. Dad will forbid the family to speak of this again, and that will be that.

Please, please, let that be that.

"If this gets out, our family will never be able to hold our heads up in this city again. Ariana's marriage prospects will be ruined, tainted by your wicked behavior. Everyone will think that Damiano has been screwing both my daughters."

I have to bite back my declaration that Damiano wouldn't touch a spoiled, petty princess like Ariana in a million years. My words must be written all over my face because Mom's eyes narrow in hatred.

"The disrespect you have shown this family. The ingratitude. Your father and I picked you up out of the gutter and gave you the best education. Expensive clothes. This beautiful house to live in. You have paid back our generosity with venom and contempt. There is something rotten inside you, Lucy. I saw it the very first time I looked in your eyes. You were born rotten, and you have grown up rotten. You are impossible to love."

With her words, Mom reaches inside me and wraps her hand viciously around my heart and squeezes. Haven't I always known I'm unlovable?

That's why my real mom abandoned me. She knew I was born broken and dirty, and Mom knows it too.

Red taillights flash in the corners of my vision. My nails dig viciously into my palms.

"We should never have brought you here," Mom seethes.

"I never wanted to come here," I snap back. I'm only making this worse, but I can't help myself. The pain is too big inside me, and it comes spilling out of my mouth. "I never wanted you to be my mother or Dad to be my father. Damiano had to convince me, and I have loathed every moment under this roof that hasn't been spent with him. I hate you. I hate Dad. Every moment I spend with you both and Ariana, I wish I'd never met you."

Mom's eyes flash, and she pulls back her hand and slaps me again with the full force of her hatred. Pain bursts in my raw cheek and my eyes sting.

"You ungrateful little bitch!" Mom storms out of the room and slams the door. A key turns in the lock, the click loud and final.

I sink down to the floor and sob. I've really done it now. The only thing keeping me safe in this house was the pretense that I am dutiful to my parents. I wonder if Mom and Dad will lock me up in here forever and tell everyone I died. I wonder if they'll hurt Damiano because of me. There's been real fear in his eyes when I've asked him what Dad's capable of, echoes of terrible things he's seen that he's keeping from me. He's always told me I don't want to know what Dad might do to us. Maybe I'm about to find out.

With my fist clenched tight against my churning belly, I can do nothing but cry, tears dripping from my cheeks, pattering on the carpet. I've been abandoned. These four walls are my prison.

Just hours ago, Damiano and I were arm in arm. Side by side. We were trying to build alliances. We were partners.

I can't hear anything that's happening outside. Once or twice I contemplate tying sheets together and trying to escape, but I'd probably fall and break my head open on the terrace below. Besides, where would I go?

"Please let me and Damiano get out of this alive," I whisper feverishly. "Don't let him get hurt because of me. Let us be together somehow. He's all I have."

When my bedroom door unlocks and opens sometime later, I look up with fear flaring in my heart, expecting to see Dad and for him to beat me

even harder than Mom did. To my surprise, Damiano comes into my room, and he closes the door behind him. His eyes are hollow, and he can't look me in the face.

He stares at the key in his hands.

Ice dances down my spine. Why does Damiano have that key? Is the man I love now my jailer?

"I'm so sorry, Lucy." Every line of his face is hard and resigned.

I get to my feet, my legs trembling. "What do you mean, you're sorry? What's happened?"

"I tried to convince Dad that nothing was happening between us, or at least that he should pretend he didn't see anything, but he was too angry to listen to me."

I moisten my lips and ask in a small voice, "Will he feel differently when he's calmed down?"

Damiano raises his eyes to mine, and they're bleak. He shakes his head.

The tiny shred of hope I've been carrying in my heart that everything will be okay dies a painful death. "What's going to happen to us?"

"I've been trying to make a plan, but every solution I play out ends with you dead." He slips the key into his pocket and comes forward to take me in his arms, and he says urgently, "Do you understand how much that terrifies me? So this is the plan, for now. You have to run. I'll give you money. You can start a new life somewhere else, and as soon as it's safe, we'll marry."

I stare at him in confusion. "Dad has banished me from the family?"

He hesitates. "This is the only way I can think of to keep you alive."

I clutch his shoulders. "But you'll come with me, won't you? You have to come with me."

Damiano's eyes are filled with pain.

"Damiano, please," I sob. "We can run away. We can be together. Don't you want me more than you want this life? Don't you want me more than all this money and power?"

He takes my hands from his shoulders, grips them in his, and says urgently, "You mean more to me than anything else in this world. I would give this life up in a heartbeat for you, but it's too late."

"It's never too late. We can just get in your car and disappear."

Damiano looks deep into my eyes. "I wish I didn't have to say this, but it's better that you know how much danger you're in. Listen to me carefully.

Dad is this close to killing you. If I run away with you, he will follow us, and he will kill us both.”

I reel back in shock. “What are you talking about? We’re his children. He loves you, even if he doesn’t love me.”

“Dad doesn’t love anyone.” He pulls back his sleeve and shows me the viper tattoo inked into his forearm. “You’ve seen this on my arm. All Dad’s capos carry a viper tattoo. If I run, it will be the ultimate betrayal. He will capture me and cut this tattoo out of my flesh or burn it away with fire. He’s ordered me to do this to others who have betrayed him.”

I search his eyes. I don’t want to ask the question that’s on my lips, but I have to. “And did you?”

He pushes his sleeve down and says bitterly, “Of course I did. I had no choice. I always shielded you from Dad’s brutality, but maybe that was a mistake. You have to understand. I swore an oath to Don Carlucci, and if I break it, I’m dead.”

I press a shaking hand over my mouth. “Then what are we going to do?”

Damiano takes my face in his hands. “You have to run, or he’s going to marry you to someone else.”

I feel like I’m shattering into a million pieces.

“But I don’t want to marry someone else. I want to marry you.” The words burst from me, desperate and raw.

“I know.” He pulls me into his arms. “God, Lucy, I know. Dad wants you married to someone who will keep you away from me. Someone who will...” He can’t finish the sentence.

“Someone who will keep me under control,” I finish bitterly. “Like a prisoner.”

“I won’t let that happen. I’ll find a way—”

“Don’t.” I pull back to look at him. “Don’t promise me things you can’t deliver. You promised we’d find a way to be together, but it’s too late.”

The words hang between us, sharp and accusing.

“I’m so sorry, Lucy.” Damiano presses his forehead to mine. “I love you. That will never change. No matter what happens, you’re mine. You’ll always be mine.”

“Then why does it feel like I’m losing you?”

He doesn’t answer. He just holds me while I cry. Get married. Live with a man who isn’t Damiano. Let him touch me. Have his children. Pretend to

love him. I've never even looked at a man in desire who isn't Damiano, and now I'm supposed to give myself, body and soul, to a stranger?

I touch his handsome face. Trace the strong lines of his jaw. The beautiful lips that have kissed mine so tenderly. Damiano is my home. My everything.

"If I get married, can I stay in Malus?" I ask through my tears. "Can I still be near you?"

Damiano's eyes fill with anger. "Lucy, *no*."

My bedroom door opens, and Mom enters. She looks at me in Damiano's arms, and she doesn't bother to hide her disgust. She thinks we're repulsive. That our attraction to each other is against all the laws of nature, God, and man.

I glare at her from beneath my wet lashes. I don't care what she believes. She's never cared about me. I hate her and Dad more than anyone in the world.

"Well," she says in a brisk tone, addressing Damiano. "Did you tell her?"

"We need more time," he says through clenched teeth.

"No, we don't," I say, in a voice so strong that it surprises me. I wipe the tears from my eyes and face her. I know what Damiano wants, but it's my decision how my heart breaks, not his.

"I'll do what you want," I tell Mom. "I'll marry a man you choose for me."

Triumph lights in Mom's eyes. Damiano seizes my hand. "Lucy, you can't do this."

I keep looking at Mom. "On one condition. I stay in Malus, and Damiano and I see each other whenever we want. You and Dad or my future husband won't try to keep us apart."

Mom's lip curls in disgust. "So you can keep sleeping with your brother?"

"So I can still see my brother!" I cry. "He's the only person I love in the whole world. I won't betray my husband, but I will have my brother in my life."

Damiano looks as though he's going to shatter into a million pieces, but this is the only way. I won't have his kisses.

I won't have his heart.

But I won't lose him forever, and without Damiano, I think I would die.

I grip Damiano's hand for strength and speak quickly to Mom. "And I want a big wedding. Hundreds of guests. No expense spared. Loving speeches from you and Dad. A celebration befitting a Barone daughter. I won't be married off quietly like a shameful, dirty secret."

A big wedding takes time to plan. Anything to delay the inevitable.

Mom's lips press together, and her expression tells me that she thinks I am shameful and dirty, and I don't deserve a big, beautiful wedding. But she wants this problem over and done with. Finally, she says, "That's a lot more than one condition, but fine. If that's what you want."

It's not what I want at all. None of this is what I want, but I'm cornered, and there's only one way out. In a shaking voice, I manage, "Yes, it's what I want."

Mom nods. "Fine. I've been making some phone calls. Tomorrow night, you're going to meet your future husband."

"Tomorrow?" I cry, and Damiano echoes me. He holds my hand in a death grip. I thought I'd have a few months before anything was decided. At least a few weeks. "Who am I marrying?"

"Your father believes there should be stronger ties between the prominent Malus families," Mom says, giving Damiano a devastating side-eye. "Something that Damiano tried to achieve but failed. Assuming he accepts you, you're going to marry a Montoni. It's an excellent match, and far better than you deserve."

"Lucy is not marrying Cristiano Montoni," Damiano snarls.

Mom laughs. "Don Cristiano? Lucy, be the wife of a don? Don't be ridiculous. It's been decided that Ariana is going to marry the Montoni don. Lucy will marry his cousin, Andreas."

The name drops like a stone in my stomach. Andreas Montoni.

A memory surfaces, sharp and unwelcome. The Corinthian Hotel gala, months ago. A blond man materializing at my elbow with a too practiced smile and damp palms. His oily flattery. The way his gaze had lingered on the pendant between my breasts. *I'd be grateful for your...expertise.*

I thought he was a creep.

And now I'm supposed to marry him.

"I remember him," I say faintly. "From the Corinthian gala. He..." I trail off, not wanting to say he made my skin crawl in front of Mom. That his smile never reached his eyes. That something about him felt wrong in a way I couldn't put my finger on.

“Does Ariana know about this?” I ask instead, my voice hollow.

“Your father is telling her the good news right now,” Mom replies.

From several rooms down, we hear a piercing, blood-curdling sound.

Ariana’s anguished scream.

It echoes along the corridor and fills every corner of the house.

Mom’s serene expression doesn’t falter. “Marriage can be a surprise to a young woman, but Ariana is a good, obedient daughter who knows that we have her best interests at heart. Lucy, you had better be sweet and polite when you meet your future husband. You have one chance to make a good impression. I hope I don’t need to spell out what the consequences will be if you don’t win Andreas Montoni’s heart.” Her eyes harden, and so does her voice.

I understand perfectly. If I mess this up, there will be dire consequences, and no second chances.

I tried to be a daughter they could be proud of, but I wasn’t good enough. Now I’m going to be handed off to a man whose touch I already dread. My heart is being ripped out all over again.

“Am I still a prisoner in this room?” I ask.

Mom considers me. “I don’t see that it’s necessary, if you keep your word and behave like a model daughter from now on.”

Damiano is holding tightly to my hand, his eyes filled with anger directed at our mother.

It hurts so much to look at him. I tug my hand from his, grab my purse, and flee the room.

When I pass Ariana’s bedroom door, I hear sobbing from within.

The Barone mansion is filled with misery tonight.

Downstairs, I’m about to open the door into the garage when a hand with painted, pointed nails seizes my arm.

Mom has followed me, and her eyes are bright with malice. She speaks in a soft, menacing tone. “You had better smile for your future husband tomorrow night. If you ruin your engagement, or if one whisper of what you and your brother have been up to taints this family, your death won’t be swift and painless. I will see to it that you are given to my husband’s men to be beaten, raped, and passed around until you beg for death.”

I suck in a frightened breath and struggle to be free of her grip, but she won’t let me go.

“Damiano won’t be coming to save you. He’ll never even find your body, and there will be no grave where he can mourn.” Her nails dig viciously into my flesh. “But maybe we’ll give him photos. Do you think that will break him, Lucy?”



“YOU CAN HAVE something stronger if you need it.”

Adora puts a glass of iced water into my hands and sits on the sofa beside me, holding her own glass. I drove across Malus in the dark to see my best friend. I didn’t know what else to do.

I watch moisture beading on the cold glass in silence, Mom’s devastating threat ringing in my ears. I feel the ghost of Mom’s nails digging into my arms. I used to believe there was something strange about my family. Something false and sinister behind Mom’s and Dad’s smiles.

There’s not just something strange about my family. They’re completely and utterly evil.

“Can you tell me what happened?” Adora asks gently.

I showed up at her home with no explanation or warning. I just seized her in a hug the moment she opened the front door, and I couldn’t let go of her. I look up and meet her beautiful, warm eyes. Her cheeks are pink and her complexion glows. She’s found happiness with Vincenzo, and marriage suits her. I know I won’t be so lucky.

“I’m getting married,” I tell her, and then my composure cracks, and I let out a sob.

“Oh, Lucy,” Adora cries in dismay, and puts her arms around me.

I choke down the tears. I cried all the way here in the car, and my eyes are red and puffy. I have to meet my future husband tomorrow night, and I don’t know how I’m going to pretend that this engagement is anything but coerced if I can’t stop breaking down.

“I’d say congratulations, but this doesn’t look like something you’re happy about. Who are you marrying?”

I give a panicked kind of laugh. “That’s a good question. I should probably pretend I’m over the moon about this proposed engagement.”

Adora looks more confused than ever. “But why?”

“Because Mom and Dad are arranging my marriage to your cousin, Andreas Montoni.”

Adora’s expression is shocked. “Andreas?”

I was already feeling pretty bad about this engagement, but now I feel even worse. “Why do you say it like that? What’s wrong with him?”

It takes Adora a moment to recover. “Nothing’s wrong with him that I know of. I’m just surprised. I didn’t think the Barones had ever met him.”

“I met him once. At a gala at the Corinthian. He made my skin crawl.”

Adora winces. “That bad?”

“His smile never reached his eyes. He looked at me like...like I was merchandise he was evaluating. Damiano wanted to break his fingers for the way he was looking at me.” I shake my head. “And now I’m supposed to marry him.”

Adora’s eyes are troubled. “Lucy, I’m so sorry. I wish I had better things to tell you about Andreas.”

“Tell me anyway. I need to know what I’m walking into.”

She hesitates, choosing her words carefully. “Andreas is ambitious. He wants to prove himself to Cristiano, to be seen as more than just a cousin. He’s smart, but there’s something desperate about him. Like he’s always trying to show he’s the most powerful person in the room.”

“Does Cristiano trust him?”

“I think so?” Adora frowns. “But Andreas seems envious of Cristiano’s position. My brother doesn’t talk about family business with me much, but I know Andreas has been pushing for more responsibility lately. He wants to be a made man. To have real power.”

“And marrying me gives him that,” I say bitterly.

“Marrying a Barone daughter definitely helps. It connects him to one of the most powerful families in Malus.” She squeezes my hand. “I’m sorry. I wish I had better things to say about him.”

“Is he cruel? Will he hurt me?”

“I don’t think so. He’s not violent, as far as I know. But he’s...calculating. Everything he does is for his own advancement.” She meets my eyes. “Just be careful around him, Lucy. Don’t let him use you.”

I stare into the glass clutched in my hands. I don’t think I’ll have much choice about that.

“There’s something else,” Adora says slowly, and something in her tone makes my stomach drop. “A few weeks ago, Andreas was asking me

questions. About the Barone family. About your father's operations. Your security. Where your warehouses are located."

Ice slides down my spine. "Why would he ask that?"

"He said he wanted to be prepared for a possible alliance between our families. That if the Montonis are going to be closer to the Barones, he should understand your business." She shrugs. "It seemed reasonable at the time, though there wasn't much I could tell him, of course. But after what Vincenzo told me happened at that restaurant tonight, the Sokoli attack, I've been wondering..."

"Wondering what?" My voice comes out sharper than I intended.

"How did the Sokolis know you'd all be there? Someone had to tell them. What if Cristiano told Andreas, and Andreas told the Sokolis?" Her eyes are troubled. "I'm probably being paranoid. But be careful, okay? Watch what you tell Andreas. Watch what he asks about."

I nod slowly, my mind racing. The warehouse explosion that almost killed Damiano. The attack at the restaurant where Antonio was shot. Both times, the Sokolis knew exactly where to strike.

Could it be a coincidence?

Or is Andreas Montoni asking questions for a dangerous reason?

"Lucy?" Adora touches my arm, pulling me from my thoughts. "There's something else going on, isn't there? Something important you're not telling me. If you need someone to talk to, I'll be Adora, your friend, not Adora, Cristiano's sister and Andreas's cousin."

I bite my lip, feeling conflicted about what to do. "I'm not supposed to talk about it. To anyone."

Adora's eyes are troubled. As a Montoni and married to a Vici, she knows just how dangerous our world can be. "Of course. I understand. No matter what, I'll always be here for you."

"Thank you," I whisper, tears brimming in my eyes. I wish I'd done more for her when she was suffering at her father's hands. "I'm sorry I didn't know how bad things were for you at home before you married Vincenzo."

"You couldn't have known because I didn't tell anyone. But why are you bringing that up now?" Her kind expression shifts to horrified. "Wait, are your parents treating you the way Dad treated me? Lucy, that's awful. I'm so sorry."

My throat is locked tight with emotion. I shouldn't breathe a word of what's happening at home, but I have to tell someone. "Will you promise me that you won't breathe a word to anyone what I'm about to tell you? It's a matter of life or death. You can't tell Cristiano, and you can't tell your husband either."

"But if your mom and dad are hurting you, maybe Vincenzo can help."

"He can't help. No one can. Mom and Dad...caught me and Damiano."

She frowns in confusion. "Caught you and Damiano doing what?"

I look at her helplessly, wishing I didn't have to spell this out to her. "Caught us together. *Together* together."

Adora's eyes widen. She stares at me for a long time, and to her credit, she doesn't look disgusted. Just surprised. "Together like lovers?"

I nod, clenching my hands on my skirt. Adora knows that Damiano and I weren't born into the Barone family, though Mom and Dad like to pretend to all of Malus that we were. Back in high school, I told Adora that Damiano and I were orphaned when a meth house exploded, without also explaining that it was the first day that Damiano and I met.

Adora chooses her next words carefully. "You and your brother have always been so close. I envied your good relationship with him when we were in high school because my relationship with my brother was never anything special. Damiano's very good-looking and he adores you. The two of you were traumatized as kids, and he's been your knight in, well, black armor ever since. If the two of you were confused and things got carried away..."

She's waiting for me to say that being with Damiano was a mistake, and it will never happen again, and I can't do that. "We weren't confused. It's not the first time things have happened between us. We love each other. Can I tell you a secret?"

"That's not the secret?" she bursts out in surprise.

I take her hand in mine and squeeze it tightly. "There's something that Mom and Dad don't know. You can't tell anyone, because if they find out, they'll kill me. You understand that I'm not exaggerating, don't you? They will murder me and chop me into a million little pieces."

Adora looked worried before, but now she starts to look scared. "I promise I won't tell anyone. I don't want you to die."

I take a deep breath. I have to tell someone, or I think I might go crazy. "Damiano is not my brother by birth. His real sister died in the explosion

that nearly killed us both. When we were at the hospital, Damiano pretended I was his sister, and we've been lying about who we are ever since."

Adora is silent for several seconds as she processes this. "You mean you're not related?"

I shake my head. "No, we're not. We met as strangers when I was ten and he was twelve. Damiano refused to leave my side, and when Mom and Dad chose him to be their son, he insisted that his sister be adopted with him. He fought so hard for me. They never wanted me. They only wanted him. They still only want him. I'm only allowed to keep breathing because they think I'm Damiano's flesh and blood."

"Surely the Barones must have some affection for you after all these years?"

I burst out laughing, but there's nothing funny about this. "Are you kidding? They hate me. If they find out the truth, they'll kill me. If I don't agree to this marriage, they'll kill me. Without Damiano, I may as well die. No one has ever loved me like he does. The only way I can remain in Malus and be close to him is if I marry someone else, and it's breaking my heart."

We're silent for a long time as I try my best not to cry. I fail, and Adora hands me a tissue.

"No wonder you love Damiano. He's completely devoted to you."

I stare at the crumbled tissue in my hands. "I'm sorry about your cousin. I've just confessed to you that I'll never be able to give him my heart."

"Barones and Montonis don't marry for love. I know that better than most."

"But you love your husband."

Her face lightens with love as she smiles. "I do. I love him so much, and he loves me. I wish you could have the same happiness in your marriage."

Wishing isn't going to do me any good. Damiano is going to have to watch me marry another man. I'll probably have to watch him marry another woman. Jealousy sears my insides. For the rest of our lives, we'll be bonded in loveless marriages. I don't know how we're going to survive.

"What can I do to help?" Adora asks.

Adora has already done so much by listening to my secrets and comforting me while I cry. There's nothing else she or anyone else can do. Damiano and I are in a hell of our own making.

I reach for her hand and squeeze it. “You can tell me more about Andreas,” I say quietly. “Everything you know. If I’m going to marry him, I need to know exactly who he is.”



MOM KEEPS me and Ariana busy all the next day. Her venomous attitude toward me is well hidden now, and she’s outwardly nothing but excited that Ariana and I are going to meet our prospective husbands. She smiles as she asks us if we want to go for manicures and offers to help choose our clothes for dinner. Ariana meekly agrees, and there’s enough sharpness in Mom’s eyes that I know I have no choice but to say yes as well. She may not be holding a literal gun to my head, but I feel the press of the barrel.

I don’t get the chance to be alone with Damiano all day, and I feel sick that he’s going to have to endure me sitting next to another man at dinner. I think I’d tear my own eyes out if I watched him meet his future wife.

Ariana and I are the first ones downstairs just before seven that evening. My sister looks beautiful in a pastel blue dress with a matching band holding back her long, sleek hair. Mom chose a burgundy satin dress for me and told me irritably to do “something” with my curls. She loves Damiano’s curls, but she’s always been annoyed by mine. I finger comb my curls and leave them loose. It’s all I have the energy for.

“I never thought you and I would be meeting our future husbands at the same dinner,” I say as I join my sister’s side.

“Don’t talk to me,” she says, staring straight ahead.

“Excuse me?”

“This is all your fault. If you and Damiano had kept your hands off each other, Mom and Dad wouldn’t be marrying us off.”

“Don’t you want to marry the Montoni don? I thought you’d be all over him,” I mutter.

Ariana’s lower lip trembles, and for a moment, her eyes fill with pain.

“Ariana, what’s wrong?”

Her eyes snap to mine, and they’re suddenly furious. “Wrong? Why would anything be wrong? Just shut up.”

My sister has always seemed eager to do whatever Mom and Dad ask of her, but apparently not this time. I wonder why. Is she afraid of marriage, or

does she love someone else?

Damiano comes downstairs and joins us, but as soon as he tries to approach me, Mom and Dad emerge from the living room and step between us.

“Do try to smile, girls,” Mom says, giving me and Ariana a pained look. “This is a happy day. When I was introduced to your father, I was so giddy I think I embarrassed myself.”

Dad says with a chuckle, “Nonsense. You were absolutely perfect.”

Mom beams at him. Neither Ariana nor I smile. Damiano has his eyes fixed on the front door, his jaw tight.

The doorbell rings, and Mom steps forward to open it and welcome our guests. A chill wind seems to sweep through the house as Cristiano Montoni enters, tall and proud and wearing a dark suit.

Cristiano’s eyes sweep the room, cold and assessing, before settling on Ariana. There’s something predatory in his gaze, but also weary. Like a man who doesn’t want to play this game.

Behind him is another blond man, almost as handsome as Cristiano, and he’s introduced to me as Andreas. His body language is tense and uncertain, and I wonder if it’s because he’s in the company of Don Carlucci, Don Cristiano, and Damiano Barone, all of whom are confident, dangerous men. Adora told me that Andreas’s parents aren’t in the mafia, but Andreas wants to be. He wants to prove himself and become one of Cristiano’s made men. I suppose marrying a Barone daughter will make him seem more like one of us. How flattering.

I watch as Andreas seizes my father’s hand with an eagerness that betrays how desperate he is to be accepted.

Meanwhile, Cristiano approaches Ariana with a reserved expression. He’s a good-looking man, with sun-kissed skin and strong features. Plus he’s rich. He’s powerful. He’s already a mafia don. I thought Ariana would be thrilled to meet him. She’s always been so eager to please Mom and Dad, and so desperate to be the perfect daughter.

When she greets him, her smile is forced. She’s performing happiness but barely managing it. I study her face, and beneath the practiced politeness, I see something raw. Heartbreak. Desperation. Fear.

Damiano’s jaw tightens as he watches Cristiano and Ariana. There’s tension between him and Cristiano that’s even more pronounced after the

restaurant ambush that nearly killed us all. I think he's as uncomfortable as I am, watching our sibling being paired off against her will.

I'm so busy observing all of this that I don't realize Andreas is standing in front of me and saying my name. When I turn to look at him, he gives a little smirk and a roll of his eyes, as though he can't believe my attention has been on anyone but him. "Finally."

It's exactly like at the Corinthian gala. That entitled assumption that I should be focused solely on him.

Andreas stares at my hair, my face, my breasts, and my hips, his gaze lingering in a way that makes me want to step back. "Are you older or younger than your sister?" he asks.

Well, hello to you too. What kind of question is that? "Younger by a year."

He looks disappointed. Maybe the older sister is the more sought-after one, like the eldest son in a family being the most important one?

Over his shoulder, Mom is smiling as she watches Cristiano and Andreas speak with their proposed brides-to-be.

"You two don't look much alike," he remarks, glancing between me and Ariana.

I stiffen. Of course we don't. Ariana is Mom and Dad's biological daughter. I'm the street rat they picked up to keep Damiano happy. But I can't say that.

"No, we don't," I say coolly.

I say nothing more because it wasn't really a question. His opinion matters to me less than that of far distant stars.

Dad addresses the room with a smile and holds out an inviting hand. "Let's go in and eat."

As everyone else walks into the dining room, Andreas stays where he is. "But you're beautiful in your own way, aren't you? Your parents sounded pretty desperate to marry you off. Have you been a bad girl, Lucy?"

Andreas is smiling, but there's something strange about this man. Something calculating. The same calculating look I saw at the gala. I catch Mom's eye, and it holds a warning. If I make a scene, this will all be over, and I'll be dead. I bristle and keep my mouth shut.

"Or is it my name you so desperately want?" Andreas smiles. "I get it. The Montoni name is the most prestigious one in Malus, after all."

His arrogance is astounding. I've never felt particularly strongly about being a Barone or the influence my name carries, but right now I feel the urge to snap back at him that a Barone daughter is ten times as prestigious as a second-rate Montoni cousin.

But Mom will be livid if she hears me talking to my future husband that way.

I school my face into blankness and walk into dinner, steeling myself to play the obedient Barone daughter that Mom and Dad want me to be, so that I can keep my head attached to my neck.



DINNER IS TORTURE.

The seating arrangement is strategic and cruel. I'm placed between Andreas and Dad, with Damiano directly across from me. Ariana is on Damiano's right, with Cristiano beside her. Mom sits at the other end of the table, beaming like this is the happiest day of her life.

Every time I glance up, I catch Damiano watching me with such anguish in his eyes that I have to look away. His knuckles are white around his wineglass, and I know he's barely holding himself together.

I also notice the tension radiating from him whenever Cristiano speaks. The alliance Damiano tried to build crumbled before it even began, and Cristiano knows Damiano went behind his father's back to arrange that meeting.

I glance down the table at my sister. She's barely touched her food, pushing it around her plate with trembling hands. Cristiano sits beside her with perfect posture, his expression unreadable as he cuts his meat with precise movements.

"You've barely eaten," Cristiano observes quietly to Ariana. "Is the food not to your liking?"

"It's fine," Ariana says, her voice small. "I'm just not very hungry."

"Nerves?"

Ariana's eyes flash to his face, then away. "I'm not nervous."

"No?" Cristiano takes a sip of his wine. "Then perhaps you're simply unhappy about the prospect of marrying me."

The table goes quiet. Mom's smile falters. Damiano's fork pauses halfway to his mouth.

"Cristiano," Dad says with forced joviality. "I assure you, Ariana is delighted—"

"Are you?" Cristiano asks Ariana directly, ignoring Dad completely. It's a power move. A don doesn't need permission to speak to his future wife. "Delighted?"

My sister's knuckles are white around her fork. For a moment, something raw flashes across her face. Fear, or grief, or rage, but she buries it quickly. When she speaks, her voice is carefully modulated and perfectly controlled.

"I'm honored," she says. It's not an answer to his question, and they both know it. "The Montoni name is very prestigious."

There's a long pause. Ariana's fork trembles slightly in her hand, and she sets it down. She pastes on another smile for Mom's benefit, tight and strained around the edges.

Damiano is watching this exchange with a frown. I wonder what he's thinking. Does he disapprove of Cristiano? Or is he just uncomfortable watching his sisters being claimed by men he doesn't trust?

Andreas, meanwhile, won't stop talking to me.

"So, Lucy," he says, leaning closer than I'd like. "I heard about the incident at the restaurant. Terrible business with the Sokolis. You must have been terrified."

I freeze, my fork halfway to my mouth. I can't believe he's bringing that up. The tension around the dinner table skyrockets. "I was never afraid. I had Damiano with me."

"Of course." He smiles, but it doesn't reach his eyes. "Antonio Conti is still in the hospital, isn't he? Cristiano mentioned the Sokolis are getting bolder."

Across the table, Damiano watches Andreas with sharp, glittering eyes.

Andreas cuts into his steak. "I imagine your father is taking extra security precautions. The Barones must be making sure the Sokolis can't predict your movements again."

The question is phrased casually, but there's nothing casual about it. He glances around the table, his eyes finally resting on Dad, as though expecting Don Carlucci to confirm his assumptions.

Dad is deep in conversation with Cristiano and doesn't answer. Andreas turns back to me expectantly.

"I wouldn't know," I say. "Dad doesn't discuss those things with me."

"No?" Andreas raises his eyebrows. "But Cristiano mentioned you were at the jewelry auction at the Corinthian. You were working for Don Carlucci, weren't you? Helping with the gems?"

My stomach drops. I've been asking Adora about him, and he's obviously been asking Cristiano about me.

"Andreas." Damiano's voice cuts across the table like a blade. His eyes are black and lethal. "My sister isn't interested in discussing business. Perhaps you should focus on your dinner instead."

The temperature around us drops ten degrees.

"I helped out that night," I say carefully. "But that's not the same as being involved in security decisions."

"Of course not." He smiles again. "Still, you must overhear things. Living in the same house as Don Carlucci and Damiano."

"Andreas." Dad has finally noticed our conversation, and his voice cuts across the table, sharp and warning. "This isn't appropriate dinner conversation. The ladies don't need to hear about business matters."

"My apologies, Don Carlucci." Andreas sits back, but I catch something in his eyes. Frustration. Hunger for information.

The rest of dinner passes in a blur. Andreas tries again, more subtly this time, asking about Dad's associates and which families we're closest to. Always phrased innocently, always with that charming smile.

But I'm watching him now. Really watching. And I don't like what I see.

Down the table, Cristiano and Ariana have settled into uncomfortable silence. When Ariana tries to make conversation, Cristiano responds with the bare minimum required by politeness.

"Ariana is quite accomplished on horseback," Mom interjects desperately, trying to fill the awkward silence. "She's been riding since she was six. She's won several competitions."

"How impressive," Cristiano replies.

Ariana takes a careful sip of wine, her movements precise and controlled, like she's trying very hard not to break.

Mom beams as if this stilted exchange is a rousing success.

When dinner finally ends, I feel like I've run a marathon. Andreas walks me to the door, standing too close, his hand hovering near my lower back but not quite touching. He knows Damiano is watching, and he's testing how far he can push.

"I look forward to getting to know you better, Lucy," Andreas says. "We have so much to discuss. About your family. About the future."

I force a smile. "Good night, Andreas."

Tonight didn't feel like a polite dinner with my prospective husband. It felt like an interrogation.

There's something very wrong with Andreas Montoni.

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Lucy

A week after the engagement dinner, Andreas picks me up in his sleek black Mercedes. He's all smiles and charm as he opens the car door for me, but I notice the little things he doesn't do. Doesn't ask how I'm doing. Doesn't ask if I slept well. If I have any preferences for where we go today.

Damiano would have asked. Damiano would have noticed the shadows under my eyes and the tension in my shoulders.

But Andreas just slides into the driver's seat, and says, "I thought we'd pick out your engagement ring today. I know a jeweler in the diamond district. Very exclusive. Only the best for my future wife."

My future wife. The casual possessiveness makes my skin crawl. He's assuming I'm going to marry him, without bothering to ask if I'm ready. I suppose he already cleared everything with Mom and Dad behind my back, and that's good enough for him.

I force a smile. "Sounds great."

"You're going to love this place," Andreas continues as he drives. "They cater to all the top families in Malus. The Montonis have been clients for generations. Cristiano will no doubt buy Ariana's engagement ring there." He glances at me, and his smile is all white teeth and no warmth. "Though, of course, yours will be even more impressive."

I notice he doesn't ask what I want. It's about what everyone else will think. What they'll say. How impressive we'll look.

"I have some ideas about wedding venues," he continues. "The Malus Grand Hotel has an excellent ballroom. Very prestigious. I'll set up a viewing."

Of course he will. Without bothering to ask what I want.

I stare out the window, remembering Damiano at the jewelry auction, bidding on those canary diamonds, not because they were the most expensive, but because I loved them. Seeing me smile was worth two hundred thousand dollars to him.

"Here we are," Andreas says, pulling up to a gleaming storefront with *Castellano Fine Jewelers* etched in gold on the window.

Inside, the store is all marble and crystal chandeliers, dripping with old money and exclusivity. A distinguished older man in an impeccable suit greets us immediately, and Andreas introduces him as Mr. Castellano, then explains what he's looking for.

He leads us to a private viewing room and begins bringing out trays of rings. Massive diamonds, intricate settings, all breathtakingly expensive.

All wrong.

"What do you think of this one?" Mr. Castellano holds up a ring with an enormous cushion-cut diamond surrounded by smaller stones. "Five carats, VVS1 clarity, D color. Exceptional quality."

I examine it carefully. The stone is flawless, perfectly cut with excellent fire and brilliance. The setting is platinum, well crafted. It's objectively beautiful. It's also ostentatious and absolutely not my taste.

"It's pretty," I say neutrally, setting it back down.

"Pretty?" Andreas laughs, and there's an edge to it. Like I've said something wrong. "Lucy, it's magnificent. This is exactly what I was thinking. The size makes a statement. Everyone will be talking about this ring."

There it is again. Everyone will be talking about it. Everyone will notice. Everyone will be impressed. What about if I like it? Does it suit me? Will I be happy wearing it every day for the rest of my life?

Mr. Castellano looks between us, his professional smile faltering slightly. "Perhaps the young lady would like to see some other options? We have some beautiful emerald cuts, or perhaps a more delicate setting."

“No, no,” Andreas interrupts, his voice sharp. “Lucy knows quality when she sees it. Don’t you, darling?” He picks up the massive ring and reaches for my hand. “Let’s see how it looks.”

He slides it onto my finger without waiting for my answer. It’s heavy, cold, and gaudy.

“Perfect,” Andreas declares, admiring how it looks on my hand. “We’ll take it.”

I pull my hand back slightly, and his smile tightens. For just a moment, I see irritation flicker across his face. Then it’s gone, replaced by that charming mask.

I force myself to smile as my heart sinks like a stone in deep water. This is my life now. A man who makes decisions for me and who cares more about status than my happiness.

I think of Damiano, and my throat tightens with unshed tears. I have to look away before Andreas notices.

“We’ll need it sized, of course,” Andreas is saying to Mr. Castellano. “How long will that take?”

“A few days. I can have it ready by Friday.”

“Excellent.” Andreas stands, already pulling out his credit card. “Lucy, why don’t you look around the store while I handle this?”

I take off the ring and get shakily to my feet. Everything’s happening so quickly. If I don’t get away from Andreas right now, I’m going to fall apart. “Actually, I’ve just remembered that I have to go. I need to do some shopping. It’s very important. For the wedding.”

“But, Lucy—”

Before Andreas can stop me, I hurry out of the jewelry store without looking back. Outside, I walk quickly along the street, taking deep gulps of fresh air and trying to calm my racing heart. The wind is cold, but I don’t care. Anything to feel something other than the suffocating weight of that ring.

I miss Damiano with an ache that feels like someone’s carved him out of my heart. I’ve barely seen him. Dad keeps him busy with meetings and errands, and Mom makes sure I’m occupied whenever Damiano’s home. They’re keeping us apart. Making sure we can’t find a moment alone. And it’s working. We haven’t really talked. Haven’t really touched. They’ve built a wall between us, and I’m on the wrong side, watching him fade into the distance.

I walk for a long time, my feet carrying me through the city streets without direction. The sun has shifted lower in the sky by the time I finally realize hours have passed, and I should go home.

And then I see him.

Andreas.

He's crossing the street toward a black car. I watch as he approaches it and gets into the passenger seat. Someone is sitting in the driver's seat, and I move surreptitiously closer to get a better look at the man.

I don't recognize the stranger, but his hand is resting on the steering wheel as he talks to my fiancé.

My blood turns to ice.

There, on the back of his hand, dark against his skin, is a spider tattoo.

The Sokoli marker.

I duck behind a parked car, my heart hammering so hard I can feel it in my throat.

Andreas is meeting with a Sokoli. Our deadly enemies. There is no innocent explanation for this.

My hands shake as I pull out my phone and carefully angle it to capture a photo of them. The quality isn't great because the car window reflects some of the light, but I can make out Andreas and the man with his spider tattoo clearly. I take three more shots from slightly different angles, just to be sure.

Their conversation looks intense. The Sokoli man is gesturing, animated, and Andreas is leaning in close, nodding. At one point, Andreas pulls out his phone and shows the man something on the screen. Whatever it is makes the Sokoli man smile and nod with satisfaction, and then Andreas is getting out of the car.

My mind is racing as I hurry away.

I need to find Damiano. I need to tell him what I saw.

As I enter the house, I hear voices from Dad's study. Dad and Damiano, their voices not raised, but tense, like they're arguing about something.

Tensions are too high. I can't tell Damiano what I've seen. Not yet.

If Damiano knows Andreas is meeting with Sokolis, he'll confront him, or attack him, and then what? I could start a war we can't win. I could get Damiano killed. Dad might think I'm lying to get out of the marriage and making up stories to get back to Damiano.

I need more evidence. Something irrefutable that Dad can't ignore or explain away.

I slip up to my room and lock the door, my hands still shaking. Then I pull out a notebook and make a physical record of my suspicions, in case I need to refer to it later, my handwriting getting shakier as adrenaline courses through me. I finish off by emailing the incriminating photos of Andreas to myself as a backup.

I read over my notes, trying to puzzle this out. What does Andreas gain by working with the Sokolis?

I think about what Adora said, that he's always wanted to prove himself and have real power. Maybe he thinks the Sokolis are the answer, and he's betting on them to take over Malus. He wants to be on the winning side when the dust settles.

But I need more proof. Enough that when I expose him, no one will be able to deny it or explain it away.

I'm not the pretty trophy Andreas thinks he's marrying. I'm a Barone daughter. I'm Damiano's partner. When the time comes, Andreas Montoni is going to learn what happens when you underestimate Lucy Barone.

Damiano

I'm going to kill Andreas Montoni.

The thought pounds through my head with every crate I haul, every shipment I approve for the warehouse. Antonio and Giovanni exchange worried glances, but they don't say anything. They're smart enough to recognize murder in a man's eyes.

Antonio is still recovering from the gunshot wound. His shoulder is bandaged, and he moves carefully, but he insisted on coming back to work because sitting at home drives him crazy.

I know the feeling.

I keep picturing Andreas clasping Lucy's shoulders and kissing her cheek like he already owns her, and her letting him. Just standing there and taking it because she has no choice, and that knowledge is a knife twisting in my gut. If he kisses her, will she allow that too? What if he tries undressing her? I go mad with jealousy just picturing it, and I nearly pick a fight with Giovanni just so I can punch someone.

Giovanni is nothing but loyal to me. I need to get a fucking grip.

"Boss, you all right?" Antonio asks, watching me with concern.

"Fine."

"You don't look fine. You look like you want to murder someone."

"I do." I don't elaborate.

In the middle of the afternoon, I make up an excuse and go home, intending to get changed and go for a run. An hour pounding the sidewalk with music blasting through my earbuds is the only way I'm going to dampen the rage simmering in my blood.

As I head inside through the garage and kitchen and make my way toward the stairs, the front door opens, and it's Lucy. She's wearing a pretty printed dress and heels, and a shade of lipstick that makes her look incredibly kissable.

Right behind her is Andreas, walking into my home like he owns it. Like he owns Lucy.

Lucy sees me, and her eyes drop guiltily to the ground. Andreas moves toward me with a grin, claps me on the shoulder like we're old friends. It takes every ounce of self-control I have not to break his wrist.

He strides down the hallway toward Dad's study.

"Where's he going?" I ask Lucy, my voice dangerously low.

She's still staring at the ground, and she can't answer me. I notice she has her left hand hidden behind her back.

Icy apprehension flows down my spine. She wouldn't have. She couldn't have. The dinner was only two weeks ago. "Lucy. Let me see your hand."

She shakes her head and tries to sidestep me, but I move in front of her.

"What are you hiding?"

"Nothing. Don't worry about it, Damiano."

She tries to step around me again, but I seize her wrist and drag it between us, making her show me.

I feel like I've been punched. The pain is slow and crushing, like my chest is caving in.

There's a diamond engagement ring sparkling on Lucy's ring finger.

It's massive. Tasteless. Everything Lucy isn't. I hate it with every fiber of my being.

"Lucy," I breathe, my voice hollow. "When did this happen?"

"It needed resizing. We picked it up today." Her voice is small.

The image of Andreas sliding this ring onto her finger, of her allowing it, makes me want to break something. In a few months, maybe less, she'll walk down an aisle toward Andreas Montoni, and I'll have to watch. "And you said yes."

“What choice did I have? You know I don’t have a choice, Damiano.” She adds bitterly, “If you’re imagining he went down on one knee and asked me to marry him, think again. He asked Dad, and then he put this ring on my finger. It’s not an engagement ring. It’s a leash.”

An ugly leash. The canary diamonds I bought her were chosen because they made her eyes light up.

“It’s hideous.”

A surprised laugh escapes her. “It is, isn’t it?”

Andreas doesn’t care what Lucy wants. He cares about status. About showing off. I hate him with a burning, visceral rage that threatens to consume me. I hate every person and every circumstance that’s putting Lucy in another man’s bed.

“I should rip this off your finger. I should put my own ring on your finger. One you actually chose. One that means something.” I pull her closer. “You’re mine, Lucy. Not his. Mine.”

“I know.” Tears are sliding down her cheeks now. “I know I’m yours. But this is the only way to keep us both alive.”

I pull her into my arms, and this time she doesn’t resist. She collapses against me, and I feel her body shaking with silent sobs. My hand tangles in her hair. For these few stolen seconds, she’s mine. Not his. Mine.

I hear footsteps. Andreas is coming back, probably looking for Lucy. She must hear them too, because she pulls away from me quickly, wiping at her eyes.

“I have to go,” she says.

“Lucy—”

“He can’t know how I feel about you.” She pulls away and hurries down the hall toward Andreas, who’s wearing the satisfied smile of a man who thinks he’s claimed something precious. I watch her go, barely breathing, jealousy raging in my heart as she moves toward her future husband.

Andreas thinks he’s won and believes he’s claimed something that belongs to me.

But he’s wrong.

Lucy is mine. And I will find a way to get her back.

Lucy

I've always felt pleasure when gazing upon fine jewelry, even when I was very small. Ever since I can remember, I have dawdled in front of jewelry store windows because the sight of all the sparkling gems made me feel good. I don't know where these feelings come from, because it's not like I was raised among diamonds and rubies. The stones don't elicit fond memories of home. The only jewelry my birth mom owned were cheap bits and pieces bought in drugstores that sometimes turned her skin green.

Once I became a Barone, I was suddenly surrounded by women who wear the most beautiful necklaces, earrings, and bracelets. Mom—my Barone mom—and her friends all wear the real thing. Timeless, expensive pieces that shine and sparkle and elevate them to the level of princesses and queens. At the end of the day, Mom carefully takes her jewelry off, lays it on velvet, and locks it up tight in pretty boxes.

Jewels are coveted. Protected. Desired.

They can also be traded for power.

I'm no diamond necklace in Mom's and Dad's eyes. That would be Ariana. But even she isn't the crowning jewel in her family. Damiano is our prince who will one day be king. He can never be traded, offered, or sold.

Every time I catch sight of the ring Andreas pushed onto my finger, panic slams through me, blaring in my ears like an airhorn. I'm going to

marry Andreas Montoni. I'm going to let him undress me, touch me, have my unwilling body, while I pretend I like it. All the while, I'll be aching for Damiano, and he'll be consumed by furious jealousy.

We're both going to be miserable for the rest of our lives.

"Lucy, pay attention. The satin or the lace?"

My head snaps up. I'm sitting on a pristine white sofa in a brightly lit shop that's filled with racks of enormous, puffy white dresses. A shop girl is holding up a draped satin gown in one hand, and a lace gown with a mermaid skirt in the other.

"The satin," I say.

Mom shakes her head. "The lace. It's more traditional. Go and try it on."

Why did she even ask me? I get up from the sofa and go with the shop girl to try on the dress that Mom prefers. It has a tight bodice and sleeves that make me feel suffocated, and fussy, itchy lace around the neckline. I emerge from the changing room and stand before Mom and Ariana, waiting for their approval. My sister is gazing off to one side as though wishing she were far, far away from here.

Mom nods. "That gown is perfect. Demure, respectful, and well-bred."

Everything I'm not.

"What do you think, darling?" she asks me.

I open my mouth to tell her that I like it, but the words stick in my throat. I've pretended to everyone that I'm happy about this marriage, and I even managed to smile when Andreas pushed the horrible engagement ring onto my finger. I don't have it in me to feign happiness with this horrible dress.

"I hate it."

Mom's eyes flash with anger. She longs to hurl a diatribe of sharp, angry words at me, about how I should be more grateful because she and Dad are paying for this expensive wedding, but the staff in the store will hear, and what if they tell other Malus families that the Barones came in here and caused a scene?

Mom forces a smile. "Then try the satin. If you must."

As the assistant helps me into the satin dress, longing pierces my heart. It's a beautiful gown with off-the-shoulder straps and an hourglass silhouette. A low draped bodice makes it both elegant and sexy, and the long, lustrous skirt has a daring slit. As I stare at my reflection, I imagine

myself walking down the aisle toward Damiano wearing this dress. I can picture the glow of love in his face as he watches me draw closer and closer and hear the music swelling around us.

The assistant meets my gaze in the mirror. “You love this one, don’t you? I can tell. This is the happiest you’ve looked the whole time you’ve been here.”

I stroke the lustrous fabric. “It’s a dress to wear to marry the man of my dreams.”

She beams at me. “Your husband-to-be is a lucky man.”

I’m still dreaming about Damiano when I step out of the changing room to show Mom. It takes her a fraction of a second to shake her head. “All wrong. Completely improper. No daughter of mine is going to have that low of a neckline on her wedding day, and that’s an indecent amount of leg for a bride to show.”

I look down at myself and then back up at her. “Mom, it’s not like I have that much cleavage showing, and when I reach the altar, I’ll make sure I stand so that the slit is barely open.”

Just let me have this, I beg her silently. I won’t be marrying Damiano, but I’ve already set my heart on him seeing me in this dress. He’s to be one of the groomsmen, and with him at the altar, I’ll be able to pretend for as long as it takes to walk down the aisle that I’m marrying him. At least I’ll get to see his face when he sees me in this dress, even if I’ll be promising myself to Andreas.

My protests fall on deaf ears. Mom turns to the assistant. “No cleavage. No slits. My daughters are traditional, virginal brides. Not a pair of whores.”

The assistant turns an embarrassed shade of red, and Mom realizes she’s let her nasty temper show in public. She quickly smothers her fury with a smile. “I apologize for my language. It’s a stressful time for us, planning two weddings. Lucy, try on the lace gown again. Now.”

Defeated, I follow the assistant back to the changing room. I hate the lace gown even more the second time. Maybe I could find a compromise between the tight, stuffy dress and the sexy satin one, but what would be the point? I could wear the most beautiful gown in the world, but I’ll still be marrying Andreas.

By the time I’ve taken the hateful lace dress off and emerged from the changing room, Mom has put a down payment on it, and that’s that.

Mom turns to my sister, who hasn't said a word the past ninety minutes. "We may as well have you try on a few dresses as well, Ariana."

"Yes, Mom," she says automatically.

"I'll select a few options for you. You may accompany me if you wish."

Mom crosses the room to a wall of dresses, but Ariana stays where she is on the sofa. It's been decided that I will marry before Ariana. I suppose Mom and Dad trust me less than they trust my sister, and they want to get my wedding out of the way.

Ariana parades before us in a succession of wedding gowns. Mom orders her to turn left, turn right, do a twirl, and Ariana joylessly obeys. Mom smiles, and her eyes glow. She's like a doll Mom is playing dress-up with.

Finally, I can't stand it anymore. "I know you don't give a damn about me, but you love Ariana. Doesn't it bother you that she's miserable?"

"Of course she's not miserable," Mom replies, and calls out to Ariana, "I'm not sure about all that beading on you, darling."

"Why don't you look at your daughter? Really look at her. She's miserable."

Mom spares Ariana's face the briefest glance, and her lips thin in what might be dismay. Even she can't deny how unhappy Ariana looks. "Every bride has a certain amount of nerves. You're happy to be marrying Cristiano, aren't you, Ariana?"

"Yes, Mom," Ariana says quietly.

Mom gives a nod of satisfaction. "Good girl. Let's see you in the tulle again."

Nearly two hours later, Mom has narrowed Ariana's potential wedding dresses down to four that have a full tulle skirt, but she hasn't decided which one.

While Mom talks to the salesperson about meeting with the designer for a longer consultation, I turn to Ariana beside me on the sofa.

"Are you okay?"

Away from Mom, Ariana doesn't bother to pretend, and she replies flatly, "Of course I'm not okay."

"I'm sorry this is so hard for you."

"I don't need sympathy from someone who fucks her own brother."

I was expecting her to say something like that, and it doesn't deter me from my point. "If you don't want to marry Cristiano, then you should say

something to Mom and Dad. I'm being punished and forced to marry Andreas, but you've never done anything wrong."

Ariana gives a short bark of laughter. "Andreas is such an idiot, and you're going to be married to him for the rest of your life."

"You don't have to sound so happy about it."

"I'll take my pleasures where I can find them." She regards me with cold eyes. "I never breathed a word about you and Damiano to anyone. I think you're both disgusting, but I kept my mouth shut."

"I know. Thank you."

"I didn't do it for you. I did it for me."

Mom is still in deep conversation with the salesperson and shows no sign that she'll be finished anytime soon. "If you wanted to keep riding horses after you're married, I'm sure Cristiano won't stop you. If you're not ready for children, take birth control. Secretly, if you have to. I'm going to."

It's a wife's duty to give her husband her body, but that doesn't mean I'll pretend to enjoy it, and I'm not having his children. There's almost no divorce in our world, but if Andreas thinks I'm barren, there's a slim chance he'll eventually get rid of me. But knowing my luck, he'll suggest we adopt instead, like Mom and Dad did.

Ariana gives me an incredulous look. "Horses and getting pregnant? You really think that's what I'm upset about?"

"Isn't it?"

"You have no idea about anything, Lucy. Keeping the peace in that house was a full-time job. A job you made so much harder. Not you and Damiano. *You*, Lucy. You're always provoking Mom and talking back to Dad. Whenever you've angered them, I've been the one to placate them. If Mom and Dad are angry, I'm the one who suffers. You're so selfish."

"How are you the one who suffers?" I ask incredulously.

"Because when they're angry, I have no freedom. They want to know where I've been and who I've been with. They're cranky. Suspicious. You might have no life outside our brother, but I've been trying to live mine, and you made it so much harder. I know you think my life is shallow. Shopping and horses, right?" She laughs humorlessly. "I've worked so hard to make everyone think that I'm the sweetest, most well-behaved little Barone girl ever, so secretly, I can live my real life. All I wanted was some time to myself before I had to do my duty. A few more years to call my own before I marry someone of Mom and Dad's choosing. You ruined that, Lucy. You

took my life away from me.” She’s fighting tears, and her hands are clenched in her lap.

“I don’t understand. What life did I take away from you?”

“None of your business,” she says bitterly, glaring around at all the wedding dresses as though she hates each and every one of them even more than I do. “I don’t need or want you standing up to Mom for me. It’s too late. Don’t even talk to me from now on.”

“Fine,” I say under my breath. “Forget I said anything.”

“Easy. I never think about you anyway.”

Mom finally finishes her conversation and returns to us, her eyes bright with purpose. “Let’s go, girls. Lingerie next. There’s a boutique across the street.”

I’m getting to my feet, but I freeze. “More shopping?”

“You seem to think we have all the time in the world to plan this wedding, Lucy. We are on a strict deadline. Let’s go.”

Ariana follows obediently, and I trail after them. We’ve just started planning my wedding, and I’m already over it. And what does she mean, strict deadline? As far as I’m aware, we don’t have a venue booked yet.

Gerardo, our bodyguard, escorts us across the street to the lingerie boutique. He’s one of Dad’s most trusted capos, and he’s been with the family for fifteen years. Lately, I’ve been paying more attention to who Dad assigns to protect us.

The lingerie boutique is called Seraphina’s, and it’s all silk and lace and soft lighting. As the style of Ariana’s gown hasn’t been decided on yet, she gets a reprieve from trying on lingerie. Meanwhile, I’m kitted out with a full bridal set. There’s nothing demure and well-bred about the lingerie. The sheer corset, thong, and suspenders set is sexy as hell. Thank heavens Mom doesn’t insist that I model them for her.

I stand before the mirror in the changing room, hating that Andreas is going to be the one who sees me wearing this lingerie. Andreas is going to be the man who takes off my wedding gown after the reception, and his clumsy, pawing hands will touch my body. Most of all, I hate that Andreas is going to be the man who takes my virginity.

My skin crawls just thinking about it. I hurriedly take off the lingerie and put my clothes back on.

When I emerge from the changing room, Mom is holding up a white silk negligee. “What about this for the wedding night?”

“It’s fine.”

“Fine?” She frowns. “Lucy, you need to show some enthusiasm.”

Before I can respond, the boutique door chimes. I glance over and my stomach drops.

Andreas.

He’s wearing one of his perfectly tailored suits, all charm and confidence as he spots us and crosses the boutique.

“There you are,” he says, smiling at me. “I was hoping I’d catch you.”

Mom beams. “Andreas! What a lovely surprise.”

No kidding it’s a surprise. How did he find us here? It’s like he’s been following us.

“I was in the neighborhood and couldn’t resist stopping by to see my beautiful bride.” He kisses my cheek, and I force myself not to pull away. “Wedding shopping?”

“Lingerie shopping,” Mom says with a conspiratorial smile. “For the wedding night.”

Andreas’s eyes light up in a way that makes me want to be sick. “How wonderful. I can’t wait.”

“Ariana,” Andreas greets my sister. Then his eyes find Gerardo, standing near the entrance. “And Gerardo. Good to see you again.”

Gerardo nods politely. “Mr. Montoni.”

“Actually, Gerardo, I’m glad you’re here.” Andreas approaches him, his manner casual and friendly.

Mom beckons me over to look at more negligees, but I keep one ear pricked to hear my fiancé’s conversation.

“I wanted to thank you personally for taking such good care of Lucy. I know Don Carlucci only assigns his best men to family protection.”

Here it comes. I can feel it. He’s going to do it again. Fish for information while pretending to make conversation.

“Just doing my job, sir,” Gerardo says.

“Of course, of course.” Andreas lowers his voice, but I’m close enough to hear. “I’ve been meaning to ask, with the wedding coming up soon, I want to make sure I understand the security protocols. As Lucy’s future husband, I need to know how to keep her safe.”

My heart starts pounding. Andreas is so confident to the point of being blatant.

Gerardo's expression remains neutral. "You should discuss security arrangements with Don Carlucci, Mr. Montoni."

"Absolutely, absolutely. But you're the one who's with her day-to-day. What kind of rotations are you running? How many bodyguards and enforcers do the Barones have?"

"Security protocols are confidential, sir."

Andreas holds up his hands in a placating gesture. "I'm not asking for specifics. I just want to know if Barone security is being stretched too thin. Should I coordinate more closely with Don Carlucci's security team?"

"That would be a conversation for you and Don Carlucci."

"You're right, you're right." Andreas nods, but he's not done. He leans in closer, his voice dropping even lower. "Between you and me, I've noticed the warehouse schedules have changed recently. More frequent shipments, different routes. Is that because of the Sokolis?"

I see Gerardo's jaw tighten, like he suspects what Andreas is doing. "Mr. Montoni, I don't discuss business operations. If you have questions about warehouse schedules or shipment routes, you need to speak with Don Carlucci."

"Of course. You're absolutely right." Andreas backs off. "I apologize if I overstepped. I'm just trying to be helpful. I'm going to be family soon, after all."

"I understand, sir."

But Gerardo's tone suggests he understands something very different than what Andreas is implying. His eyes are hard, suspicious. He knows Andreas was seeking information.

Good. Let him be suspicious. I have the photos from the Sokoli meeting. I have his questions from the engagement dinner. And now Gerardo has seen him fish for information. The evidence is mounting.



AT HOME, I carry the embossed paper carrier bag containing my bridal lingerie upstairs to my room. Damiano appears in my doorway a moment later. He's wearing black pants and a black shirt with the sleeves rolled up and pushed past his elbows. His dark eyes are stormy, his curls are falling into his eyes, and the viper tattoo on his arm hisses menacingly. He looks so

good that I want to throw myself into his arms and beg him to make me forget every horrible thing that's happening to us.

He eyes the carrier bag curiously. "What's that?"

I hesitate, not wanting to torment him even more than I already am, but Damiano's not going to go away until I tell him something. "Lingerie."

His gaze sharpens, and he strides into my room. "Bridal lingerie?" He takes the carrier bag from me and looks inside, transfixed by the sight. He swallows with effort and says huskily, "Lucy. You'll look beautiful in these."

If only it were Damiano I was marrying, and that it's him who is going to see me wearing these lacy garments on my wedding night. I take the sheer corset out of the bag and hold it up to my body, craving a taste of how things might have been between us. "Do you think so?"

Damiano's eyes rove over me, and I can tell he's picturing me wearing nothing but the tempting white lace. "Lucy. I know so."

"I think this lingerie will go to waste on my husband."

"It will be a complete fucking waste on that idiot. He wouldn't deserve you in a million years of trying." Damiano reaches into the bag and pulls out the matching lace suspender belt. Lips parted, thumbing the fabric, he lets out a low, ragged, "*Christ*."

My core clenches and aches. I'm burning with need for Damiano. I've tried quitting him cold turkey, but I'm craving him more than ever. My heart pounding, I move past him, close the door, and put my back against it. "This set cost over a thousand dollars. Someone with taste should appreciate them. I could...put them on."

Two unspoken words hang in the air.

For you.

I could put them on for you.

Damiano stares at me, and I watch as his chest rises and falls.

"I just thought you could tell me how the lingerie looks. Maybe it will look terrible, and I should return them."

"It won't look terrible, sis."

I put my fingertips against his chest and gently propel him backward until he sits down on my bed. "Let's find out. Close your eyes."

After giving me a long, searching look, he does.

I strip slowly down to my underwear, pausing every so often to check that his eyes are still closed. I unclasp my bra, slip off my panties, and drop

them beside him on the bed. “Don’t open your eyes. I’m completely naked right now.”

Damiano’s Adam’s apple bobs as he swallows, and his hands, which are resting on his thighs, tighten into fists. His handsome face is tilted up to mine, his velvety black lashes resting on his cheeks. He’s wound tight with the anticipation of seeing me in my bridal lingerie. Throughout all the hideous days and nights to come with Andreas, I’ll have this memory of Damiano to cling to.

There are white stockings to go with the suspenders, and I put them on, slowly drawing them up my legs. I let the suspender straps snap against my thighs, and Damiano smothers a groan.

I’m ready. I could tell him to open his eyes.

But I don’t want him just to look at me.

Bracing my hands on his shoulders, I ease myself down into his lap. My thighs wrap around his hips, and I take his face in my hands. With my lips close to his, I whisper, “You can open your eyes.”

Damiano does, and his hands seize my waist as he takes in the sight of me. His pupils are blown and brown eyes are almost black as they linger on my face. I begin to wonder if he has forgotten all about the lingerie until his fingers push beneath the suspender belt. He lowers his gaze and drinks in the sight of my breasts, pushed high by the corset, the lace covering but not concealing my nipples.

Damiano plants a slow kiss against my throat. “I never thought I’d be allowed to hold you again.”

I arch my back and rock against him. No one will ever look at me the way Damiano does. No one will ever make me feel this beautiful and loved.

“My lingerie. What do you think? Is it worth the money that Mom spent?”

“Lucy, you’re a goddess,” he breathes.

I turn my head to the side to admire our reflection in the mirror. The long, muscular lines of his body are curved possessively around mine. We fit together so perfectly, me dressed in white lace and nestled in his big, dangerous arms.

He meets my eyes in the mirror, and his are filled with reckless need. “Lucy, I love—”

I quickly cover his mouth with my hand. “Don’t. We have no future, so there’s no point in saying it. All we have is this moment, and I want to live

in it with you.”

He takes my face in his hands. “Whenever you leave my sight, I die over and over again. So give me your lips and let me live.”

“Damiano,” I cry desperately.

He slants his mouth over mine in a hungry, devouring kiss. A kiss that means *I need you* and *I love you* and *goodbye* all at once. A last kiss, because we can never do this again. I lose myself in the kiss, giving in to him completely. His fingers whisper up my back. His body moves against mine, desperate for more.

“Can I have you?” he pants between kisses. “Please, Lucy. You’re the only woman I’ll ever want.”

“There’s a ring on my finger. I belong to another man.”

He cups the back of my head and kisses me insistently. “There are no other men. There’s only me. Don’t you fucking dare say that again.”

I let his kisses devour me, growing drunk on his intensity. “I’m still a virgin. I was saving myself all these years for you, Damiano.”

He buries his face in my breasts with a groan. “For me, my love?”

“Of course for you. I would have given myself to you years ago, after the kiss in the diner when I was sixteen and you were eighteen and covered with Sokoli blood.”

He caresses my cheeks with his knuckles and takes a ragged breath. “I wanted you too, but I had to protect us.”

“In public you did. In private, I could have been yours.”

He nods bleakly, holding me tight. “I know that now. We were going to be found out anyway, so I wish I had kissed you the moment we were alone, and then all night long in my bed. If I could do it all again, I would have made you mine that night, and every night after.”

My heart aches for the sweetness we might have had together. “But now it’s too late.”

“It doesn’t have to be. Are you wet for me, Lucy?” Damiano whispers in a darker voice. “Are you soaking through your bridal lingerie for the man you love?”

I put my lips against his ear. “Are you hard, even though you’re forbidden to touch me?”

Damiano sinks his teeth into my shoulder in a hungry love bite. He shifts beneath me, about to turn around and tumble me onto the mattress.

He'll pull my lace underwear aside and thrust into me, hard and deep, claiming me now and forever.

But the two of us are cursed to be interrupted before we can find any pleasure together.

Andreas Montoni pushes open my bedroom door with the confidence of a man who thinks he owns me. "Lucy, good news. I've confirmed with the venue, and the date has been set for three weeks from..." The smirk on his lips fades away as he sees me and Damiano locked tight around each other. "What the fuck?"

Damiano snatches my robe from where it's laying over the back of my chair and wraps it around me, covering my body against my future husband's gaze. He points at the door. "Get the fuck out."

"Are you two kissing?" Andreas speaks loud enough for his words to echo through the whole house. "You're brother and sister. That's *disgusting*."

Damiano lifts me up and places me on the mattress, and then he strides toward Andreas. "I said, get the fuck out of Lucy's room."

There's the sound of rapid high-heeled steps in the corridor, and my heart seizes in panic. We're so screwed.

"What is going on in here?" Mom says as she enters my bedroom. "Damiano, stop shouting at our guest. Andreas came to tell Lucy the good news about her wedding date."

Her eyes land on me, huddled in my robe on the bed, and then on the lingerie bag discarded on the floor, and finally at Damiano's kiss-swollen mouth. She turns a furious shade of red. After a murderous glance at me, she turns to Andreas with a smile. "I'm sure there's an innocent explanation for what you thought you saw. Damiano and Lucy can be...overly affectionate sometimes. We're a very affectionate family."

I nearly snort at that.

Andreas turns to me, revulsion filling his amber eyes. "Is that true? You and your brother were being *affectionate*?"

I don't know what to say. It's plain that nothing I can say will make any difference. Damiano's whole body is tense like he wants to attack Andreas for coming into my room.

"You're all fucking crazy." Andreas shakes his head in disgust as he heads out of my room.

Is the wedding off? I think the wedding is off. Mom gives me a look that turns my blood to ice, and then she hurries to catch up with Andreas. “Andreas, wait! This is all just a misunderstanding. Andreas, please.”

Damiano scrubs a hand over his face. “Fuck. Are you okay, my love?”

I’m so not okay. Mom’s going to kill me, and it’s not a figure of speech. I start to cry, and Damiano holds me for several minutes.

“Just go,” I manage in a whisper. “Mom will be angrier than ever if you’re still here when she comes back.”

“Don’t worry. I’ll fix this. I’ll follow Andreas right now. I’ll find him.” He presses a kiss to the top of my head, and leaves the room, closing the door behind him.

My eyes follow him, fearing that this will be the last time I’ll ever see him.

It will be the last time I ever lay eyes on him. I have to stand up, pull some sneakers on, shove a few things into an overnight bag, and run for it. Mom isn’t going to convince Andreas that he didn’t just see what he saw, which means I’m a dead woman. I have to walk away from the only man who means home, and my heart is shattering. If I don’t, I’ll be given to Dad’s men to be raped and beaten, begging for mercy until they finally slit my throat. What they will do to me will destroy Damiano, and I can’t let that happen to him.

My eyes drift to my closet. Running will only delay the inevitable. There’s a surer, swifter way out of this.

Feeling numb, I pull myself slowly to my feet. My gun is hidden in the bottom of the shoe rack in my wardrobe, inside a shoebox. Better to die swiftly by my own hand, to spare Damiano from all that suffering. It will hurt him when he finds out what I’ve done, and he won’t ever forgive me, but I am sparing us both from an even worse fate. Maybe he’ll take some comfort from knowing that I went out on my own terms, and I’ll live on in his heart forever. It’s the only place I want to be.

If Damiano can’t have me, no one can.

My hand is on the wardrobe door when I hear determined, masculine footsteps sounding along the corridor and getting louder. My bedroom door bursts open, and I turn toward it with a sigh. Why does Damiano have to make this so much harder than it is? We’ll both end up dead at this rate.

“Damiano, I told you...”

But it's not Damiano who's come into my room. Andreas slams the door behind him, and turns to me with an angry, petulant expression. "What were you doing with your brother?"

I draw the robe tighter around me. "Get out."

He crosses the room toward me, and I sense violence radiating from him. Gone is the deferential, overeager man who's been desperate to impress my father and his cousin. Damiano has just humiliated him, and he's furious. "Everyone in Malus says that Damiano fucks his sister. It's true, isn't it? You do fuck him."

He crowds me, and I step back, and with the wardrobe suddenly pressing against my spine, I have nowhere to run.

"Damiano," I shout at the top of my lungs, but there's no reply.

Apprehension skitters through me as I realize how silent the house is. Where's Damiano? Right now, I'll even settle for Mom. My gun is stacked under several shoeboxes, and Andreas won't stand there patiently while I dig it out.

"Go and tell Mom and Dad the wedding is off," I say in a shaky voice. "I don't care. Just get out of my room."

Andreas's eyes narrow. "You're too important. I can't call off the wedding."

By important, he doesn't mean that he cares about me. I'm a useful tool for his ambitions.

"You crave your brother's dick and that's sick and twisted, but I can work with that. You just need to be corrected, and that's a husband's duty."

My mouth drops open. "I need to be *what*?"

Andreas's eyes light up in a disturbing way. Before I can react, he seizes my shoulder, throws me face down on the bed, and strips off my robe in one violent tug. My cry of surprise and pain is muffled by the blanket. I lift my head to scream for help, but before I can, Andreas plants a hand on the back of my head and forces my face into the mattress. He clambers on top of me, pinning me down. He's not very athletic, but he is heavy, and that's all it takes to keep me trapped beneath him.

I can't process what's happening to me. It doesn't feel real. I don't even feel scared, just shocked, until I feel Andreas trying to unfasten my lingerie. "Sick and twisted. That's what you are. A nasty little slut who needs to be taught a lesson."

As I struggle ineffectually, I try to scream or make any noise at all, but the only thing that comes out is a muffled buzzing noise.

Over my struggling, I hear the sound of a car engine outside. I instantly recognize Damiano's car. The engine races and then grows quieter as he drives out the gates. I sob in despair. He can't have known that Andreas was still in the house. I picture the red taillights disappearing, and a desperate, smothered cry rises up my throat.

Damiano, please.

Don't leave me.

But he's not coming to save me. Andreas's fingers are ripping viciously at the fastenings on my lingerie, and any second now, they're all going to come free. He's manhandling me like this in my own house, in my own bed. I feel my corset come off first, and then he yanks at my suspender belt. I need to stop panicking and *think*. What did my kickboxing trainer teach me in the several self-defense classes he gave me? If I'm pinned face down, I can't kick or scratch or bite. I can't thrust my fingers up my attacker's nose, or gouge his eyes, or knee him in the balls. But I can roll to one side beneath him and try to tip him off me.

Using my right elbow and knee as leverage, I fling myself to the left as hard as I can. Nothing happens. I try again, but still I barely move him. Andreas swears and shifts his weight so he can get a better grip on me. At the same time, I screw up my eyes and twist to the left a third time, and Andreas is momentarily off-balance.

I feel his weight shift off me for a fraction of a second, and it's all the chance I need. I fling myself off the mattress and stumble across the room, tears blurring my vision. I wrench open the door and run down the corridor, screaming at the top of my lungs.

"Help me. *Someone help me.*"

Mom and Dad's bedroom door opens, and Mom appears, staring at me in shock. My hair is sticking to my tearstained face, and I'm crying so hard I can barely get any words out. I'm so grateful that there's someone in the house that I fling myself into her arms. "H-he was trying to hurt me. He's in m-my room. He was going to force himself on me."

"Lucy, what on earth?" She puts her hand on my shoulder and pushes me away from her so she can get a better look at me. I'm wearing only the thong and the suspender belt. The little clips have all been ripped off the stockings, which are now laddered, and one is falling down to my knee.

She looks past me, and I realize that Andreas is coming down the hallway toward us, his clothes rumpled and his face red with anger. With her hand on my shoulder, she asks him, “Did you do this to my daughter?”

Andreas glares at me as I try to stop crying. Every breath is painful. I wish Damiano would come back. I need Damiano.

When she doesn’t get any reply, Mom raises her voice and calls. “Carlucci, come up here, please.”

But Dad is already at the top of the stairs. When he sees that I’m nearly naked, he frowns in disapproval. Ashamed, even though none of this is my fault, I cover my breasts with my arms and wish that I could sink through the floor and disappear.

“What is going on up here?” he asks, his voice ringing with authority.

Speaking quickly as though he’s anxious to deflect blame, Andreas accuses, “Lucy was wearing her bridal lingerie for her brother. They were practically screwing. You’re trying to marry off a defective woman. You promised me a virgin.”

Promised him a virgin? They’ve all been talking about me like I’m livestock.

Dad’s severe expression doesn’t change as he glances at me and then Mom. “I’m ashamed to admit my youngest daughter can sometimes be disobedient and provocative. But that is all it is. Provocation. Marriage to a strong and steady man like you is all she needs to settle down.”

Andreas stands up straighter hearing Dad take his side.

“Dad, he tried to rape me,” I cry.

“Lucy, be quiet,” he snaps. Mom’s nails dig into my shoulder, reminding me what will happen if Andreas rejects me.

“Maybe I was too forceful,” Andreas says, with a guilty glance at me. “But a husband has to be able to correct his wife.”

“You are absolutely right, Andreas,” Mom agrees.

“Mom, please,” I whimper.

“Lucy, you are being dramatic and emotional. You were mistaken about your fiancé’s intentions, just as he was mistaken when he saw you and Damiano talking in your bedroom.” Mom glances at Andreas. “Weren’t you, Andreas? Isn’t this all just a misunderstanding?”

I look to Dad for help, but his expression is closed, and he won’t meet my eyes. Of course they don’t care if Andreas tried to rape me. Dad’s men will be eager to do the same thing if they’re given the order.

“Maybe you’re right,” Andreas says finally.

Mom smiles placatingly. “We all need a little time to cool off. Tomorrow Lucy will apologize to Andreas for all this upset, and we will continue with planning your wedding.”

“If she’s sincere in her apology,” Andreas says.

“She will be. Won’t you, Lucy?” Mom prompts.

My near nakedness is making me shiver from cold and humiliation. Apologize for nearly being raped? They want me to put on a sweet smile for Andreas and beg him to forgive me for not letting him painfully and violently force himself on me.

From the vile, gloating expression on Andreas’s face, my parents taking his side has thrilled him. After we’re married, he’ll force me to perform my wifely duty, and no doubt he’ll make it as horrible for me as he possibly can. If I complain to Mom and Dad about it, my cries will fall on deaf ears. The gun hidden in my wardrobe is seeming more enticing than ever.

But why should I and Damiano be the only ones to suffer?

A new idea is forming in my mind. A better one than a swift bullet of self-obliteration, or even of retaliation. I can have revenge.

Beautiful, devastating revenge.

At the wedding, in front of everyone—Montonis, Barones, all of Malus—I’ll expose him. I’ll show everyone what he really is. A traitor. A spy. A violent predator who tried to rape me in my own home.

But first I have to convince everyone they’ve broken me.

I turn my face upward to Andreas and beseech him like a broken Lucy would. The Lucy who huddled in misery in the dirt because she was abandoned like a stray dog at ten years old.

“Of course I will apologize. I will be the bride you’ve always wanted, Andreas. I promise.”

He smiles, victorious. He thinks he’s won. He thinks he’s broken me.

He has no idea what’s coming.

At our wedding, I’m going to destroy him in front of everyone.

Damiano

The wedding is still on.

I pick up my wineglass and down the contents in three swallows. Every drop tastes bitter and burns down my throat like acid. I was anticipating Andreas and Cristiano to jump me, attempt to beat my ass, and demand to know what the hell I was doing with my “sister.” There was no way the marriage would continue after the groom had seen his bride with another man. I would have welcomed the chance to fight Andreas, maybe even “accidentally” kill him.

It’s been nearly three weeks since Andreas caught Lucy and I together, and everyone’s pretending like nothing happened. When I came home that night after searching fruitlessly for Andreas, Lucy was different. Distant. Compliant. She wouldn’t tell me what happened while I was gone, just that the wedding was still on.

I know something happened. I can see it in her eyes. But she won’t talk about it.

In front of Mom and Dad, she’s been talking about the guest list, the honeymoon, and her future with Andreas. They managed to secure the ballroom at one of Malus’s big hotels for the reception, and the church has been booked for the ceremony.

I overheard Lucy and Mom shortlisting baby names, and I wanted to put my fist through the wall.

Andreas sits across from me at the table, flushed red from too much alcohol and talking and laughing loudly with the men around him. Next to him, Lucy is smiling, sipping her wine, speaking every now and then when Mom or an aunt or another woman talks to her. She's a perfect, demure mafia bride-to-be, wearing a butter yellow cocktail dress with her long, loose curls neatly pinned back with sparkling clips. Laid out on the table are the remains of the wedding rehearsal dinner.

They're getting married tomorrow.

Lucy looks radiantly happy about it.

I'm going out of my fucking mind.

But there's something off about Lucy's performance. She's too perfect, too composed. She smiles at all the right moments, says all the right things. But her eyes... There's something hard and calculating in them. Like she's watching everything from a distance. Planning something.

But what? What could she possibly be planning?

The music changes to something vibrant and classic, and the Montonis and their wives and friends call out that Andreas and his bride should dance. Andreas waves them off, protesting good-naturedly, as their calls grow louder and more insistent. Lucy laughs as Mom's sisters push her toward her groom, and finally the pair get to their feet, hand in hand, as applause breaks out around the room. Andreas pulls his bride close with an arm wrapped around her waist and his hand holding hers, and they start to dance. Everyone in the room fawns over them, and a few minutes later, several more couples join them on the improvised dance floor. Lucy smiles up at her husband-to-be as he says something to her. They look like the picture of soon-to-be wedded bliss.

I can't tear my gaze from them as thick, angry jealousy pounds through my blood. There must be a murderous expression on my face, because I hear someone ask, "Damiano, are you all right?"

The world has gone insane. My woman is marrying someone else, and she's happy about it. I'm so goddamn far from all right.

Lucy must feel my eyes upon her because, a moment later, she turns and watches me over Andreas's shoulder. Only her eyes are visible, and the hand that's caressing the nape of his neck. There's an unreadable expression in her eyes, hard and glittering.

I wonder if she hates me because I couldn't save her from this.

I wouldn't blame her. I hate myself.

The party starts to break up. People say their goodbyes and leave the restaurant. Andreas kisses his bride good night on the cheek. The next time they see each other will be at the altar.

I can't stand it any longer. I go out and stand in the moonlight, my hands shoved angrily into my pockets.

Lucy joins me a few minutes later. Standing before me, she reaches up and strokes her fingertips through the short hair by my temple. She says nothing, but her eyes are filled with that same hard glitter.

"Why are you looking at me like that?" I ask.

"Like what? I'm admiring my handsome brother."

My insides twist and burn up, and I look sharply away. "I'm not as handsome as your groom, apparently. Are you angry with me, Lucy? Do I deserve you tormenting me like this?"

"How am I tormenting you?"

"By being happy while I am sunk in the blackest misery, with nothing but torture to look forward to in my future."

"You think I'm happy?" Lucy puts her hand on my wrist and steps closer, the hard glitter vanishing from her eyes as she whispers, "I'm in hell, but I would suffer any torment to remain close to you, Damiano."

"You do not love him?" I ask urgently.

"I could never love him."

"He doesn't make you feel the way I make you feel?"

"He does not," she insists.

"Good." I close my eyes, pull her into my arms, and press my brow against hers. Breathing deeply, I inhale her sweet scent. Out here in the moonlight, I can pretend she's all mine. "Or I'd have to kill him right now."

Lucy's fingers graze over the gun holstered under my arm. "I love that you're always armed, Damiano."

"All the better to protect you with, my love." My lips find her ear, and I whisper, "Ask me to kill him for you. I'll do it now, as he heads for his car in the dark. You want him dead, don't you?"

Lucy shakes her head. "Murder him unprovoked and in cold blood in the parking lot? Don Cristiano would kill you in an instant."

And Dad would kill Lucy, but right now, I'm desperate enough for us to take our chances and go on the run.

"Ask me to kill him for you," I insist. "Prove to me that you want me, not him."

Lucy pretends not to hear me. “Will you take me home with you, one last time?”

My insides feel like they’re being submerged in acid. One last time. The only person in the world I love is being taken away from me, and I don’t know how to stop it other than by murder, and, apparently, that’s not what Lucy wants.

She pulls herself out of my arms, slides into my car, and holds my hand tightly in both of hers all the way home.

Lucy goes to her bed, and I go to mine, but it takes a long time for me to fall asleep.

As soon as I do, I dive headlong into nightmares.

Lucy, laughing and carefree, running unknowingly into a burning church.

Lucy in her wedding dress, dousing herself in gasoline, and striking a match.

Lucy and Andreas in bed together, writhing in pleasure among burning flames. I call out to her again and again, but she doesn’t hear me.

I feel hands on me, dragging me out of the hell I’ve fallen into.

“Damiano, wake up.”

My eyes snap open, and I gasp for frantic breaths. Smoke is burning my throat and lungs, and flames are dancing in my vision, but when my eyes clear, I see her.

“Lucy.” I clasp her in my arms, rocking her back and forth in my lap as though she’s the one who needs comforting and not me.

“You’re all right. It’s just a dream,” she assures me.

“It’s not just a dream,” I remind her fiercely. “This is a living nightmare because you’re being taken away from me. I can’t lose you, Lucy. I’ll go mad if I lose you. Don’t marry him. Please don’t marry him.”

I’ll crawl over hot coals if she’ll let me kill her fucking fiancé.

Lucy takes my face in her hands, and there’s so much pain and longing in her expression that I can’t take it anymore.

I kiss her.

Lucy inhales sharply, and then she’s kissing me back. Our mouths and tongues move with feverish desire, and we clasp each other urgently, afraid to let go even for a second. Lucy hurts as much as I’m hurting, and she wants me as much as I want her, but she’s still going to marry Andreas.

“Lucy, I am begging you—”

She puts a finger over my lips. “Shh, Damiano. We have such a terrible record of being caught when we do these kinds of things, and this is our last chance.”

“Our last chance for what?”

Instead of answering, Lucy pulls her T-shirt that she’s been sleeping in—my T-shirt, I notice—up over her head and tosses it aside. She picks up my hands and cups her breasts with them, and they’re warm and heavy in my palms. “Please, Damiano,” she breathes. “Make me feel loved for the first and last time in my life.”

She’s nestled naked in my lap, her beautiful body pressed against mine. I squeeze her breasts and rub my thumbs over her nipples. “The first and last time? Lucy, it kills me to hear you talk like that.”

“Are you going to waste this moment, or are you going to give me the wedding night I need?”

I kiss her hard, desire flashing through me. “You have barely spoken to me these past weeks. I thought you’d decided to save your virginity for your husband.”

“I would never give myself to a man so undeserving. I have saved myself for you, and only you, Damiano.”

“But you will give yourself to him tomorrow?” I ask through gritted teeth.

Lucy presses soft kisses to my cheeks, my eyelids, my lips. “Tomorrow is tomorrow. Tomorrow doesn’t matter. I want you now, Damiano. Don’t you want me?”

Tomorrow doesn’t matter. What does that mean? But I’m too caught up in her to think clearly.

Do I want her?

With the power of a thousand suns.

Her mouth is parted and eager, and I capture her lips with mine. We kiss like we need each other more than oxygen. I do need her more than oxygen. I don’t know how I’m going to live without her.

“I’ve prepared my wedding vows,” she says breathlessly between kisses. “Do you want to hear them?”

“Don’t speak to me of your wedding vows,” I growl.

“You don’t wish to know the words I will speak at the altar tomorrow?”

I seize her nipple in my mouth, and I suck. “I won’t be listening. I will block it all out.”

“I took a long time over these vows, Damiano. They’re meant to be listened to.”

There’s something strange in the way she says it. Like she wants me to understand something.

I look up at her with a glare. I wish I could forbid her from even thinking about him. How dare she linger over the vows she’ll speak to Andreas? I’m even jealous of the time she devotes to him in her head. “You thought for more than a second what you wanted to vow to that idiot?”

“It’s my wedding day, Damiano. Everything has to be perfect, from my vows to my dress.”

I pick her up in my arms, drop her onto her back, and spread her legs. “Your dress,” I mutter with a curl of my lip.

“You’ve seen my dress?”

“Of course I’ve seen your dress. As soon as it was delivered and you were out, I went into your room.”

“What do you think?”

“It’s all wrong. Mom chose it, not you. I can tell.” I kiss slowly down her body. “When I imagine you marrying me, you’re wearing a very different dress, and you’re radiantly beautiful.”

She half sits up and buries her fingers in my hair. “You have imagined marrying me?”

I meet her eyes. “Every day. But tomorrow you’ll wear that horrible dress and marry him, and I don’t understand why you’re letting this happen. Lucy, what aren’t you telling me?”

But she just leans forward to kiss me, silencing my questions.

Breaking the kiss, I move down her body, and my mouth descends on her clit. Lucy covers her mouth, before she can cry out, and falls back on the mattress. I taste her thoroughly, my tongue licking her everywhere. She jumps and gives a muffled cry every time I circle her clit with my tongue. I hook her legs over my shoulders, and I push her thighs wider. Needing more of her. Needing all of her. Every gasp of her pleasure is the most beautiful music I’ve ever heard. My cock is iron hard, and I’m aching to sink into her, but I won’t let up until she gives me what I want.

“Come for me, Lucy,” I whisper between licks. “Show me how much you want me.”

“Damiano, oh God. I’m going to come. Don’t stop. *Don’t stop.*” Her nails dig urgently into my flesh.

Wild horses and rabid dogs couldn't drag me away from her. I lovingly caress her with my tongue until her body shatters beneath me, and her legs lock around my shoulders. She tenses up, and then when her orgasm finally releases her, she goes limp.

I sit up with a pleasurable groan, moving between her thighs. I don't have a condom, and I don't want one either. Lucy's my woman, and I won't have anything between us. I take my cock in my hand.

"Are you scared, my love?"

"With you? Never."

"Of course you're not, my beautiful girl." I glance at the door, and then back at her. "If someone comes in here before I'm finished with you, I'll kill them, and that's a promise."

She smiles and smothers a giggle with her hand. She's just so cute, my adorable Lucy, with her riot of golden curls and her pretty brown eyes. I sink into her, swift and deep. Her breath catches, and she covers her face with her hands. Suddenly afraid I've hurt her, I freeze, but she wraps her thighs around me so I can't pull out.

"Don't you dare not fuck me."

She's so tight around me. I kiss her again and slowly push deeper.

"Oh, God, Damiano." Lucy breathes in sharply and locks her arms around my neck. "Oh, fuck. *Oh, fuck.*"

"That's my line," I say through gritted teeth, nearly overwhelmed by pleasure.

"You feel huge," she whimpers, but she keeps holding me close.

"Just breathe, my love."

Lucy takes a steadying breath and looks into my eyes. I finally have her. I can barely believe it. I reach down between us to caress her clit, and slowly, her body melts for me. I pull back a little and give a tentative thrust. Then I move more firmly, and again, and then finally sharply and deeply.

My hand covers her mouth to muffle her cry. I'm balls deep in her, and we look so good that all I can do for a moment is stare.

I see the engagement ring on her finger—his ring—and I want to rip it off. But she stops my hand.

"Leave it," she whispers. "Tomorrow it won't matter anymore."

What does that mean? Tomorrow it won't matter? But I'm too lost in her to ask.

I sit up, ease out of her, and palm my cock in the dark. Her smear of virgin blood is transferred to my palm. I grasp her throat and squeeze as I thrust into her again, leaving a bloody smear around her throat.

“Mine,” I growl, and kiss her hard, possessively, and fuck her harder. “Mine, now and forever. Tonight and always.”

She reaches down between us and works her clit with her fingers. Her other hand squeezes my shoulder, holding on tightly. “Damiano,” she gasps.

I pump my hips and move in and out of her at a demanding, hungry pace. “I love you so much, Lucy.” She can’t do anything to stop me saying it now. Her pussy gripping my cock feels like heaven. “So perfect. You were made for me.”

I watch her fingers skimming her clit until she climaxes again. I want this to last forever, but I can’t hold myself back. With her hand pressed against my chest, I thrust hard and deep until I burst inside of her.

As soon as I pull out, I move down her body like a starving man and get my mouth on her sex. She’s swollen and slick, slippery with my cum, and faintly metallic with blood. I’ll never get enough of her.

Lucy gasps in surprise. “Damiano, you can’t. Your cum. My blood. Isn’t that...weird?”

“Silly girl,” I say, and keep licking her. “You taste even better now. You taste of both of us.”

I push my middle and ring finger up inside of her and rub the spot behind her clit firmly. As I move my hand back and forth, her wetness and my cum coats my fingers, and I lick her with abandon. She’s so delightfully messy, and she gives herself over to me completely. No thinking. No worrying. Only feeling and letting me have her. When she comes, I make sure she keeps riding my tongue and my fingers until I’ve wrung every last drop of pleasure out of her.

With Lucy clasped against my chest, she grows drowsy until she falls asleep. I hold her, not the least bit tired. For a short time, I lost myself in pleasure, and I was able to forget that she’s marrying someone else tomorrow.

As the realization tumbles back, black shadows seize my heart.

How has every decision and action I’ve taken in my life, all of which have been to protect Lucy, brought us to this hellish end?

As I hold her while she sleeps, pieces float through my mind.

Her strange compliance. The hard calculation in her eyes. Her insistence I listen to her wedding vows. *Tomorrow doesn't matter*. The way she said Andreas couldn't be killed unprovoked, as if she was waiting for provocation.

For a moment, I wonder if Lucy is planning something.

But no. That's impossible. If Lucy had a plan, she would have told me.

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Lucy

I wake before dawn and Damiano is asleep beside me on his stomach, his cheek pressed into the pillow and his curls falling over his brow. My heart flutters. What a beautiful sight first thing in the morning. How can I wake up next to any man but him for the rest of my life?

I stretch my arms over my head, and there's a delicious ache deep in my core. It was the most perfect wedding night spent with the man I love. Too bad the man beside me is not my intended husband.

Damiano feels me moving around beside him, and without opening his eyes he reaches out and drags me to him. His warm, muscular body wraps around mine, and he rolls on top of me and seeks my mouth. My body lights up with pleasure, and I arch against him.

"I have to go," I whisper between kisses. Damiano's erection is working itself insistently between my naked thighs.

"I don't want you to."

"I'm getting married today, remember?"

"Fuck getting married."

I pull back and give him an exasperated look. "You know I have to. It's this or never seeing you again."

Damiano opens his eyes, and there's jealousy raging within them. He plants his hands on either side of my head. "Are you going to turn me into

the other man? Will you give me crumbs of your affection while that idiot owns your body and your life?"

"I wouldn't call giving you my virginity crumbs of my affection."

His breathing is rapid and angry. "I won't stand silently by in that church while you marry Andreas. If I hear him say his vows, and you saying yours, I'll lose my mind."

I stroke my fingers through his curls, trying desperately to calm his fury. "Please, Damiano. Don't abandon me on my wedding day."

He closes his eyes and mutters a string of curse words. When he opens them again, he says through clenched teeth, "I won't, I promise. Even if it kills me, or if I kill everyone in that church."

I take a relieved breath. "Thank you, Damiano. Now let me go, because I have to shower, put on my bridal lingerie, and be ready in thirty minutes for the hair and makeup artists that Mom booked." I bought all new lingerie after Andreas wrecked the last set. I couldn't stand to look at what remained of them.

Devastation fills Damiano's eyes, like he's anticipating watching me go to the gallows rather than to the altar.

"Trust me, all right? I know what I'm doing." I press a final kiss to his mouth and pull myself out of his arms.

As I walk out of Damiano's room with tangled hair and wearing one of his T-shirts, Ariana sees me through her open bedroom door. Damiano is sitting up bare-chested in bed. Ariana's eyes flicker with disgust as she realizes we were in bed together, but without a word she goes back to hunting through her jewelry box.

I enter my bedroom and catch sight of my bed. My stomach clenches in panic, and my pulse races, as it has every time I'm reminded of Andreas's body trapping mine, or of his vile, greedy hands ripping at my lingerie. Today is my wedding day, and the thought that being subservient to him could be my fate for the rest of my life makes cold sweat break out on my lower back.

With the help of the experts Mom hired, within two hours, I'm transformed into a bride. The bridal gown I dislike so much weighs heavily on my body. The pins in my hair are too tight and dig into my scalp. There's a full-length mirror in my room, but I turn away from it without a glance. I already know today is all wrong, starting with the dress, and ending with the groom.

My duty to the Barones is a heavy stone around my neck, dragging me down into heartbreak.

While I wait downstairs for the cars to arrive, I recite my vows under my breath. I wrote them myself, and I'm proud of them. They're the only thing about this ceremony that's me. Repeating them over and over is all that's keeping me grounded and able to go through with it.

I hear footsteps behind me. Warm hands clasp my waist and turn me around. It's Damiano dressed in a suit, his jaw clean-shaven and smelling like cold, crisp aftershave. My heart thumps with longing. His mouth was on mine last night. His body moved against mine, in and out of me, hard and deep. His hand was wrapped lovingly and possessively around my throat. I cried in the shower as I washed the smears of blood from my neck. I didn't want to lose this little piece of us.

"You look beautiful," Damiano breathes, and presses a kiss to my cheek.

I smile weakly. "No, I don't. This dress is awful."

"You are always beautiful."

As he embraces me, I feel the gun holstered under his arm. Damiano is prepared for violence, even on my wedding day.

Ariana joins us without a word, wearing a simple pink bridesmaid dress, chosen by Mom, of course. As the wedding cars, festooned with white satin ribbons, pull up the driveway, Mom and Dad come downstairs. Dad wears a dark suit. Mom is in a pencil dress with an embroidered jacket, and she's wearing a large, decorated hat.

She examines each of us critically, hunting for faults. The Barones are going to be on display before all of the important people of Malus today. We can only be perfect. Anything less than that is unacceptable.

After twitching folds of my skirt, straightening Damiano's tie, and adjusting the strap of Ariana's dress, she says, "Very well," and walks out of the front door to the waiting cars.

Dad follows her out of the house without a word to me.

"We're so proud of you, Lucy," Damiano mutters, glaring after them. "How beautiful our daughter looks on her wedding day."

It's sweet of Damiano to care how they treat me, but even if they did say those words, they wouldn't mean them.

My bouquet is laying on the hall table, and I collect it. The flowers are uninteresting and pale, and not what I would have chosen.

I'm supposed to ride to the church in the second car with Dad, but Damiano insists on being the one with me instead. It causes an argument because it's "not how things are done," but eventually Mom gives up, and she, Dad, and Ariana get into the car in front of ours.

As we drive along, Damiano helps me arrange my voluminous skirts, and while I'm distracted, he steals a kiss.

My eyes close as warmth and love spread through me. I want to linger in this kiss, but I quickly pull away. We're driving through the busy streets of Malus, and people love to peer inside wedding cars for a glimpse of the bride. "Damiano, someone might see."

"Let them see. You won't deny me this while you still belong to me." He takes my face in his hands and kisses me again.

I don't have the strength to push him away. His lips move over mine with heartbreaking tenderness. As we break apart a few minutes later, gasping slightly, I catch the driver's eyes in the rearview mirror, but he quickly looks away.

The church where I'm going to marry Andreas is the same one we frequent for Christmas and Easter services. The outside is gray and forbidding, and inside it's cavernous and always freezing.

We all meet outside the church, and I listen to the voices and music from within. Damiano's expression is hard and his whole body is taut. Mom and Dad stand several feet from us, as silent and cold as strangers. Ariana is lost in her own miserable world, no doubt anticipating her own fate on these steps in a few months. I insisted upon this charade. The full wedding experience befitting a beloved Barone daughter obediently marrying a Montoni man, before Mom and Dad wash their hands of me forever. They can't wait to be rid of me.

"Come along, Damiano," Mom says crisply. She has a seat in the front row, and Damiano will join my fiancé at the altar. Dad moves to my side because he will be walking me down the aisle, but he still doesn't look at me as he offers me his arm. Ariana will follow behind.

Damiano grips my waist and says tightly, "I don't want to leave your side. Let me be the one who walks you down the aisle."

"Damiano, go inside that church." Dad's eyes are glinting with so much anger that I wonder if he noticed us kissing in the wedding car.

I cup Damiano's cheek and gaze up into his handsome face, my heart aching with longing for him. "Please, Damiano. You have to go inside so

you will be there when I arrive at the altar. I won't be able to do this without you, and I must do this." I lower my voice and whisper, "For us."

Damiano doesn't understand what I mean, but he will soon enough.

He presses one last kiss to my lips, not caring that Dad is standing right there, and looks deep into the eyes. "You will always be mine."

My fingers slip through his, and my throat feels tight as I watch him walk away from me.

Dad has to tug sharply on my arm when it's time to walk down the aisle. I put one white satin heel in front of the other, and a shiver goes down my spine as the massive church opens up before me and the music sweeps over me. There are roses at the end of every pew, and they're filled with people who have come here to witness this spectacle between the Barones and the Montonis. They will fill all of Malus with gossip about this wedding for days, weeks to come. What happens here today will strengthen our two powerful families or shatter them.

In the crowd, I glimpse Adora standing beside her tall, dangerous husband, and her amber eyes are filled with concern for me. She's the only person beside Damiano who's truly here for me.

I'm vaguely aware of Andreas standing at the end of the long aisle next to the priest. I seek out Damiano, my pillar of strength. Our eyes lock as I approach the altar, my heavy gown dragging on me, and my fingers white-knuckling my bouquet. I'm so focused on Damiano that it's a shock when Ariana takes my flowers and Dad propels me toward Andreas before stepping away.

Andreas gazes down at me with awkward haughtiness. This is probably the most important he's ever felt in his life. Over his shoulder, Damiano is looking at me with pain and darkness swirling in his eyes.

Ever since Andreas tried to force himself on me and my parents didn't care, Andreas has been strutting about like he's finally a "real" man. In private, he's a little wary of me, waiting for me to bring up what he did. I've been smiling at him and simpering like I'm excited to be his wife, and he's almost convinced himself that it's true.

He has no idea I've been investigating him. That I've documented every suspicious question, every secret meeting. That I have photos that are proof of his betrayal.

Do I take this man?

I do *not*.

I don't want him.

I want Damiano.

Yet I turn obediently to the priest and listen as he begins the service. I wince as Andreas takes my hands in his and speaks his vows, promising to love and honor me. He doesn't know the first thing about loving me, and there's not one drop of honor in his body.

The priest announces that I've written my own vows, and I feel Mom's gaze boring into my neck. She didn't approve this. I made the priest promise not to tell her, making it sound like a lovely surprise for my family and groom. I know they're going to be surprised.

I take a steeling breath before I begin. It's important that I speak these words loudly and clearly for the whole congregation to hear.

"I, Lucy Barone, vow to obey you, Andreas Montoni. I will obey you when I'm frightened. I will obey you when I'm sobbing." I pause as a slightly confused ripple passes through the church. It dissipates quickly. I lick my lips and continue. "I vow to give you my body without protest or tears, even though I would rather die than feel your hands on me again, because your vile touch makes my skin crawl."

The ripple breaks over the congregation again, stronger now. I can feel the people shifting behind me. The confused glances they're sharing. The pretty smile on my face and the adoring way I'm gazing at my groom doesn't match what I'm saying.

"I will obey you when I'm panicking. I will obey you when I'm begging you to stop."

The priest is staring at me in horror.

My groom's interest has wandered, and it takes Andreas some time to realize I'm not speaking words of love and obedience. When he does, his eyes suddenly widen. He leans close to me, and whispers harshly, "Lucy. What the hell are you doing?"

"I'm reciting my wedding vows, Andreas," I say, and my voice rings through the stunned silence of the church. "I thought you would want truthful vows, and so I am giving them to you. What was it you said to me? I'm a nasty slut who needs to be taught a lesson. I need to be corrected, and that's a husband's duty. And so I vow to submit without protest to whatever you decide to do with my body, no matter how much it hurts. No matter how scared I am, or how many times I beg you to stop."

Mafia brides are lambs to the slaughter, but I'm not going to silently bare my throat to the knife.

By the time I'm finished speaking, my voice is trembling with anger. I feel a vindictive flash of pleasure knowing everyone who matters in Malus has heard what I've said. I've kept my hatred from Andreas bottled up tight, but now I've yanked out the cork, and every drop of loathing I feel for him is ringing in my voice and blazing from my face.

Andreas glances nervously around at the dozens upon dozens of shocked expressions on the faces of the congregation. Behind closed doors, daughters and wives are expected to swallow their tears and pretend that everything's rosy, but a rapist is still a rapist in the cold light of day. Condemnation for what Andreas has done resounds through the church.

A large, dark figure appears over my groom's shoulder. Damiano looms over Andreas like a demon summoned from hell. In a voice brittle with violence, he seethes, "You raped my sister?"

Andreas turns from Damiano to me, frozen in panic. "No! I didn't. I swear, I..." He looks to the priest for help, but the man of cloth has taken a healthy step back.

Damiano reaches inside his jacket and pulls out his gun. The dark metal glints in the red and golden light beaming through the stained glass windows. He only holds it, he doesn't point it, but all the blood drains from Andreas's face. For the first time since he pinned me face down on my bed and half suffocated me, I feel a weight lift from my chest. The air smells sweeter. The world is brighter. How beautiful that Andreas finally feels a fraction of how terrified he made me.

"You hurt Lucy? You said those disgusting things to her?" Damiano glares at where Andreas is still gripping my hands. "Get your fucking hands off her."

Andreas yanks his fingers from mine. "I—I don't know what she's talking about. Nothing happened. Ask your mom. She was there." Andreas points desperately into the front row.

Damiano whirls around and glares at Mom. Her back is ramrod straight as she keeps her polite society smile fixed to her lips, but her eyes are wide and showing signs of panic. She leans forward, and hisses at Damiano, "Stop this right now. Put away your gun. You're making a scene at your sister's wedding, and your father and I will not stand for this."

Damiano seizes Andreas by his suit collar, and tosses him down the aisle, where he lands in a heap on the ground. In one long stride, Damiano reaches me, holsters his gun, and sweeps me into his arms. He takes my face in his hands and presses his brow to mine, pain etched on his face. "I'm so sorry, Lucy. I didn't know. What did he do to you, my love?"

Emotion swells in my chest, and I lean my cheek into his hand, seeking his warmth. "I wanted to tell you. He saw us together, and he tried to 'correct' my attraction to you, but nothing could change how I feel about you, Damiano."

In front of the whole church, Damiano, the man the whole world believes is my brother, is caressing me like a lover. The shock and condemnation in the room takes on a whole new flavor, but I don't care. This is what I wanted, all our secrets out in the open so Mom and Dad can't quietly force us into miserable marriages.

I wrap my arms around Damiano's neck and turn my lips up to his. We're dappled in colored sunlight coming through the stained glass. The man I love is holding me in his arms.

"Lucy..." Damiano whispers, his eyes growing hazy with desire.

His lips descend toward mine, but he's prevented from kissing me when a hateful voice cuts through our perfect moment.

"Lucy's lying. I didn't do a thing to her. You two are fucked in the head. You're brother and sister, and you're screwing. Look, everyone. You can all see it!" Andreas has pulled himself to his feet and dusted himself off, and he's fuming in anger.

I pull away from Damiano and turn to face Andreas.

"I'm not lying," I say clearly. "And I can prove it. For the past few weeks, while you thought I was being the perfect meek bride, I was actually investigating you, Andreas." My voice carries through the church. "After you bought me this hideous engagement ring, I saw you get into a car with a strange man. A man with a Sokoli tattoo on his hand."

Gasps echo through the church. The name Sokoli sends a ripple of shock and rage through the congregation. Everyone here hates the vicious rival family who attacked the Malus dons and our tentative allies.

"You showed him something on your phone," I continue. "Documents? Maps? Were you showing him our warehouse locations, Andreas?"

Andreas's face has turned from red to white. "That's not... You're making this up."

“Am I making up all the questions you asked Gerardo, my bodyguard, while I was buying my wedding lingerie? Our shipments. Our security. Our business operations. All things that are of interest to the Sokolis if they want to overthrow us. At dinner in my own home, Andreas asked so many suspicious questions that both Damiano and Dad had to tell him to stop.”

I look Andreas dead in the eye. “You’ve been selling Barone secrets to the Sokolis. You saw them as the rising power, and you wanted to be on the winning side. And you thought marrying me would give you access to even more information.”

The church erupts in chaos. Cristiano Montoni rises from his seat, his face dark with fury that I pray is directed at his cousin and not at me. The Sokolis are enemies to all the families, including his.

“She’s lying!” Andreas shouts desperately. “She made all of this up because she wants to fuck her brother! She’s twisted!”

“Gerardo,” I call out. “Will you confirm that Andreas questioned you about security rotations and warehouse schedules at the lingerie boutique?”

A row behind my father, Gerardo stands up, his jaw tight. “I will. He asked about guard schedules, shipment routes, and Sokoli-related security changes. I refused to answer.”

“Dad, Don Cristiano, Don Vincenzo, I prescheduled an email that you should have received by now that contains the photos of Andreas meeting with a Sokoli. I’m telling the truth. I’m not a reluctant bride making up lies. Andreas has been betraying all of you to the Sokolis.”

Damiano reaches inside his jacket and pulls out his gun once more, and he aims it at Andreas. “You hurt my Lucy, and you’re a traitorous piece of shit. Now you’re going to pay.”

The murmurs from the crowd increase to a fever pitch.

Andreas looks around for help, but no one’s coming to save him. Cristiano stands rigid, staring at his cousin with cold contempt. Next to Mom, Dad looks mottled and clammy.

“She’s making it up! I didn’t do anything to that bitch.”

“You’re calling Lucy a liar?” Damiano roars. He dearly wants to shoot Andreas in the head, but he wants a confession even more, and he wants everyone to hear it. He points the gun at Andreas’s upper arm and pulls the trigger.

Andreas cries out in pain. A ragged hole appears in his suit sleeve, and a moment later it’s soaked in blood.

Andreas falls to his knees, staring at the wound. There are shocked cries and gasps all around the church. The priest backs away and makes the sign of the cross.

“Lucy, stop him,” Mom shrieks.

Stop Damiano, when I’ve fantasized about this moment night after sleepless night? I carefully crafted my vows to expose Andreas and my family’s complicity in my rape. I’m tearing us down in the most public way possible. I stand proudly on the altar beside Damiano, who’s wild-eyed and breathing hard, and deciding where to put the next bullet.

“Mom and Dad, you ripped my heart out when you forced me to marry my would-be rapist. You saw what Andreas Montoni tried to do to me with your own eyes. And you were going to hand me over to a traitor. A man selling Barone secrets to the Sokolis. Now everyone knows the kind of people you are.”

This is my revenge.

Mom shoots to her feet and screams in outrage, her beautiful face twisting into something ugly.

She hates me so much.

The feeling is mutual.

Dad’s capos have pulled out their guns, but they’re confused about who they should aim at. Dad hasn’t ordered them to do anything. He’s red in the face and totally motionless.

“I’m asking you again,” Damiano seethes. “Did you put your hands on my sister? Answer me, or you’ll get another bullet.”

Andreas is wailing and gripping his elbow. “My arm. You shot me in the fucking arm.”

Damiano fires again, the report echoing sharply around the cavernous church. This time, he shoots Andreas in the thigh, and he shrieks in pain and collapses onto his heels.

People in the back of the church stand up and crane their necks for a better view.

Andreas’s face twists in hatred as he glares up at Damiano. “Lucy deserves everything she got. That twisted bitch is frigid, and she’s a conniving little spy as well. Don’t you dare touch me. I’m a Montoni. My cousin is going to kill—”

Damiano’s expression darkened the moment he heard, *Lucy deserves everything she got*. He aims between Andreas’s eyes and pulls the trigger.

At point-blank range, Andreas's blood spatters all over Damiano's face, hands, and chest. My bridegroom slumps to the ground, dead. Blood pools around his head and drips slowly from the altar steps.

People scream. Some of them try to get a better look, while others rush for the doors at the back of the church.

Damiano pulls me into his arms. His handsome face is spattered with blood. He kisses me hard—desperate, possessive kisses that devour me.

Four years ago, Damiano pulled away from me in horror when he realized that a roomful of people were watching him kiss me. Today, in front of this congregation, his only purpose is me.

He speaks his vows with more ferocious intent than any groom has at the altar of this church. "No one is ever taking you from me, Lucy. You're mine, now and forever."

Even if we only survive for another few minutes, at least I'll die belonging to the man I love.

Damiano Barone is everything I've ever wanted, and now he's mine.

"I love you," I confess, desperately holding him back.

"I love you, too. I always have." Damiano kisses me one more time, thrilling me down to my toes. "Come on. I'm getting you out of here."

Before I flee with Damiano, I turn to Andreas's corpse. I feel vindictive spark or pleasure as I meet my would-be rapist's dead, staring eyes. I pull the engagement ring off my finger and toss it toward his body. "You can have this back. I never wanted it in the first place."

Damiano seizes my hand, and we dash through the mayhem toward a side exit. I stumble in my heavy, cumbersome dress, so Damiano lifts me up in his arms and carries me out of the church into the sunshine.

He looks around for a moment, and then Antonio appears and holds out a set of keys. "Take my car. Don't get killed."

I seize the keys gratefully from Damiano's soldier and thank him. Damiano swiftly carries me to Antonio's Mercedes and bundles me into the back seat.

As soon as he gets into the driver's seat, he guns the engine, and we shoot off down the street.

My heart is pounding with exhilaration over what we just did, but my tight dress is choking the life out of me.

"Screw this dress." I fight to get it off as we drive, but Mom's horrible choice is tormenting me even now. The corset laces are trying to strangle

me. Finally, I manage to undo the laces and pull the bodice down, and I sit there, semi-free and panting. After taking a moment to recover my strength, I wriggle out of the skirt and kick the whole monstrosity into the corner.

Damiano has been watching my struggles in the rearview mirror, and when he sees me in just my lingerie, he shrugs out of his suit jacket and passes it back to me. I drape it over my shoulders and clamber into the passenger seat beside him.

I push my hair out of my slightly sweaty face, and pant, “Where are we going? Are we going on the lam?”

Damiano’s fingers flex on the wheel, and his eyes narrow. “Why should we run? This is our city, and we haven’t done anything wrong. It felt pretty fucking great to fight for you, my love. Now I have you, I want to keep fighting.”

Trepidation floods my chest. “You want to stay in Malus?”

“I do.”

“We could die.”

“Not if I kill all our enemies first.” He reaches for my hand and holds my palm to his lips, pressing a kiss there. “I was cautious before, and I almost lost you. I won’t hide you away like I’m ashamed of us, and I won’t run and be hunted down like an animal. We stand and *fight*.”

My heart flutters with excitement. Damiano’s strength inspires me, but I’m not ready to throw caution to the wind. “Dad is going to come to his senses and be so angry with us. Cristiano Montoni is probably going to demand revenge.”

“Dad has been publicly shamed for trying to marry his daughter to a rapist. You saw to that, Lucy. I hate that I didn’t know until today what that piece of shit tried to do to you, but I understand why you waited until you were standing at the altar. Cristiano can choose to start a war with the Barones over a traitorous cousin if he wishes, but I don’t think he will, at least not once he’s had the chance to calm down. What you did today was brilliant.”

My heart swells with gratitude and pride. No one but Damiano ever has any words of love and praise for me. I squeeze his hand and whisper, “Thank you for believing me. Thank you for defending me.”

He glances at me while he drives. “Are you crazy? Of course I believed you. Of course I defended you.” He hesitates, and then asks, “I have to know. What did Andreas do to you?”

I hold his hand in my lap and caress his fingers. “It was awful, but he didn’t manage to do much to me. I was scared and panicking, and that was the worst of it, to feel so helpless. Until I remembered some self-defense my kickboxing trainer taught me. Then I managed to fling him off me and run away.”

“All by yourself?” he asks. When I nod, he groans and squeezes my hand. “I’m so sorry that I wasn’t there to kill him on the spot, but I’m so proud of my magnificent Lucy.”

I softly caress his cheek with the back of my hand. “Thank you.”

“I would have decorated the Montoni mansion with his intestines if I’d been given the chance. You do know that, don’t you?”

“I know. I’m sorry I kept the truth from you, but I wanted my revenge served cold. For that, I needed Andreas to believe he’d gotten away with it. I wanted the whole of Malus to know that Mom and Dad were forcing me to marry a man who tried to hurt me and was betraying our family to the Sokolis. I wanted everyone to see that behind their smiles and success and money, they’re monsters.”

Damiano lifts my hand to his lips and kisses my palm. “My beautiful, bloodthirsty woman. How I love you.”

I stroke his cheek again. “I think that’s the most beautiful part. Everyone in Malus knows how much Damiano Barone loves me, and how much I love him.”

He turns his head and smiles at me. “I love you harder than any man has ever loved a woman.”

Pleasure sparkles through my body. Damiano’s ferocious, forbidden love is all I’ve ever craved.

A car pulls out in front of us and cuts us off. I seize his thigh, and cry, “Damiano, look out!”

He slams on the brakes, and at the same time, he reaches across my body and presses me back to my seat. I’ve forgotten to put my seat belt on, and I jerk forward, but I’m kept safe by Damiano. Thank God for his reflexes because, otherwise, my head would have slammed into the dashboard.

Damiano turns to me, his eyes wide and startled that I nearly got hurt. “Shit. *Shit*. Are you okay?”

I start to say that I am, until I see who’s getting out of the car in front. I’m not okay.

Neither of us are okay.

“Damiano. Look.”

The man getting out of the car is Cristiano Montoni. There’s a gun in his hand, and his cold eyes are glittering with fury.

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Damiano

My heart is still pounding in fear that Lucy nearly got hurt, but I follow her gaze. The Montoni don is glowering at us through the windshield with vengeance sparking in his eyes.

I killed his cousin.

Now he's here to kill us both.

Blood for blood.

"Stay here," I tell Lucy as I get out of the car.

But Lucy being Lucy means she doesn't listen to a word I say. As I approach Cristiano, I hear the car door slam behind me and the *click, click* of high heels on asphalt.

Cristiano gives Lucy a contemptuous look as she reaches my side and turns to me. "I don't care about whatever fucked-up thing the two of you have going on, but you just murdered my cousin, Barone. Your sister threw her engagement ring at his corpse. Tell me why I shouldn't kill you both right now."

His gun is still pointed at the ground. For the moment. "You will not hurt Lucy. She's already suffered enough at your cousin's hands. If you want your pound of flesh, you'll take it from me."

Lucy pushes between us and glares up at the Montoni don. "You will take a pound of flesh from no one, Cristiano Montoni. If you were

following what I said in church, you'll know why Damiano did what he did. Were you even listening?"

She has wrapped my jacket tightly around her, but it's obvious that she's wearing nothing but lingerie underneath.

Cristiano presses his lips together and looks from one of us to the other. "I was listening. My cousin tried to rape you, and he was selling Barone secrets to the Sokolis." His voice is flat, emotionless.

The tension is strung tight in the deserted street. Our lives depend on whether he believes Lucy or not.

"If a man had done that to Adora, you would have killed him on the spot," I tell him.

Cristiano says to Lucy, "Adora told me just now that you'd sooner cut out your tongue than lie about what you say Andreas did to you." There's a short, heavy silence. "But she also told me that you lied about being blood-related brother and sister. For years. So how am I supposed to believe you?"

Adora knowing that we're not blood related is news to me. Lucy must have told Adora about us and sworn her to secrecy. While it explains why we're so in love, it does make us seem deceitful, and my mind races, wondering how to play this. "It's none of your concern what Lucy and I are to each other. The question is, do you believe Lucy when she tells you your cousin is an attempted rapist and a traitor? If you don't, then you and I can get down to killing each other, because I won't let you live if you accuse her of lying about such a terrible thing."

The tension between us crackles with barely controlled violence.

Lucy puts a soothing hand on my chest and turns to Cristiano. "Let me explain why I lied about me and Damiano, Don Cristiano. It was for Mom and Dad. The Barones never wanted me when they adopted us from a group foster home. They only wanted a son. If they'd found out that I'm not Damiano's sister, they would have put a bullet in my head and buried me in a shallow grave." She reaches for my hand and grips it tightly. "I've loved Damiano from the first moment I laid eyes on him. It's been killing me all these years to pretend I'm just his sister."

"You were going to marry my cousin while you're in love with another man?" Cristiano asks Lucy.

She gives him a challenging look. "What, like it's never happened before in Malus that a husband and wife don't love each other? Are you going to claim you're desperately in love with my sister?"

Cristiano glances away, his jaw flexing.

But Lucy isn't done talking. "I was going to do my duty to your cousin. I would have been a caring wife, right up until the moment he pushed me forcefully onto my bed, called me disgusting names, and tried to do the worst thing a man can do to a woman. While I was planning my wedding to him, he was meeting with Sokolis. Selling my family's secrets to our enemies. Are you proud to call that kind of man your cousin? A rapist and a traitor? Is it worth shedding more blood over a pathetic man like him?"

The heat is slowly fading from Cristiano's eyes. "You know, I've been wondering how the Sokolis knew to ambush us in that restaurant. I believed it was your fault, but now I'm wondering if it was mine. I told Andreas I was meeting with you, Vincenzo, and Rafiel."

I had no doubt that Andreas ran straight to the Sokolis with that juicy detail.

"I'll make you an offer, Cristiano." I draw my weapon and offer it to him. "If you love your cousin as much as I love Lucy, if you still want revenge for his death, you can put a bullet in me right now. You can even use my gun."

Cristiano gazes at the weapon for a long time. Finally, he does a strange thing. He laughs. A humorless laugh, as if this is all preposterous. "Me? Love Andreas? That weak, pathetic excuse for a Montoni? He brought shame on our family twice over—once as a rapist, and again as a traitor to the Sokolis. You did me a favor, Barone." His coldness sends a shiver down my spine.

Cristiano turns to Lucy, and says courteously, "Miss Barone, I apologize for my cousin's behavior. I hope that your brother...your boyfriend..."

"Her future husband," I tell him.

"I hope that Damiano has given you the vengeance you desire."

"I'm satisfied. You're not going to attack us for killing a member of your family?" she asks warily.

"I have no desire to continue my father's bloodshed," he tells her.

"Then thank you."

He shrugs carelessly. "Don't bother thanking me. You'll probably be killed by your own father. Good luck." He gets back into his car without another word and drives away.

I pull Lucy into my arms and hold her tight. That could have been so much worse.

It still could be.

We haven't faced Dad yet.

Lucy burrows into my arms, and there's a scared note in her voice as she asks, "What are we going to do now? How are we going to deal with Dad?"

I hold Lucy tighter against me. "You and I are going to lay low for a few days, until tempers cool. Then I'm going to do what I should have done weeks ago when this whole ridiculous plan was proposed. I'm going to tell Dad the truth about us and how we met, and why we had to lie to him all these years."

"And if he refuses to understand?"

I press a kiss to the top of her head. "Then I'll deal with it, whatever it takes. I'm not going to let him hurt you, and I'm going to try my damndest not to let him kill me, either. Now, how about we go and enjoy your wedding night?"

I wish I could take Lucy to a luxury hotel, but Dad's men will no doubt start checking those at nightfall. It's too risky to take her to Giovanni's or Antonio's houses either. I end up driving to the outskirts of the city and into one of the less prosperous neighborhoods.

Lucy presses her hand to the window as she gazes out at the passing streets. "I never thought I'd be back here."

"Where?"

She hesitates before saying, "This is not far from the neighborhood where I grew up. You see that convenience store? Mom—my birth mom—abandoned me there one time."

My stomach flips. I grip the wheel, preparing to do a U-turn. "Shit. Sorry, Lucy. I can take us somewhere else."

She turns to me with a smile. "Don't. It feels good coming back here with the man I love. Look at me now, bitches. I'm Lucy goddamn Barone."

I grin and pull over in front of the motel, then turn and cup her face. "Only you would say such a thing. You're so goddamn brave. It's why I love you."

We head inside the dingy motel, and what a picture we must make, me covered in blood, and Lucy wrapped in my suit jacket, her stocking tops peeking out beneath.

"Your bridal suite, please," I tell the receptionist. There's a spider web behind him up on the ceiling, and the pattern has worn off the linoleum

beneath our feet.

The man behind the front desk stares at me, my joke going right over his head. “No bridal suite. Single or double rooms only.”

“Then we’ll take a single room. Can you send champagne up?”

Beside me, Lucy smothers a giggle.

The receptionist gestures over my shoulder at the vending machine. “There’s soda.”

I take the key, feed some money into the machine, and punch the buttons for two cans of soda. We head back outside and along the covered walkway to our room. I’ve put Antonio’s Mercedes out back where it won’t be visible from the street.

We sit on the creaky mattress and toast each other with our sodas.

“To us, and the fact that we’re still breathing. Sorry that there’s no bridal suite.”

Lucy takes a sip of her soda and puts it aside. “I don’t need a bridal suite. I just need you.”

Somehow I manage to put my soda on the nightstand while I’m kissing Lucy. I push my jacket from her shoulders and tug the pins from her hair so that her curls tumble down her back. Now she looks more like the Lucy I know and love.

“Will you wear your hair down when you marry me?”

She smiles. “You haven’t asked me to marry you.”

“So I haven’t.” I slide my hand between her legs and groan when I feel how soaked she is through her thong. “Holy hell, Lucy.”

“I’ve been turned on ever since you killed Andreas,” she pants. “You avenged me. You protected me. Please don’t make me wait.”

I can’t refuse Lucy when she pleads so sweetly. Slowly and gently, I loosen and undo Lucy’s bridal lingerie, kissing her body as I go. I want to wipe away all the pain in Lucy’s heart after what Andreas did to her when he tore at the lace on her body. The tight corset slips from her ribs, and I hold my future wife in my arms as I press kisses to her naked breasts. Next comes the suspender belt and filmy white stockings, and then I finally ease her thong down over her legs.

“So beautiful,” I murmur, pressing kisses to her inner thighs. Lucy has her hands buried in my hair, and she’s gazing at me with love filling her eyes.

Finally, we have everything we want.

I sit up and wrap my hand around my iron-hard cock, lining myself up against her slippery pussy. "Beg for me, my love."

"I've been begging for you all my life."

I grin wickedly down at her. I'm enjoying the tension strung tight between us. I want to know if she's ready for me, and that she really wants this after everything she's been through with Andreas and today's violence.

"Please, *please*," she whispers, dragging her nails down the sparse black hairs and the viper tattoo on my forearm.

Her sweet, breathy voice undoes me, and I push into her. Lucy gasps and clutches my shoulders, and I groan as I feel her tight grip on my shaft. Finally, there's nothing between us.

"You feel like you were made for me," I whisper, moving in and out of her. I let out a deep, slow, "Mmm. That's my girl."

After just a few thrusts, Lucy's already looking hazy-eyed and her cries are growing sharper. "Don't stop. I want you so much. Please don't stop."

Her gaze flickers to the door, and I know she's worried about someone coming in here and interrupting us or killing us.

"Lucy. Look at me," I command. "Only at me."

Lucy turns her face back to mine, and there's anxiety swirling in her eyes.

"The only one who matters is me. You're the only one I'm thinking of. Got it?"

She nods and takes a deep breath, the rigidity in her body and the apprehension in her eyes softening.

I brush my lips over hers, and murmur, "Good girl. You feel my cock? You like that?"

"Yes. Yes."

"I going to make you mine, one stroke at a time."

"Please, Damiano," she cries. "All I want to be is yours."

As she climaxes, I watch with rapt attention at the pleasure flickering over her face. Pushing her knees up to her chest, I fuck her harder and deeper with more purpose. Every stroke reminds me she's mine. Every thrust is pure pleasure. As I come, I'm rewarded with Lucy's second climax, and we ride out the wave together.

My head drops close to hers as we pant, my cock still deep inside her.

"Perfect," I whisper and kiss her.

Slowly withdrawing, I gather her into my arms. Lucy cuddles against my chest and closes her eyes. She must be exhausted after the day she's had, and the engagement she's had. I press a kiss to the top of her head and silently vow to keep her safe while she rests.

As she dozes, I notice my phone lighting up every few minutes on the nightstand, but it's on silent, and I can't see who's calling me. Finally, I reach out and check the screen and see that I have seven missed calls from Mom. As I'm looking at my phone, it rings again.

Lucy lifts her head with a frown. "Who's calling you?"

"It's Mom. I'll ignore her."

Before I can reject the call, Lucy puts her hand on my arm. "If you don't talk to her, she'll just keep getting angrier. Tell her that we'll talk to her face to face as soon as we know it's safe."

This time should just be for me and Lucy, but she does have a point. I answer the call, and I try to cut off Mom's diatribe. "Mom. Before you say anything, I had to kill Andreas. No one hurts Lucy and..."

I trail off as the sound of Mom sobbing hysterically fills my ear. I've rarely seen her shed a tear in ten years, let alone lose all emotional control like this. "Mom, why are you crying over Andreas Montoni? He had it coming after what he did, and I'm furious with you and Dad for keeping it from me."

"This isn't about Andreas," she shrieks, before going back to sobbing. "This is all your fault. Yours and Lucy's. You've killed him."

Lucy

Damiano's face goes on a journey from resigned to angry to shell-shocked. I can't hear Mom, and Damiano gives brief, one-word answers. Finally, he hangs up the call and lifts his eyes to mine, and they're etched with trouble and confusion. "Dad had a heart attack. He's in surgery."

Damiano's words break over me like a freezing cold wave, blasting away all my post-orgasm pleasure and warmth. I sit up, unable to comprehend what I'm hearing. I've been picturing Dad ordering our assassinations, not fighting for his life. He didn't look well in church, and he didn't do or say anything as I denounced him and Mom or when Damiano murdered my fiancé. I put that down to shock. When he walked in on me and Damiano in the bathroom, he clutched his chest and crumpled in on himself. That was a warning he's not as strong as he seems.

There's a storm of guilt and confusion in my heart as I lift my eyes to Damiano. "We did this, didn't we? I did this."

Damiano shoves his phone in his pocket, and says fiercely, "Andreas did this when he hurt you, and they kept it from me. Dad was having warning signs, and he should have gone to his doctor. You are not to blame, my love."

"Are we allowed to see him?"

He presses his lips together in a grim line. “Mom gave me the name of the hospital. I’ll go. Dad’s men might have orders to hurt you.”

“You think it’s better I stay here by myself?” I ask doubtfully.

Damiano glances at the shoddy lock on the door. “You’re right. It’s better if we stay together. I don’t want you out of my sight.”

“I wish I had my gun,” I mutter, reaching for my underwear and pulling it on. “I couldn’t think of a way to holster it under my wedding dress.”

“Where is it now?”

“At home in my closet.”

Damiano nods decisively. “Then we’ll go there, pick it up, and get you some clothes at the same time. Dad’s still in surgery.”

My heart skips a beat. No *don’t worry, Lucy, I’ll protect us both*. No *it’s dangerous for you to be armed*. Just *let’s get your gun*. Simple. Equal.

I wrap my arms around Damiano and kiss him. “Do you know how much I love you?”

He smiles and kisses me back. “I hope it’s a whole fucking lot, because that’s how much I love you.”



WHEN WE ARRIVE at the hospital, me dressed in jeans and a sweater and carrying my gun in my purse, and Damiano wearing fresh black clothes, Dad’s still in surgery. Mom and Ariana are seated in a small, bleak waiting room that’s empty apart from them. The harsh neon light turns Mom’s mascara-streaked face pale and greenish. She and Ariana are still wearing the dresses they put on this morning for the wedding, and our sister’s gown is crumpled.

Mom’s been dabbing at her tears with a tissue, and as soon as she sees us, she gets to her feet and clenches her fist. Completely ignoring me, she says shrilly to Damiano, “I had to deal with this all on my own, Damiano. Where were you?”

All on her own? Ariana is right there.

Damiano explains that we came as soon as we could, while I wonder why it’s just the two of them in this room.

“Cristiano isn’t here with you?” I ask Ariana tentatively, and she shakes her head. “Has he at least called to ask how you are? How Dad is?”

Again she shakes her head.

I know a Barone just killed a Montoni, but that's not Ariana's fault. I thought after Cristiano decided not to kill Damiano, he would have checked in on his bride. Montoni men are the worst.

While I'm feeling sorry for Ariana, Mom's watching me and Damiano through narrowed eyes. She seems particularly interested in what we're wearing.

"I know what you two were doing while your father is fighting for his life," she accuses. "You were screwing, weren't you? You both make me sick."

I fight to keep my chin raised, even though a little voice is saying in the back of my mind that all this is my fault. I should have realized Dad isn't as strong as he seems, and I shouldn't have put him through public humiliation today.

"At least Lucy has the decency to look ashamed of herself."

I take Damiano's hand and squeeze it. "I'm not ashamed of loving Damiano. I just wish Dad was all right. I never wanted any of us to get hurt."

"You have lost the right to address him as your father after what you've done, you little whore."

"Don't you dare call Lucy names," Damiano seethes.

"Mom, stop it," Ariana says in a small voice, gazing down into her lap at her clenched hands.

But Mom isn't anywhere near done. It's plain that she's been dying for us to get here just so she could lose it at us. "Carlucci and I invited two demon children into our family. I wish I could turn back the clock. I'd leave you both in that shabby little foster home."

"Mom, *stop*," Ariana exclaims louder, both hands clenched on her bridesmaid dress. She stares up at Mom with pain and confusion in her eyes. "Dad's heart condition is not their fault. What was Damiano supposed to do today? Andreas tried to rape Lucy. Of course he had to kill him. Dad should have been right by his side."

I'm surprised to hear my sister defending us.

Mom gives an angry, dismissive shake of her head. "It was all a silly mistake. Lucy is so dramatic. She tells lies. She shouldn't have been parading around her bedroom in her bridal lingerie."

Tears well up in Ariana's eyes as she realizes the truth. "You knew about what Andreas tried to do to Lucy, didn't you? And you and Dad still wanted her to marry him? If Cristiano tries to rape me, will you still insist I marry him?"

"Don Cristiano would never do that to a good girl like you."

Ariana stares at Mom in total disbelief. "Sure, because Cristiano loves me so much. You're marrying me to a complete stranger just because he's the most powerful man in Malus, apart from Dad. You don't know the first thing about him, and you didn't know the first thing about Andreas either. When you found out, you did nothing to protect Lucy. I thought the Barones were all about family, but we're not." She puts the back of her hand to her face as she struggles not to sob.

Ariana is scared, I realize.

Absolutely terrified of the man she has to marry. My heart goes out to her, and I wish that she and I had found some common ground over the years. I think I'm starting to like my older sister, and I wish there was some way I could save her from marrying Don Cristiano.

Ariana glances between me and Damiano. "I think you're both messed up, but at least you have someone who loves you and will protect you no matter what."

I take a deep breath, and let it out slowly, coming to a decision. "Ariana, Damiano and I aren't related. We met when I was ten, and his father and sister were killed. I'm sorry we lied to you."

Damiano looks at me sharply, but what's the point in hiding it anymore?

Mom's head snaps up. Ariana stares at me wide-eyed, and then my sister starts to laugh. Shaky, near-hysterical laughter. Tears fill her eyes and spill down her cheeks. "So you're free to marry the man you love, and he loves you back? Great. That's just great. I thought we were all going to suffer together, but it's just me who's going to be miserable and trapped for the rest of my life."

Mom rushes toward me with a scream and raises her hand. Before she can strike me, Damiano seizes her shoulders and holds her back.

"Mom, don't you dare lay a finger on her."

"You lying little bitch," Mom screams at me, her face turning from red to purple, and a vein bulges in her forehead. She struggles against Damiano to get to me. "You heinous, spiteful little cow. You're not related to him? We never needed to adopt you? You disgusting little *parasite*."

Her words are daggers that are meant to wound me. As I look at Mom, turned ugly by her rage, I'm relieved I don't have to pretend to love her anymore.

I wait for her to draw a breath between screams, and tell her, "Since I was ten years old, I've been haunted by the knowledge that I'm the unwanted Barone, and I was terrified that someone would find out my secret. I'm glad you don't think I'm part of your family. You can go to hell."

Mom reels back, as if it's preposterous that anyone wouldn't clamor to be a Barone. "How dare you? You have ruined our lives. When your father is back on his feet, he is going to...going to..."

Mom falters and falls silent as a man dressed in surgical scrubs comes into the room wearing a somber expression.

Mom hurries over to him. "My husband?"

The surgeon's expression is sympathetic as he looks at her, though he probably heard our screaming from the other side of the hospital. "He's alive, but barely. He's asking for Damiano. You only have a few minutes."

Damiano

The surgeon looks at me, his expression grave. “I warn you, he’s very weak.”

I wasn’t expecting this. I thought Dad would refuse to see me, and that his last act would be to curse me for what I’ve done. Lucy squeezes my hand once, and I see the worry in her eyes.

I follow the surgeon down the sterile corridor, our footsteps echoing off the linoleum. He stops at a door, pushes it open, and gestures me inside.

“Five minutes,” he repeats quietly.

The ICU is cold and filled with the rhythmic beeping of machines. Tubes and wires run from my father’s body to various monitors. An oxygen mask covers his nose and mouth, fogging with each labored breath.

I approach the bed slowly. His eyes are closed, his skin ashen. This is the man who ruled my life and Malus with an iron fist. He commanded respect and fear from every family in the city. Now he can barely breathe.

His eyelids flutter open, and his formerly sharp, calculating eyes struggle to focus as they fix on me. He reaches up with a trembling hand and pulls the oxygen mask down slightly. His voice is a rasp, barely audible over the machines.

“Damiano.”

I stand at his bedside, my hands clenched at my sides. “I’m here.”

He studies my face for a long moment. The silence stretches between us, filled only by the beeping monitors and his labored breathing. My stomach clenches as I anticipate what's coming.

"You and Lucy." Each word is an effort. "You're not blood siblings, are you?"

"No. We're not related. We met the day my father and sister died in the meth lab explosion. I lied to you for ten years so I could protect her and keep her with me."

I wait for the final curse of a dying man, but Dad just closes his eyes and takes several ragged breaths.

"I should have seen it," he finally says. "All these years. The way you looked at her. The way you protected her."

"You're not angry?"

He makes a sound that might be a laugh. "Angry? I'm dying. I don't have time for anger." He pauses, struggling for air. "Lucy kept her suspicions about Andreas to herself, and lying here, I have been wondering what I would have done if she came to me with them."

"You wouldn't have believed her," I say bitterly.

"No, I wouldn't have." He coughs again. "The girl. I never wanted her. Never trusted her. But she saved this family. She's smarter than I gave her credit for. Smarter than half my capos."

Hearing him finally acknowledge Lucy and what she's capable of makes my body unclench.

"She's everything," I tell him.

"The way you killed for her today. That's not a brother's love. That's the love of a man for his woman."

"I have loved her for a long time."

Dad closes his eyes. "I chose power. I married your mother for an alliance. We have always respected and honored each other. But you chose love, and I thought that made you weak. Today I watched you stand in that church with a gun in your hand, ready to die for her. That's not weakness."

"Lucy only makes me stronger," I say fiercely.

"Listen to me." His hand reaches out, grabs my wrist with surprising strength. "The Sokolis won't forgive this. Lucy exposed their spy and humiliated them. They'll want revenge."

"I'll protect her."

“You’re the don now,” he rasps. “The family will be yours. The business. The territory. All of it.”

The weight of those words settles on my shoulders.

“No one’s ever ready for this, but don’t make my mistakes, Damiano.” He looks at me with something that might be regret. “I never knew you. Never really saw you. The girl loves you. Don’t waste that.” His breathing is becoming more labored, the beeps on the monitor speeding up then slowing down. “Protect the family. Your mother and sister. Lucy. Promise me.”

“I promise.”

His hand releases my wrist and falls to the bed. His eyes are starting to close. The monitor’s beeping grows erratic. I should call for the surgeon. I should do something.

Dad speaks so quietly that I have to lean close to hear him. “You were a good son,” he whispers. “Better than I deserved.”

The monitor flatlines. The long, steady beep fills the room.

I stand there, staring at the body of the man who taught me to lead. The man who never showed me love.

He’s gone.

And I’m the don now.

I step back as the nurses and a doctor rush in. I stand at Dad’s bedside for another moment, looking at his face. In death, he looks peaceful.

I then turn and walk out of the ICU.

Lucy is waiting in the hallway, her face pale with worry. As soon as she sees me, she knows.

“He’s gone,” I tell her.

She wraps her arms around me, and I hold her tight. Over her shoulder, I can see Mom and Ariana in the waiting room. I have to tell them and face what comes next.

I take Lucy’s hand and walk into the waiting room. Mom looks up at me, her face streaked with tears. She already knows. She can see it in my face.

“No,” she whispers. “Please, no.”

“He’s gone, Mom. I’m sorry.”

She lets out a long, anguished wail and slumps to her knees. Ariana, fresh tears spilling down her cheeks, gets up and goes to Mom. She can’t

make her get up off the floor, so Ariana stays down there holding her, rocking her mother back and forth.

“Twenty-seven years,” Mom sobs. “Twenty-seven years, and he’s gone. I have nothing.”

Ariana strokes her hair gently. “Mom, you still have us.”

“*Nothing*,” Mom repeats, her voice cracking with raw pain. “I gave him everything. My youth. My freedom. My whole life. It can’t just end like this.”

The bitterness in her voice is laced with grief, not just for Dad, but for the life she gave up. I understand suddenly why she hates Lucy so much. They’re so much alike, strong and smart, but Lucy refuses the duty and obedience that Mom chose to embrace.

Mom catches me watching. Her tear-streaked face hardens, and her vulnerability vanishes behind cold rage. Her glare shifts to Lucy. “This is your fault. If you’d been a proper daughter and married Andreas without all this drama, Carlucci would still be alive. You killed him. And I will never forgive you. Never.”

She clutches Ariana and sobs.

Lucy turns away and buries her face in my shoulder.

There should probably be tears somewhere inside me for the man I’ve called my father for so many years. But I just feel hollow and heavy. I can feel the weight of leadership settling on my shoulders.

Lucy and I hold each other in silence, intruders upon our own family’s grief.

Lucy

A cold wind slices through my black coat as Damiano and I stand hand in hand before the open grave. Dad's casket is being lowered into the earth while the same priest who performed my abandoned wedding ceremony drones on somberly.

Across the grave from me and Damiano, Mom is statuesque in a black blazer and narrow dress, with a black hat atop her sleek hair. She dabs a tissue at the corner of her eye, clutched in a gloved hand. Ariana is by her side, and our extended family is clustered around them both. Various aunts and cousins glare balefully at us. Mom made it clear that Damiano and I are not welcome on that side of the grave with them. She's been telling everyone that Dad's death is all our fault, and since they all witnessed Andreas's murder and me kissing my "brother," they have no reason not to believe her.

I don't know if Dad ever saw a doctor about his heart problems, or if he was afraid of a diagnosis. Don Carlucci Barone shunned any hint of weakness and imperfection.

Whether he did or not, it's too late now. All that's left to do is decide who is going to lead the family now. I've noticed several of Dad's capos sizing each other up, as though they're wondering how soon is too soon to make a play for power. Damiano is watching them all closely with a hard

expression in his eyes. They're scheming for something that belongs to him. I wonder if more blood will be spilled.

We each toss a handful of dirt onto Dad's casket, and I feel hollow as we turn and walk away from the grave. I don't want or need to shed a tear for the man who ignored me for most of my life, and who was happy to marry me off to a man like Andreas Montoni.

There's a wake at Dad's favorite restaurant, but an invitation wasn't extended to us. Damiano and I decide not to impose our presence.

I stand at the open car door and watch as the gathering at the graveside slowly breaks up. "Dad's will is being read tomorrow. If by some strange twist of fate we're left with nothing..." I trail off.

Damiano takes my chin in his hand and raises it gently. "If we're left with nothing, we'll still have each other, and we will build a new life together."

He says the words easily, and there's no worry behind them.

"You don't think you'll be disinherited?" I ask, and he shakes his head. I suppose it is unlikely that Dad would have changed his will when he caught Damiano and me together in the bathroom, because he seemed to place all the blame for that incident on me. "In that case, Mom, Ariana, and I will be left with almost nothing, while the house and all the money are bequeathed to you."

"I will never begrudge you anything," Damiano reminds me. "You or Ariana. She can break off her engagement to Don Cristiano if she wishes, and you can go to college, or start a business, or learn three languages. Your life is yours." He dips his head closer to me, and his lips are very close. "As long as you're still mine."

I play with his tie and gaze up at him through my lashes. "You know what I really want."

His smile widens. "Yes, I do."

"Will you give it to me?"

"If everything goes as planned tomorrow, I'll give you the whole fucking world."

As we walk to Damiano's car, his two closest soldiers join us. Antonio's arm seems to have healed well. He's probably wearing a bandage beneath his suit, but his arm and fingers are mobile.

"Are you two waiting to see what happens tomorrow before you abandon me?" Damiano asks, his voice light.

“We’ll never abandon you, Damiano,” Antonio tells him.

“And if I have to fight for what’s mine, or someone starts a war to overthrow me?”

Giovanni’s expression is deadly serious. “Then we’ll fight with you and do what we can to convince our fathers to join the winning side. They respect loyalty to blood, and you are Don Carlucci’s blood.”

“I respect your loyalty to me and Lucy. It won’t be forgotten.”

“And the Sokolis?” I ask quietly. “Have there been any...repercussions from the wedding?”

Antonio and Giovanni exchange glances.

Giovanni’s expression darkens. “They’ve gone quiet. Too quiet. We’ve had our ears to the ground, but there’s been no retaliation. Nothing.”

“That’s what worries me,” Antonio adds. “After what Lucy exposed, they should be screaming for blood.”

Damiano’s hand tightens on mine. “They’re planning something.”

“Probably,” Giovanni agrees. “Gerardo has men watching the Sokoli territories. If they make a move, we’ll know.”

“We’ll deal with them when we need to,” Damiano says firmly, squeezing my hand. “For now, let’s focus on securing what’s ours.”

Antonio glances curiously at the man I once called my brother. “There’s a rumor going around that you two are not actually related. It’s true, isn’t it?”

Damiano smiles at Antonio, saying nothing.

“It has to be true,” Giovanni says. “What I don’t understand is why you’re not confirming it one way or another, Damiano.”

“It’s simple. Lucy and I don’t owe anything to anyone.”

Antonio gives him a shrewd look. “It probably doesn’t hurt our enemies to believe that Damiano Barone is borderline crazy, and your mom sure looks pissed off about the whole situation.”

He lets Antonio and Giovanni speculate about this, until Giovanni changes the subject by saying, “I heard a rumor that the Lucania don might be having a family reunion.”

Damiano turns to him in surprise. “What do you mean?”

“Rafiel is being sent to prison,” Antonio replies.

“You’re kidding,” I exclaim. “Both Rafiel and Gabriel in prison. The Lucanias can’t catch a break.”

Damiano gazes across the graveyard, lost in thought. “I’m sorry for Rafiel. I’ll reach out to him to see if there’s anything I can do.”



THE FOLLOWING MORNING, we sit in Dad’s lawyer’s office beside Mom and Ariana for the reading of the will, though their chairs are discreetly drawn apart from ours. We’re all dressed in mourning black, and a somber mood hangs in the air. Mom’s hands are clenched in her lap, and her knuckles are white. She refuses to look at us, let alone speak to us.

As the lawyer reads the will, her hands start to tremble.

Everything goes to Damiano.

Everything.

The house. The money. The various properties. The investments. Damiano is the head of the Barones, both the domestic family and by implication the crime family. He has all the assets and authority necessary to wield power in Malus, though whether Don Carlucci’s capos will be loyal to his son or start a turf war remains to be seen.

Despite being a loyal wife to Don Carlucci for decades and raising his children, all Mom’s left to show for it is a handful of jewelry that he gave her over the years and some personal effects. There are provisions for her, and for his daughters, but they pale in comparison to the riches that have been heaped upon Damiano.

Mom is given an allowance, and she’s permitted to reside in the family home, which is now Damiano’s home, until her death. Ariana and I are provided with an allowance until we’re married, but it’s cut off as soon as we turn twenty-five. I suppose if we were still unmarried at twenty-five, Dad believed it would be an incentive for us to accept the next eligible man out of sheer desperation.

Mom kept a pretty smile on her face, her mouth shut, and her eyes turned away from Dad’s business dealings for all those years, for the sake of a few scraps at the end. If I were her, I’d be furious.

Mom turns narrowed, sparking eyes on Damiano.

She *is* furious.

But not with Dad.

“Mr. Rosso. Leave us for a moment.”

The man gets up out of his chair and leaves quickly, no doubt grateful to close the door behind him on the tension in this room.

“Congratulations,” Mom seethes when we’re alone, spittle flying from her lips. “You got away with it, both of you. If he’d lived just one more day, you would be disinherited, or better yet, dead.”

I think of Dad’s final words to Damiano in the ICU. How he acknowledged that I’d saved the family. How he told Damiano to protect me. How he gave his blessing, in his own way.

Mom has no idea. She thinks Dad died hating us.

Damiano gazes calmly at Mom, his long legs crossed, and his arm draped possessively across the back of my chair. “I won’t challenge your right to live in my house, but you will treat Lucy with respect. She’s the lady of the Barone estate now.”

Mom grips the arms of her chair. “How dare you, Damiano. *I’m* the lady of the Barone estate, and I always will be.” She takes several short, angry breaths. “This is what’s going to happen. At Ariana’s engagement dinner, in front of all the prominent people in Malus, you are going to give a brief speech and tell everyone that you and Lucy are not related. Then you may announce your engagement, if you must. Lucy will not attend Ariana’s wedding. Damiano, you will give your sister away to Cristiano. The two of you may marry in a discreet, private ceremony much later in the year.” Mom pauses for a furious moment, and continues icily. “I need not point out that if your father were still alive and the head of this family, you would be facing deadly consequences for what you have done to this family. You had better be grateful for my concessions to your disgusting behavior. You may not be brother and sister by blood, but you have lived as brother and sister for half your lives.”

Damiano is lounging in his chair, perfectly at ease. He replies with a single word. “No.”

Mom’s face goes from pale to red. “What did you say to me?”

“I said no. Lucy and I will announce our relationship when and how we choose. Lucy will attend Ariana’s wedding if they both wish it, and we will marry when we’re ready, in whatever ceremony we want.” He leans forward slightly. “You seem to have forgotten something, Mom. This is my house now. My money. My family. You live in that mansion at my pleasure. If you won’t treat Lucy with respect, you can get out.”

Mom’s mouth opens and closes, speechless with rage.

“Furthermore,” Damiano continues, his voice deadly calm, “I know what Andreas tried to do to Lucy. I know you and Dad saw it and did nothing. You told her to apologize to him. You were going to hand her over to a rapist and a traitor.” His eyes are cold. “So before you lecture us about disgrace and family honor, remember that Lucy saved this family. She’s smarter and braver than you ever gave her credit for.”

Mom looks like she’s been slapped. “How *dare* you—”

Ariana’s exasperated voice cuts across her. “Mom, it’s too late. Can’t you see that the angrier you get, the more they enjoy it? Leave them be, for heaven’s sake.”

Mom grasps her handbag and heads for the door, her face lined from anger and grief. The beautiful mother I’ve known for so much of my life is becoming a bitter and vindictive old woman. “Ariana, come. We’ve fallen far behind on planning your wedding.” She opens the door to the office and strides out of the room.

Our sister wears a resigned expression as she gets to her feet.

Overcome with curiosity, I call after her, “Ariana, why are you still going ahead with this marriage when you don’t have to?”

Ariana pauses by the door. “Who says I don’t have to?”

“I’ll say it if you like,” Damiano tells her. “You don’t have to marry Don Cristiano.”

“Wow, thanks, Damiano. You’ve fixed everything,” she says flatly. “Neither of you have any idea what’s been happening outside your own drama, do you? You didn’t notice who wasn’t at Lucy’s wedding. You didn’t spot who was missing from Dad’s funeral.”

Damiano and I exchange glances, but neither of us have any idea what she’s talking about. Both events had several hundred guests, so I’m not sure I could pick out if a particular one was missing, unless it was immediate family. “Who was missing?”

But Ariana shakes her head. “It’s too late for me. Dad saw to that before he died. He had enough time to ruin my life or change his will, but not both, I guess. I hope you’re both happy though.”

I hear genuine good wishes in her voice, as well as bitterness. She turns and walks out of the room.

“Who is she talking about?” Damiano asks.

I think for a moment. “I remember at the bridal shop, she said something about having her own life. A secret life. She was angry that I’d

taken away her time before she had to marry.” I frown, trying to remember her exact words. “She said keeping the peace was a full-time job, and when Mom and Dad were angry, they watched her more closely. She wanted a few more years to herself before doing her duty.”

“So there is someone she cares about.”

“Someone Dad found out about,” I add. “And did something about before he died.”

We sit in silence for a moment, both of us feeling guilty. We were so wrapped up in our own drama that we didn’t see what Ariana was going through.

“I wish there was something we could do,” I say quietly.

“We can’t do anything if she won’t confide in us,” Damiano points out, and then calls Mr. Rosso back.

When Mr. Rosso is once more seated behind his desk, Damiano reaches for my hand and holds it. “Do you have a moment to speak with us, Mr. Rosso?”

The lawyer looks surprised that his wealthiest and most important client is bothering to request such a thing. “Of course, Mr. Barone. I have as much time as you need. Please tell me how I may be of service.”

Damiano caresses my knuckles, looking darkly dangerous all dressed in black, and gazing at the man from beneath his brows. “I want you to reverse Lucy’s adoption into the Barone family, or emancipate her, or do whatever legal hoop-jumping is necessary.”

“Necessary for what, sir?”

Damiano raises his eyebrows. “For me to marry Lucy, of course.”

The lawyer opens and closes his mouth several times, but before he can speak, Damiano says, “I’m not finished. I want Lucy’s name to be added to the deed for the family home. I want my bank account to be held jointly by Lucy.”

I look sharply at Damiano. I’ve told him many times that I wish to be his equal, but all I meant was that I didn’t want him to treat me like a silly, scared girl or a smiling idiot who had to wait at home while he got to be the great Don Damiano. I never imagined he’d give half of everything he owns to me.

The lawyer frowns. “I’m sorry, Mr. Barone. I don’t understand.”

“What is it you don’t understand? It’s typical for a married couple to combine and share their assets.”

“But Don Carlucci never...” He trails off as Damiano’s eyes flash in warning. “Yes, sir. Of course, sir. I will make those arrangements for you, but the matter of marrying your sister, I’m afraid that this is impossible. My hands are tied by the letter of the law.”

“Lucy is not my sister.”

Mr. Rosso looks back and forth between us, clearly trying to find a tactful way of telling Don Damiano that just because he wishes something, doesn’t make it true.

“I’m truly not Damiano’s sister, Mr. Rosso,” I say, and explain about meeting Damiano the day his father and sister were killed, and that my name before I was adopted was Lucy Cinders.

Mr. Rosso straightens his glasses. “I see. In that case, Miss Cinders, I’ll need to locate your original birth certificate.”

Damiano’s jaw flexes. “Lucy is a Barone. Address her as such.”

“Of course, Mr. Barone. Perhaps I may also draft a prenuptial agreement?” he asks hopefully.

Damiano’s face grows stormy with anger. “No, you may not, and don’t you dare insult my future wife ever again. Now, get out. I want a private moment with Lucy.”

The lawyer scurries out of the room as though it’s not his office but Damiano’s.

I picture pulling into the driveway of the Barone family home, and for the first time in my life, the facade no longer seems cold, forbidding, and unwelcoming. It will no longer be a house that I can be shamefully cast out of if my secret comes out. It will be my home. Mine and Damiano’s.

“We can eat pizza for dinner in front of the TV on a Saturday night,” I whisper.

Damiano smiles. “What did you say, my love?”

I turn to Damiano and seize his hands. “We can wear jeans to dinner. Sit on the kitchen counters. Dance to loud music in the living room. No one’s going to tell us what to do anymore.”

It feels like an enormous weight has been lifted off my shoulders.

Damiano lifts my hand to his lips and kisses it. “I want you to be my equal from now on. You will never have to ask me for money, and I will never keep you in the dark or force you into ignorance.”

“Partners,” I say softly. “In everything.”

“In everything,” he agrees.

I pretend to think about this for a moment. “That sounds wonderful. But you’re still forgetting something.”

His brows draw together in consternation. “What is it? Tell me and it’s yours.”

“You still haven’t asked me to marry you.”

Damiano’s face relaxes into a smile. “That’s true, I haven’t.” He studies me for a moment. “I suppose you’ll have to become Lucy Cinders for a while, but I’ll be impatient to give you back my name. Our name. Will you...”

“Will I what?” I prompt impatiently, my heart doing a joyful skip.

This is it.

This is the moment I’ve been waiting so long for.

The man I love is finally going to ask me to marry him.

Damiano takes my chin in his thumb and forefinger, and murmurs, “Lucy. My love. Will you plot and scheme with me forever?”

I burst out laughing.

“I’m serious, Lucy. Will you be my better half? The brains and the beauty. The heart and the soul of us. Plot and scheme with me. Love me. Marry me.”

I rub the tip of my nose against his, remembering how handsome he was the first day I saw him. How I couldn’t help but crave to be his even then. “From the first moment I laid eyes on you, Damiano, I saw only you. Loved only you. But you’ve got one thing wrong.”

“What’s that, my love?”

“I’m the brains. You’re the beauty.”

He kisses me, his warm lips moving over mine. “I doubt that, my love. You are most certainly the brains, but I happen to think you’re the beauty as well. I’m impatient to tell the whole world that you’re mine, so let’s go buy you the most beautiful engagement ring in all of Malus. One that you choose.”

I think of the bland, careless ring Andreas gave me. The one I threw at his corpse. This time, I’ll choose my own ring. With the man I love.

“The perfect ring for me,” I agree, smiling. “I’ll be so proud to wear it.”

EPILOGUE

Damiano

I stride into the warehouse with Lucy's hand in mine, and a wickedly sharp axe resting on my shoulder. All Dad's capos are assembled and waiting to be addressed by the new don. From today, they'll be my capos, assuming none of them walk out of here, or end up in pieces on the floor.

My bride-to-be looks stunning in a sumptuous wine-red dress, with a vintage diamond necklace around her throat. On her ring finger is a beautiful, ornate diamond engagement ring. Lucy chose the ring herself, and I put it onto her finger and sealed our engagement with a kiss. Now she's mine forever.

In the middle of the concrete floor is Dad's desk, the one that he once sat behind in his office in this very warehouse. I walk over and stare at it for a long time, then lift my eyes to the capos.

"I always hated this desk. When Don Carlucci sat behind it, it made me feel like a schoolboy being told off in the principal's office. Fuck that feeling."

I take the axe from my shoulder, raise it over my head in both hands, and bring the blade down in the middle of the desk. The wood splits but doesn't break. I raise the axe and bring it down again, and then again. On

the third hit, the desk breaks in two. On the seventh, there's nothing but splinters of what was once an identifiable piece of furniture.

Some of the capos look confused. Others seem bordering on outrage.

"We're not schoolboys," I tell them. "We're men, and we should feel like men. Come with me."

I take Lucy by the hand and lead our men to the office that now belongs to us. The room is now dominated by a table where we can all sit together. Discuss. Plan. The table is round so that we may all see each other, though one of the chairs is taller and more ornate than the others.

The don's chair.

My chair.

"This is where we'll conduct family business. I will listen to you. I will respect you. In return, I ask for your loyalty and respect." I gaze around thoughtfully. "But something's missing. Antonio, Giovanni," I call out, and a moment later they enter, carrying a second tall, ornate chair between them, and place it next to its twin.

Two dons' chairs.

One for the king and one for the queen.

I walk around the table and place my hand on the back of the second chair. "Does anyone have any objection to Lucy joining my side? If you do, leave now, and there will be no repercussions this day. But after today, I make no such promise. I will not tolerate any man disrespecting or undermining my bride. She will be by my side forever, not because I bestow power upon her, but because she has earned it. Any man who questions her place questions me."

I place the axe on the table, and the sharpened blade glints in the light.

No one moves. No one speaks.

"Then let's sit down."

Lucy and I take our seats side by side, and I feel proud as I watch my queen settle into her throne with a proud tilt to her lips. The rest of the capos take their seats, with Antonio and Giovanni on my other side. Gerardo is among them, the bodyguard who refused to answer Andreas's questions about security. He meets my eyes and gives a single nod of respect.

Now, I want Lucy to speak. I turn to my fiancée. "What are your ideas for our future, my love?"

Lucy takes a long look around at each of our men, holding their gazes. Unflinching in the face of their bold, doubting stares. “Malus is unstable and dangerous, and we need stronger ties with our allies so that all of us can survive. At the moment, there is little trust between the Vicis, the Montonis, the Lucanias, and the Barones. I want to leverage their most powerful and criminally underused asset: their women. I have a plan, and the daughters, wives, and mothers of these families are key to bringing us all closer together, and it will make all our women safer. Your women. Your daughters. Your sisters. Your mothers.”

Lucy lets these words rest on the air, and the capos glance at each other. I can tell they like the idea of their women being safer.

“On a more personal level,” Lucy continues, “I’ll be taking over the family jewel business and hand selecting a few of you to work closely by my side. I plan on making this a highly lucrative business, and the bonuses for my men will be significant.”

Several of the men, especially those who were there the evening that Lucy sold fine jewelry to the richest men in Malus, perk up. A proud smile steals over my face. With just a few words that appeal to their love for their women and their wallets, Lucy has Dad’s capos—our capos—in the palm of her hand. Together, Lucy and I are going to be unstoppable.

I lean back in my chair, holding on to my bride’s hand, my ambition for the two of us blazing like crowns upon our heads. We are the Barones, and no one is going to stand in our way.

“Then let’s begin.”

Thank you for reading *Forbidden Vow*. If you enjoyed this book, please take a moment to leave a review on Amazon and Goodreads.

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***He's waited five years to come home to her. She's spent five years praying
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Cristiano Montoni would crawl over broken glass for one touch, one kiss, one sweet word from me. He has the face of an avenging angel and a body to die for. Powerful. Rich. Dangerous. Deadly.

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Five years ago, Cristiano worked his dark magic on me and ruined my life. Five years ago, I fell pregnant with his child. Then he vanished—and I was free.

I gave myself to a man I knew was twisted and terrifying. As the housekeeper's daughter, I witnessed Cristiano's brutal punishments at the hands of his father. I tried to put the pieces back together, but Agnello Montoni broke his son. Shattered his heart. Warped his mind.

Now I'm terrified that Cristiano will do the same to his son.

My son.

Our child.

I'll protect Leon with my life. Cristiano can never know the child is his, or my son will be dragged into a violent underworld from which there's no escape.

But Cristiano won't stay away from me. Five years have passed, and he hasn't changed. He's still a monster. And I've never stopped wanting him.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Lilith Vincent is a steamy romance author who believes in living on the wild side! Whether it's reverse harem or M/F romance, mafia men and bad boys with tattoos are her weakness, and the heroines who bring them to their knees.

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